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FM Sitharaman said she will be 'keenly hearing' the debate on stock investment, taxes, LTCG and STT, a remark that fired up a lacklustre market. ▶ FRONT FLAP

▶ India Believes in the Power to Empower, says PM ▶ Blackstone Plans $100b Investment in India in 5 Years ▶ MDR Levy Deferred till After Diwali: P 1

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BENGALURU

AI Runs into Rough Weather, Sun Shines Bright for Indian IT Stocks

SEBI EXTENDS IPO SIZING FLEXIBILITY TILL MARCH NEXT YEAR ▸▸ PAGE 9

'NO WORRIES IN FISCAL DISCIPLINE, INVESTMENTS'

FM Ready to Hear Out Stock Market Tax Debate...

Sitharaman says focus is on healthy economic fundamentals, curbing Re volatility & not 'fixing' it

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday said she will be "keenly hearing" the ongoing debate on stock investment taxes, long-term capital gains (LTCG) and securities transaction tax (STT), fuelling speculations about possible changes that fired up an otherwise lacklustre market late afternoon.

Sitharaman, however, declined to share any specifics, citing preparations for the Union Budget due in February. "We are very close to the budget... It may not be the best time for me to say what I will or will not consider," she said at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum.

The finance minister also said the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is trying to prevent rupee volatility through its measures and not "fix" a rupee level.

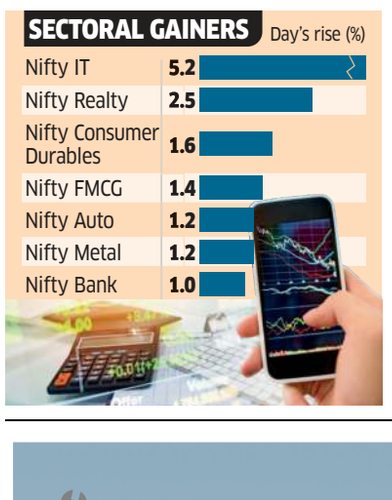
She added that fiscal discipline was not going to be a matter that should worry investors.

Sitharaman said the government is trying to keep economic fundamentals strong. Sectors such as renewable energy, semiconductors and chip design, biosimilars, pharmaceuticals, generic drug manufacturing and aircraft maintenance, repair and overhaul centres are drawing both domestic and foreign private capital, she added.

External Challenges, Uncertainties ▸▸ 7

SHORT-COVERING IN HOPE OF SOME GOOD NEWS LEADS TO 1.6% RISE

...Remarks Turn Street Lights Green



Indices mark highest single-session jump in two months

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equities surged 1.6% on Tuesday, their biggest single-day gain in more than two months, as finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman's remarks on stock market transaction taxes raised hopes of a possible review, triggering short-covering. A rally in IT stocks amid a selloff in AI-related shares in South Korea and Taiwan added to the gains. The Nifty 50 rose 1.6% to close at 22,722, while the Sensex advanced 1.54% to 73,034. The rally came amid continued concerns over elevated crude oil prices, foreign investor selling and the conflict in West Asia.

Sitharaman acknowledged the debate over the securities transaction tax (STT) but stopped short of indicating any proposed change. "It's healthy to have this debate, and I will be keenly hearing them," she said. India's taxes on stock market transactions have drawn criticism for being excessive and higher than those in many other markets.

"The rally was (led by) expiry-related short covering," said Sunny Agrawal, head of fundamental research, SBI Capital Securities.

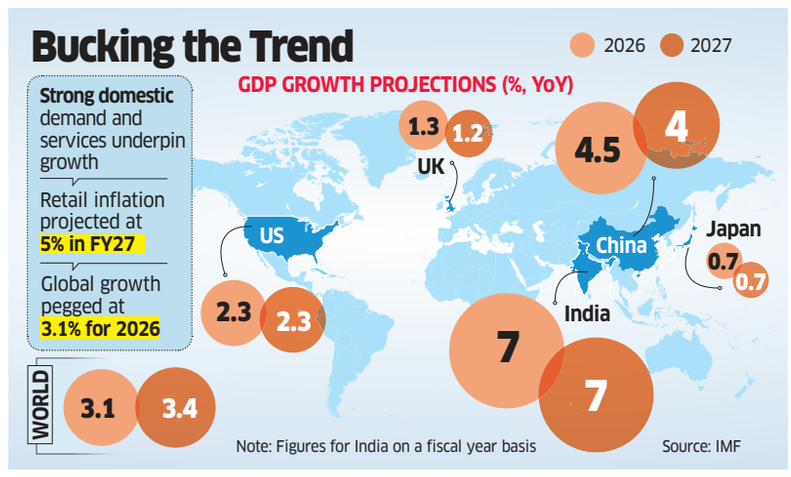
Kospi Slumps 5.5% ▸▸ 7

BOOMING LOCAL MKT, STRUCTURAL REFORMS BOOST ECONOMIC MOMENTUM

IMF Raises India's FY27 and FY28 Growth Forecast to 7%

Says trade pacts with UK, EU may boost economy by removing trade barriers, easing policy shifts and strengthening supply chain

Our Bureau



New Delhi: The International Monetary Fund (IMF) raised India's economic growth forecast for FY27 to 7%, up from its earlier estimate of 6.4% in July on the back of domestic demand and strong services activity as higher energy prices linked to the West Asia conflict clouds the global economic outlook.

India remains among the fastest-growing major economies globally, according to the forecast. In its latest World Economic Outlook (WEO), the IMF also upgraded India's FY28 growth projection to 7% compared with the previous estimate of 6.7%.

In its medium-term outlook, IMF said India stands out against a broader trend of downward revisions for economies directly affected by the conflict in the Gulf, as well as energy-importing emerging markets and developing economies elsewhere. It said India's sustained economic momentum and stronger growth potential are supported by favourable demographic trends, a large and expanding domestic market, and continued structural reforms.

India's gross domestic product (GDP) growth stood at 7.8% in FY26.

The revision follows similar upgrades by other major institutions. Last week, the World Bank raised its FY27 growth forecast for India to 7.1% from 6.6%, supported by robust domestic demand and strong exports despite global headwinds.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) increased its FY27 GDP growth projection to 7.1% from 6.7% earlier, citing the economy's resilience.

IMF said India's trade agreements with the UK and European Union could boost growth by lowering trade barriers and strengthening supply chain resilience.

India's GDP expanded by 7.8% in the June quarter, exceeding expectations.

On a calendar year basis, the IMF projects India's economy to grow by 7.4% in 2026 and 7% in 2027. "India remains among the fastest-growing major economies, with growth in 2026 projected at 7%," it said, adding that India's growth remained robust, underpinned by domestic demand and services, despite higher oil prices.

On inflation, IMF projected India's retail inflation at 5% in FY27, easing to 4.4% in FY28.

However, the latest data showed that annual retail inflation rose to 5.54% in September from 4.8% in August.

Global inflation is projected to rise to 4.7% in 2026 before easing to 4.1% in 2027.

The Fund assumes crude oil prices, based on futures markets, will average $95.74 a barrel in 2026, up 41% from $67.74 in 2025, before easing 9% to $87.39 in 2027.

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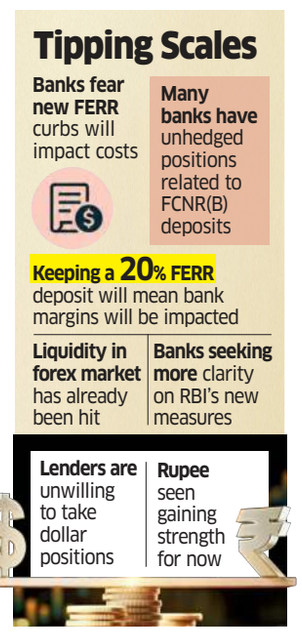
INDIAN CURRENCY GAINS 0.5%

RBI Curbs on Forex Trades Strengthen Re

May impact banks' profitability as hedging dollar bets becomes costlier

Joel Rebello



Mumbai: The rupee surged more than half a percentage point Tuesday, building on its percentage-point advance a day earlier, as Indian banks got busy calculating the cost of fresh derivative-deal curbs that seek to undergird the local currency, arrest capital outflows, and prevent imported inflation from quickening.

The Indian currency ended at 95.28 per dollar, up 0.52% from Monday's close of 95.78 agains the the greenback.

Late Monday night, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said banks using derivative contracts to hedge currency risks on their own balance sheets will also need to keep a foreign exchange risk reserve (FERR) up to 20% of the notional amount against each derivative contract, making it prohibitively expensive to hedge their dollar purchases.

The latest directive follows other measures, aimed at deterring speculative trading, announced over the weekend.

Monday's directive got banks busy with fresh cost calculations on their respective balance sheet commitments, including an assessment of how much they will now have to keep aside for unhedged foreign currency deposits and ongoing external commercial borrowings amid a clear regulatory signal against over-hedging.

Interest on FCNR(B) Deposits ▸▸ 7

TERMINAL-1 REVAMP

Mumbai Airport Freezes Winter Slots for Airlines

Relief for carriers as Adani defers plan to shift intl ops to summer schedule

Forum Gandhi

Mumbai: The planned shift of international operations from the airport in Mumbai to Navi Mumbai has been deferred to the summer schedule, pushing the transition back by five months, people familiar with the matter said. This followed protests against the directive to move flights to the new facility during the winter schedule. The move gives carriers and passengers a reprieve during the peak festive travel season.

Mumbai airport is located in the northern suburbs of the metro, while the Navi Mumbai airport is situated about 34 km away by road.

The plan affects 46 airlines and is linked to the redevelopment of Mumbai airport's Terminal 1. Almost all the carriers attended a meeting with Mumbai International Airport Ltd (MIAL) on Tuesday.

Next Meeting on Oct 28 ▸▸ 7

EYE ON AI VALUE CHAIN

AEL, Jabil Sign MoU for Data Centre Infra JV

Adani Enterprises and US' engineering, supply chain and manufacturing firm Jabil have inked a non-binding MoU for a 50-50 JV to make and assemble AI and data centre equipment in India. ▸▸ 11

STRATEGIC CORE MARKET

Hyundai Motors to Invest $15.5 Billion in India by 2032

South Korea's Hyundai Motor Group has said it will invest $15.5 billion in India over a six-year period till 2032.The initiative positions India as a strategic core market for future growth, innovation. ▸▸ 11

CENTRE CALLS FOR MORE TRANSPARENCY

Hospitals Will Need to Prominently Display Prices for Services

The Centre has told states to ensure hospitals and other clinical establishments prominently display their rates for services and facilities for billing transparency. **Teena Thacker** reports. ▸▸ 8

SEPTEMBER QUARTER TREND

GQG Partners Pares Stakes in Adani Cos; Other FPIs Mix It Up

GQG Partners has pared ₹8,000 crore stakes across five Adani companies in the September quarter. Mixed trends were seen in FPI holdings in Adani firms. **Ravindra Sonavane** reports. ▸▸ 9

'Small' Pains: Inflation Squeeze Likely to Choke FMCG Volume Growth Again

Shift towards reduced pack sizes, cheaper goods signals repeat of 2022-24 downturn

Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: India's fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies could face renewed volume pressure as inflation pushes shoppers towards smaller packs, cheaper products and away from premium goods, with historical data suggesting a repeat of the 2022-24 consumption squeeze, Worldpanel by Numerator (Kantar) analysis showed.

India's retail inflation rose to 5.54% year-on-year in September, the highest since the revised Consumer Price Index (CPI) series was introduced in January. During the previous inflation cycle, average FMCG pack sizes fell 11% from 188 grams to 167 grams between the March 2022 quarter and the December 2024 quarter. Consumers also shifted toward unbranded products, particularly in urban markets. Volume growth in such goods outpaced branded ones during the initial inflation shock. Premium volume growth fell from 29.4% in the first quarter of 2023 to 13.6% in the fourth quarter of 2025, according to the report shared exclusively with ET.

"Prolonged inflation typically impacts demand," said Mayank Shah, vice president at Parle Products, the country's biggest food company. "Consumers initially cut back on spending but gradually return to buying, particularly in food and other essential categories. However, commodity prices remain highly volatile, making it difficult for companies to plan price revisions, at least until Diwali."

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Blume, Kalaari Among 19 Chosen for R&D-Innovation Scheme

DISRUPTION: AI, STARTUPS & TECH ▸▸ 12

TRUMP SAYS HE DOES NOT BELIEVE CHINA AND RUSSIA HELPING IRAN 'AT ALL' ▸▸ PAGE 11

IN-SPACe Pushes Space Cos to Adopt Indigenous Chips

DISRUPTION: AI, STARTUPS & TECH ▸▸ 12

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PUREPOLITICS

INDIA Bloc may Pause Protest Rallies in Delhi During Festive Season

INDIA bloc leaders are expected to put their street protests in Delhi on hold in view of the ongoing festive season and related sustainability issues. **CL Manoj** reports. ▸▸ 2

Shah Slams Rahul, tells Cong to be Ready for Big Defeat in '29 Polls

Home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday hit out at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over the protests against the CEC, saying the party should prepare itself again for a "crushing defeat" in 2029 polls. ▸▸ 2

India Rejects China's Objections to Naming 28 Places in Ladakh

India has rejected China's objection to home ministry assigning standardised names to 28 places and geographical features in Ladakh, saying the UT is an "integral and inalienable" part of the nation. ▸▸ 2

STRENGTH OF INCLUSIVITY

Modi highlights the transformation that is making data, tech, knowledge & innovation the power of this decade

India Believes in the Power to Empower: PM

Whenever the world needs a pillar, India extends its hand... We do not grow at anyone's cost. We grow with the world, and for the world

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi said India believes in growing with the world and for the world, not at anybody's expense, making an outreach to global investors. The principle of 'Power to Empower' is manifested in the 21st century through sharing of technology, data, knowledge and innovation, he said at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum on Tuesday.

The Prime Minister told the gathering of business leaders from India and abroad that the country has seen inclusive growth at a steady pace in the last decade, despite challenges such as the Covid pandemic, wars, disruption of supply chains, trade barriers and supplies of critical minerals being choked off.

"Every era has had its own sources and definition of power. But in the 21st century, especially in this third decade, a major transformation is taking place. Today, technology is power, data is power, knowledge is power, innovation is power," Modi said. Moreover, the issue is not who possesses power but how it is being harnessed, the PM underlined. "Will technology advance only a few people or will it create new opportunities for millions? Will knowledge remain the strength of only a select few? Or will it enhance everybody's capabilities?" he asked.

Traditional Wisdom ▸▸ 7

ET INTERVIEW **JONATHAN GRAY** COO, BLACKSTONE | India, with its 7% growth & youth advantage, doesn't merit negativity

Blackstone has $100-billion Plans for India in 5 Years

Sruthijith KK | New Delhi

Blackstone, the world's largest alternative asset manager, aims to double its investment in India to $100 billion in about five years, chief operating officer Jonathan Gray said in an interview. "It could be in private equity, could be real estate. We're going to be expanding here in infrastructure. We're looking to expand in credit. I think growth equity is an opportunity," said Gray, 56. "In five years, we'd love that number to be $100 billion," from $50 billion now.

READ FULL INTERVIEW ▸▸ PAGE 10

He's not too worried about the exodus of overseas investors from the Indian stock market, predicting they'll likely be back soon. "Public market investors can be fickle. There was a simple narrative last year, which is that India is an importer of a lot of energy, and energy costs are going up; that made investors cautious," he said. "But the public markets can fall back into love again too. If earnings growth, which I think is expected this quarter to be mid-teens, continues, then you'll see global investors come back."

Apart from its inherent strength, the Indian market is also the easiest place after the US to list, allowing early investors an exit avenue. "People in India don't fully appreciate just how strong your capital markets have become. The stock market's up five and a half times in the last 20 years," Gray said. "It is probably, after the US, the easiest place to list a company. That is very good for foreign capital because when you think about inves- ting money, and in particular our drawdown funds, we've got to send capital back to our investors."

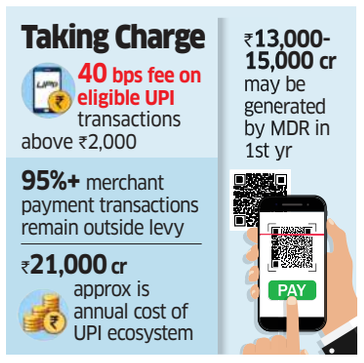
Given the long-term fundamentals and rising middle class, there are a lot of "interesting places to deploy capital," he said.

Public markets can fall back in love again... If earnings growth continues, you'll see global investors return

ROHIT MAHESHWARI

MDR Rollout Pushed to After Diwali

NPCI Breather Levy on UPI transactions over ₹2k was set to start on Oct 15



Our Bureau

Mumbai | Bengaluru: The reintroduction of merchant discount rate (MDR) on select UPI payments has been deferred until after Diwali, giving businesses and payment firms time to prepare for the first significant pricing change on the digital network that has helped revolutionise day-to-day transactions in a country primarily using physical currency until a few years ago.

The UPI and Services Steering Committee Tuesday decided that, in view of the festive season, the levy on select person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions will be implemented immediately after Diwali, the National Payments Corp of India (NPCI) said in a statement. The NPCI will announce the exact starting date later.

The levy was earlier scheduled to take effect from October 15. Diwali, which marks the end of India's month-long festive season, falls on November 8. **ET** first reported on July 16 that the government was moving to restore UPI MDR with a ₹2,000 threshold.

Industry Bodies Sought Postponement ▸▸ 7

THE BRAND EQUITY SHOW by The Economic Times

Can Prime Video make its India bundle add up?

From free streams, subscriptions and advertising to theatrical releases, Prime Video's India offering keeps widening. Gaurav Gandhi makes the value case; Nikhil Madhok lays out the content bets.

FOCUS NOW SHIFTS TO COURT BATTLE OVER OPPN PLEA

INDIA Bloc's Daily Delhi Marches Hit Festive Season Pause Button

CJP's protest over Jantar Mantar issue may prompt Opposition to do a similar act in some form

PTI

Our team will not stop. If not today, tomorrow or the day after or after three months... We will go till the end of the fight. We can't give details

RAHUL GANDHI *Congress Leader*

CL Manoj

New Delhi: A day after INDIA bloc leaders staged a united march, their fifth since last week, and filed a petition in the Supreme Court against the chief election commissioner and SIR, their street protest was paused in Delhi on Tuesday, even as a meeting of bloc leaders convened by Rahul Gandhi felt that in view of the ongoing festival season and the related sustainability issues, they will have to scale down their daily protests and marches in the national capital to occasional outings.

At a presser after the INDIA bloc meeting, all leaders vowed to fight unitedly

Yet, the Cockroach Janta Party's agitation against the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site has also put pressure on the bloc, especially Congress, to do something similar, if not unitedly, at least through the respective parties and their student and youth wings and through civil society.

While INDIA bloc leaders made no official statement about the next protest schedule post-meeting, sources said there won't be regular united Delhi street marches till at least the third week of October due to Navratri-Durga puja festivities and later during Diwali-Dusshera-Chhat season in November. Congress will hold its scheduled Delhi rally on November 1. Leaders/MPs of parties facing state elections will also have to work on their home turf rather than staying put in Delhi. This, even as the Opposition lawyers are trying to get an emergency hearing of their petition in the Supreme Court with the Opposition hoping for at least an interim stay on SIR.

"In view of the current festival season, starting with Navratra and Durga puja and lasting till mid-November with Diwali and Chhat, many of our colleagues suggested at the meeting that it would be difficult to carry on during this period with the same kind of united daily protest in Delhi. However, we stand together...," a leader who participated in the bloc meeting told **ET**.

Sources said the meeting also witnessed some participants suggesting shifting the bloc's protest later to states, and places like Varanasi, the PM's LS constituency. However, most felt that to get maximum optics and impact, Delhi was the place for protests.

At a post-meeting presser, all leaders vowed to fight unitedly, with Gandhi saying that there were plans for a 'surprise' effect. "I used the word perseverance yesterday. Our team will not stop. If not today, tomorrow or the day after or after three months... We will go till the end of the fight. We can't give the details," he said, adding that the Opposition will also 'challenge' the bar on Jantar Mantar. Leaders, including Tejashwi Yadav (RJD), Supriya Sule (NCP-SP), Sanjay Raut (SS-UBT), HS Malik (SP), MA Baby, D Raja and Neha Bora (Left) and Sagarika Ghosh (AITC-Mamata) vowed to keep up their unity and fight against CEC, SIR and the Modi government.

BJP'S OFFENSIVE AGAINST RAHUL GANDHI AND OPPOSITION LEADERS

Oppn Heading for Crushing Defeat Again in 2029: Shah

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: After days of protests, Union home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday joined BJP's offensive against Rahul Gandhi, saying the Opposition should be prepared once again for a "crushing defeat" in 2029 as people are with BJP, NDA and Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Shah said the kind of "negative politics" Congress has been engaged in will not benefit it as the Opposition party needs to understand people and connect with the public. "I want to tell Rahulji and his associates to prepare themselves once again for a crushing defeat in 2029. In 2029 general elections, NDA is going to win with a resounding majority, and Congress is going to face defeat for the fourth consecutive time."

Slamming Gandhi, Shah said people of India know his plans of "getting infiltrators registered as voters...I want to ask Rahul Gandhiji directly: Is this the result of SIR? SIR started only after 2024."

"Ever since you became the principal leader of Congress, and later its president, and now Leader of the Opposition, Congress party has continuously lost elections. You need to engage in introspections. You cannot win the trust of people through fabricated media events and lies," he said.

PTI

Ever since you became the principal leader of Congress, and later its president, and now Leader of the Opposition, Congress party has continuously lost elections. You need to engage in introspections. You cannot win the trust of people through fabricated media events and lies

AMIT SHAH *Union Home Minister*

Earlier, senior BJP leader Piyush Goyal, at a joint press conference with JDU leader and his Cabinet colleague Rajiv Ranjan invoked the Gen Z phrase "delulu is the solulu" to mock Gandhi and called the Congress leader's conduct "childish".

Goyal accused the Opposition of undermining constitutional institutions and said the government was ready for a parliamentary debate on electoral issues and dismissed Gandhi's "vote chori" charge as baseless and asserted that the Modi government had given the Election Commission complete autonomy to function in the interests of the country and its people.

He accused the Congress of rewarding former CECs with political appointments, alleging that one was given a Cabinet berth and two others were made governors during its rule. Singh accused Congress of harming democracy and constitutional institutions through protests based on what he called baseless allegations.

"Rahulji, do some introspection and meditation. Do some positive work if some good sense prevails upon you by the grace of God. Democracy cannot function with such negative politics and drama," he said, urging the Opposition not to pressure or discredit constitutional bodies.

Drawing a parallel with the Emergency in 1975, Singh accused Gandhi of following in the footsteps of his grandmother, former PM Indira Gandhi, alleging that she had undermined the Constitution to retain power.

FILE PHOTO

DEFAMATION CASE

'Commander-in-Thief' Remark: SC Stays Trial Against Rahul

Comments allegedly made against PM in connection with Rafale fighter deal

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Tuesday stayed trial court proceedings in a criminal defamation case against the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi over his 2018 remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi in connection with the Rafale fighter jet deal.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Aparesh Kumar Singh issued notice on Gandhi's plea challenging a September 8 order of the Bombay High Court, which had refused to quash the criminal defamation proceedings against the LoP. The bench sought responses from the Maharashtra government and complainant Mahesh Shrishrimal within four weeks.

Bench seeks responses from Maha govt and complainant Shrishrimal within four weeks

The case stems from remarks allegedly made by Gandhi during a public rally in Rajasthan on September 20, 2018, when he used the slogan 'Chowkidar chor hai' while criticising the PM over the Rafale deal. Gandhi subsequently posted on social media where he described Modi as "India's Commander-in-Thief". He also allegedly made remarks against Modi at a Congress workers' meeting in Amethi.

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

FAMILY MEMBERS PROTEST

ANI

Anti-Drug Activist Shot Dead in Punjab

CHANDIGARH: Anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh, alias Jhota, known for raising his voice against drug abuse and illegal sale of addictive substances at chemist shops, was shot dead in broad daylight in a busy market in Punjab's Mansa town. **Punjab Police is on the lookout for the medical store owner, who chased and opened fire on the activist and his companions as the public watched in horror**, allegedly enraged over being questioned for the sale of addictive drugs to an elderly man. Following the incident, tensions simmered in Mansa town as the activist's supporters vandalised the medical shop, even as Jhota's family refused to cremate his body in protest. A heavy police force has been deployed outside the Civil Hospital, where his body is kept. The incident has invited widespread condemnation from political leaders, who cornered the ruling AAP over law and order. – PTI

FILE PHOTO

Delhi Records 5 Road Deaths Daily in 2026, Highest in 6 Years

NEW DELHI: Delhi's roads turned deadlier in 2026, claiming an average of five lives and leaving 17 people injured every day in the first nine months of the year, which saw 1,309 fatalities, with **two-wheeler riders and pedestrians accounting for 81% of those killed**, according to official data. The city recorded an average of 17 road accidents daily between January and September, with the daily averages for accidents, fatalities and injuries all reaching their highest levels in six years, the data showed. The national capital recorded 4,679 road accidents and 4,662 injuries in the first nine months of 2026. The average number of accidents per day stood at 13 in 2021 and rose to 16 annually between 2022 and 2025. Similarly, the daily average of fatalities increased from three in 2021 to four in 2022, remaining at that level until 2025. – PTI

SOUTHERN POLITICAL CONNECT

Tamil Nadu chief minister Joseph Vijay (right) being greeted by Andhra Pradesh HRD minister Nara Lokesh in Vijayawada on Tuesday. Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu is also seen –PTI

Plea Filed in SC Over Oppn Gathering on Premises

CJI AGREES TO LIST PETITIONS TODAY Matter mentioned before bench by Bhatia and Jethmalani

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Writ petitions have been filed in the Supreme Court seeking its intervention over the gathering of a large number of people inside the court premises after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other INDIA bloc leaders entered the complex on Monday in connection with their proposed petition against the Election Commission of India's special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The matter was mentioned before a three-member bench, headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, by senior advocates Gaurav Bhatia and Mahesh Jethmalani, who sought urgent listing. The CJI agreed to list the petitions on Thursday.

The petitions relate to the events of Monday evening, when Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, among others, entered the Supreme Court premises along with their supporters.

The gathering followed a march by INDIA bloc leaders against SIR and their move to challenge the poll panel's decisions before the apex court. The march was stopped by police barricades before the leaders could reach the court, but a petition challenging SIR was subsequently filed. The gathering inside the Supreme Court complex at around 7 pm on Monday led to a large crowd assembling within the premises, with reports of commotion.

INDIA bloc's separate petition challenges SIR and raises concerns over alleged irregularities in electoral roll revision and the exercise of powers by CEC Gyanesh Kumar. It seeks judicial intervention in the functioning of ECI and safeguards against arbitrary deletion of eligible voters.

OPPN PLEA CHALLENGES SIR, CEC'S EXERCISE OF POWERS

INDIA bloc's separate petition challenges SIR, raises concerns over 'irregularities in voter roll revision' and exercise of powers by CEC

Poliloquy R PRASAD

Kerala Introduces Elderly Care Bill

Thiruvananthapuram: Kerala on Tuesday became the first state in the country to introduce a comprehensive Bill– the Keralam Senior Citizens (Care and Protection of Rights) Bill, 2026– to protect senior citizens from abuse and exploitation, regulate elderly care centres and ensure better access to healthcare and social security.–**PTI**

DIPKE ON JANTAR MANTAR DENOTIFICATION

'Entire Country may Become Protest Site'

CJP FOUNDER DIPKE HITS OUT AT SC, CJI

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Tuesday said that if Jantar Mantar was shut for protesters, then they would turn the entire country into a protest site. Dipke claimed that protests would continue at Jantar Mantar despite Delhi Police denotifying it as a protest site.

"Ashutosh Ranka, Saurav Das and other CJP leaders were detained today for flying the tricolour at Jantar Mantar. Flying the tricolour is not a violation, this is autocracy. Jantar Mantar is not anyone's personal property. The entire country will resemble Jantar Mantar if protests are not allowed there. We will not stop till chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar resigns," Dipke told reporters in Hingoli on Tuesday.

Dipke alleged Delhi Police had been threatening to detain lawyers who had gone to meet Ranka, Das and other CJP cadres who were detained after Tuesday's protests. "They could allow lawyers to meet, what are you afraid of? Today journalists, Opposition MPs, students, everyone is getting detained. The country is not being run by the Constitution," Dipke claimed.

The CJP founder took aim at the Supreme Court, saying it has not taken any action against ECI. "Whether it is CJI (Chief Justice of India) or the Supreme Court... He (Surya Kant) had recently said that law and order is not the responsibility of the court. They have not taken any action against the Election Commission. When votes were deleted in Bengal, they said it's alright if you can't vote now, you can vote later. Will the Supreme Court say the same thing to Narendra Modi that you do not fight elections now but can fight later? If you can't say to him, then how can you say to the people?"

ANI

They (SC, CJI) have not taken any action against Election Commission. When votes were deleted in Bengal, they said it's alright if you can't vote now, you can vote later. Will the Supreme Court say the same thing to Narendra Modi that you do not fight elections now but can fight later?

ABHIJEET DIPKE
Cockroach Janta Party Founder

DIPKE HAILS OPPN PROTEST

Lauding the Opposition for the protests in Delhi on Monday, the CJP leader said it was necessary to 'stay united' and carry out such protests until CEC resigns.

CJP Leaders Detained as they Sneak into Jantar Mantar

HEAVILY-GUARDED AREA BREACHED CJP on Govt-Delhi Police decision: De-notification of democracy itself

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: CJP leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were detained on Tuesday after they sneaked into the heavily guarded Jantar Mantar with the Indian national flag in their hands and raised slogans demanding resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

In a post on X, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke shared the video showing Ranka and Das jumping the gates and barricades and reaching the protest site and later taken away by Delhi Police in a van. CJP termed the Centre and Delhi Police decision to remove Jantar Mantar as an authorised demonstration site, as a blatant assault on constitutional rights, calling it a "denotification of democracy itself."

ANI

Addressing a press conference, CJP activist Mehr Parsicha asserted that public spaces belong to all citizens and cannot be commandeered by the state to silence dissent. "Cockroaches have shown that this country does not belong to just one person. Jantar Mantar does not belong to one individual. Jantar Mantar belongs to all of us. Today, they showed that you cannot simply snatch away our rights," she said. Criticising the heavy security arrangements across Central Delhi, she questioned the deployment of massive paramilitary and police forces to curb peaceful gatherings.

RAISING A POINT

Public spaces belong to all citizens and cannot be commandeered by the state to silence dissent: Cockroach Janta Party

BEIJING OBJECTS TO INDIA NAMING 28 PLACES IN LADAKH

Ladakh Integral Part Of India, China's Denial Cannot Change Fact: MEA

Locations, including Gogra and Hot Springs, identified on October 2 to streamline official cartography

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: India on Tuesday rejected China's objection to New Delhi assigning standardised names to 28 places and geographical features in Ladakh, saying that the Union Territory is an "integral and inalienable" part of the country.

Last week, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) assigned standardised names to 28 places and geographical features in Ladakh, including key border friction points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), such as Gogra and Hot Springs. India's response came hours after China strongly opposed New Delhi's move.

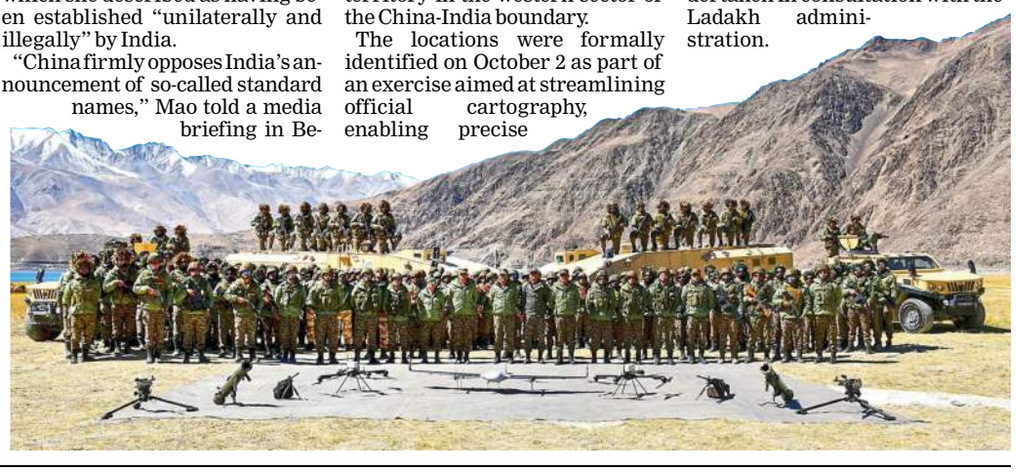
"It is reiterated that the Union Territory of Ladakh is an integral and inalienable part of India. No amount of denial by the Chinese side can change this established fact," External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said. He said the press release issued by the MHA on October 2, which China had referred to, was "self-explanatory".

"The announcement mentions that the 28 places/features located in the UT of Ladakh have been identified with standard place and feature names on the official map of Survey of India, and it has been done in consultation with the Union Territory of Ladakh and local stakeholders," Jaiswal said. "Identifying these places formally on the Survey of India map of UT of Ladakh is aimed at facilitating their accurate recognition and better awareness among the public at large," he added.

China on Tuesday opposed India's move, with Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Mao Ning saying Beijing had never recognised the Union Territory of Ladakh, which she described as having been established "unilaterally and illegally" by India.

"China firmly opposes India's announcement of so-called standard names," Mao told a media briefing in Beijing, adding that the move was "illegal and invalid" and could not change what China claims to be its territory in the western sector of the China-India boundary.

The locations were formally identified on October 2 as part of an exercise aimed at streamlining official cartography, enabling precise identification and improving public awareness of the sensitive border region. The exercise was undertaken in consultation with the Ladakh administration.



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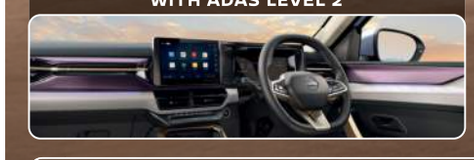

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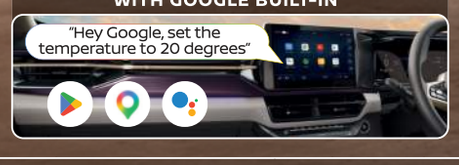

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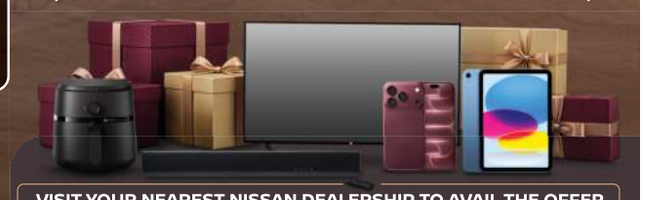

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Quota Verdict: Cabinet to Weigh Legal Options

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: The Karnataka Cabinet will examine the high court's verdict striking down the state's enhanced quota for SC/STs in college admissions and government recruitments before deciding whether to challenge it in the Supreme Court, deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said on Tuesday.

A division bench of the Karnataka HC on Monday quashed provisions of the Karnataka SC/ST (Reservation of Seats in Educational Institutions and of Appointments or Posts in the Services under the State) Act, 2022. **The law raised SC reservation from 15% to 17% and ST reservation from 3% to 7%, taking the state's total reservation to 56%.**

Parameshwara said the previous BJP government led by Basavaraj Bommai had introduced the increase, which the Congress government continued to follow in recruitments. The Cabinet will examine whether to appeal against the verdict or pursue other legal options within the constitutional framework.

He also said the government would assess the ruling's implications for educational admissions and government recruitments already completed under the 56% reservation structure.

SHIVAKUMAR SEEKS REPORT FROM SENIOR OFFICIALS

Police Action against SIR Protesters Draws CM's Ire

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Chief minister DK Shivakumar sought a report from senior officials on the police action against protesters and media personnel during a demonstration against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bengaluru on Monday. He said any unnecessary use of force would invite accountability.

"The right to peaceful protest is fundamental to our democracy. We cannot demand that right for ourselves in Delhi and deny it to others in Bengaluru," Shivakumar said in a media statement on Tuesday, endorsing home minister Priyank Kharge's position on protecting peaceful demonstrations.

The protest was organised by students, lawyers and others who marched towards the Election Commission of India office in Bengaluru to condemn the Delhi Police's handling of demonstrations. Protesters alleged that Bengaluru Police resorted to similar action, claiming that about 100 people were affected and that some women, students and lawyers were manhandled.

Shivakumar said he had sought a detailed report on the circumstances that led to the police action. "Disagreement with the Election Commission, disagreement with my government, or disagreement with me personally does not diminish anyone's right to peacefully express it," he said, adding that action would follow if the inquiry established that excessive force had been used.

Kharge said he had instructed the police to ensure that peaceful demonstrations were not disrupted. He also urged protesters to cooperate with the police and inform the authorities about their plans to help protect their safety and the rights of others.

City Lawyers Protest Delhi Detentions

Bengaluru: Advocates affiliated with multiple associations staged a demonstration outside the Karnataka High Court in Bengaluru on Tuesday, protesting the detention of lawyers and activists by the Delhi Police during demonstrations in the national capital.

Court Restrains Media From Linking Siddu to Honey Trap

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: A local court in Bengaluru on Tuesday granted an ex parte ad-interim injunction to veteran Congress leader Siddaramaiah, restraining 42 media organisations, digital platforms and other defendants from publishing or circulating videos allegedly linking the former chief minister to a honey trap.

Additional city civil and sessions judge B Pushpanjali passed the order in a defamation suit filed by Siddaramaiah.

The court restrained the defendants from telecasting, rebroadcasting or disseminating videos and clips, screenshots, extracts, transcripts or edited versions of the content.

Siddaramaiah said his name was being falsely linked to a sting-operation video circulating on social media and alleged that the campaign was intended to damage his reputation.

"Over the past few days, I have noticed a malicious campaign being carried out by linking my name to a sting-operation video circulating across various social media platforms. This appears to be an attempt to tarnish my reputation and assassinate my character for political reasons," he said in a statement.

Siddu said his name was being falsely linked to a sting-op video circulating on social media

The Congress leader said he had no connection with the video and had approached the court as a precautionary measure. He added that advances in technology had made it easier to present falsehoods as facts.

"My conscience is clear that I am completely innocent in this matter. I firmly believe that truth will ultimately prevail," he said.

Kumaraswamy Seeks CBI Probe into Alleged Sting Targeting State Leaders

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Union minister for heavy industries and steel HD Kumaraswamy on Tuesday called for a CBI investigation into allegations of surveillance and sting operations targeting political leaders and their families in Karnataka.

Will submit a formal complaint to Union home minister Amit Shah: HDK

He said he would submit a formal complaint to Union home minister Amit Shah, seeking an independent probe.

Speaking to the media in Bengaluru, Kumaraswamy said the investigation should establish who was behind the alleged operations, who carried them out and the roles of those involved. He urged the state government to refer the matter to the CBI to ensure that the investigation was free from political influence.

"Those who have done nothing wrong need not fear an investigation. Whoever is responsible must be investigated, regardless of their position," he said, adding that anyone found guilty should face strict action.

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Note: It is informed that in case tender process is not completed due to any reason, no corrigendum will be published in newspapers. Details regarding corrigendum may be seen on official PSTCL website **www.pstcl.org.** Terms and conditions may be downloaded from PSTCL's website **https://eproc.punjab.gov.in**
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Corrigendum to Tender Notice No. RWF/S/P1/13/2026-27 dated: 29.09.26
The due date and quantity of the Tender against Sl No.4 of the above Tender Notice is modified and to be read as under:-

Parameter	Existing	Amended to
Due date	19/11/2026	05/11/2026
Tender quantity	1608 MT	4093 MT

Detailed Scope & corrigendum will be available in IREPS E-Portal.
Principal Chief Materials Manager (on behalf of President of India)

Karnataka Soaps & Detergents Limited
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
An ISO-9001:2015 & 14001:2015 Company
Sandal City: P.B No. 5531, Bengaluru - Pune Highway, Bengaluru – 560055. Ph: 080-22164879, 22164886,
Website: **www.mysoresandal.org** E-mail: **ksdl.dgmmtls@gmail.com**
Date : 13.10.2026

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1	KSDL/2026-27/IND1315	Procurement of Mysore Sandal Talc 300g Corrugated Boxes with partition and top plate	17500 Nos	12.10.2026	27.10.2026
2	KSDL/2026-27/IND1316	Procurement of machine made 9 inch raw agarbathi sticks White	5000 Kgs	13.10.2026	28.10.2026

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I, Aiswarya Harish (Old Name), aged 35 yrs, W/o Harish Karuvayil Shivaram, R/a. No. 53, 14th B Main, 8th E Cross, Near Attiguppe, RPC Layout, Vijayanagar, Bangalore - 560040 have changed my name to be read as AISWARYA HARI (New Name) for all purposes vide affidavit dated 12.10.2026 sworn before Notary MK Devaki.

I, Priya Pawankumar Mundada, W/o Priyank Rathi, residing at D501, The Ripple, Gunjur Balagere Road, Gunjur, Bengaluru - 560087, hereby announce that I have changed my name to Priya Mundada. Henceforth I shall be known as Priya Mundada for all purposes vide affidavit dated 12-10-2026.

I, Anil Kumar, declare that my name and DOB were wrongly recorded as Anil Kumar Appaji instead of Anil Kumar, and 29/03/1973 instead of 20/04/1973 in my old passport. Henceforth, my name is Anil Kumar and DOB is 20/04/1973, vide affidavit dated 08/10/2026

I Gayathri Bhat D/o Giridhar Prabhu M W/o Sharath V P Bhat has changed my name post-marriage from Gayathri Prabhu M to Gayathri Bhat for all future purposes.

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JC671202H SUB Maj & Hony Capt Chander Mani 2 ATC my daughter name service records Mrinalini changed to Mrinalini Kapoor, for all purpose.

MEENA Kumari, W/o JC676641X Sub/MT Ashok Kumar, R/a Chhonda Kanera Ater Bhind MP changed my name to Meena, for all purpose.

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LOW USAGE UNDER SASCI SCHEME

States Asked to Expedite Capex Loans Utilisation

Only a qtr of ₹2 lakh cr interest-free loan allocation for the year used so far

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The Department of Expenditure (DoE) has asked states to quicken utilisation under the Centre's ₹2 lakh crore interest-free capex loan program, with only about a quarter of the budgeted amount used so far, people familiar with the matter told **ET**.

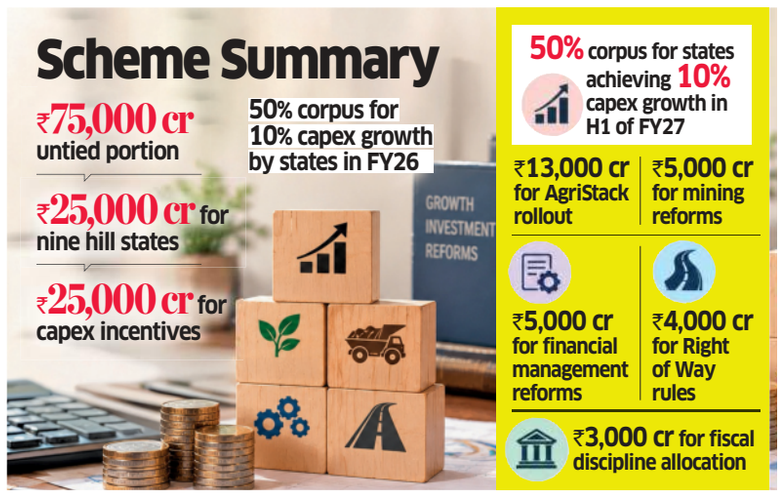
In letters sent in the first week of October, DoE flagged slow utilisation under the Scheme for Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI), with several states yet to draw available funds or submit utilisation certificates, officials said.

The department has directed officials to reach out to states for utilisation certificates and also speed up approvals, among other measures. The Centre has released around ₹51,000 crore under SASCI as on October 1 and has sanctioned loans worth ₹67,000 crore. Releases account for about 26% of the ₹2 lakh crore allocation for the year, while actual utilisation remains lower. The Centre's push comes amid concerns that delays in deploying the funds could hold back state-level capital expenditure, a key component of the government's broader public investment strategy. "This year the budget under the SASCI scheme is generous, but we have seen a slowdown after July," a senior official told **ET**, who did not want to be identified.

The centre has already released ₹44,500 crore till July. Officials added that the centre is confident that states would absorb the full allocation in the second half of the fiscal year. The department is working closely with the states to resolve implementation bottlenecks, including helping identify suitable projects and facilitating faster clearances so that available assistance translates into expenditure on the ground, the official added.

Introduced in FY22, SASCI provides states with 50-year interest-free loans to boost capital investment in infrastructure and other projects. The scheme is a key component of the Centre's effort to use public capital expenditure to support economic growth, with state spending complementing investment by the Union government.

This year, the united component, distributed largely on the basis of states' share in central taxes, accounts for 37.5% of the total allocation, and the rest is dependent on a series of reforms, which states can take up. The scheme also includes ₹25,000 crore to incentivise states to meet capital expenditure targets and ₹25,000 crore for the development of hilly states, recognising their distinct geographical and fiscal constraints and introducing an incentive for the states for fiscal prudence.



MSMEs Need to Focus on Quality, Cost to Gain from New FTAs: Secy

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's expanding network of free trade agreements (FTAs) and economic partnerships is opening new opportunities for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) to expand their global footprint, but improving quality and cost competitiveness will be critical for converting these opportunities, said MSME ministry secretary Bharat Khera.

"The opportunity does not automatically translate into growth," he said on Tuesday, underlining the need for enterprises to build greater trust through quality and become globally cost-competitive. Speaking at the CII Global MSME Business Summit, Khera said government schemes aimed at promoting exports would need to be complemented by practical assistance and handholding, particularly for first-time exporters.

The goal, he said, is to make MSMEs more productive, innovative, resilient and globally confident. "One that creates more employment, contributes much more to exports, strengthens the manufacturing and supply chain," he said. The secretary highlighted the five priority areas for the government to enhance MSME competitiveness: formalisation, access to finance, technology and quality, export competitiveness, and entrepreneurship and enterprise development. These five key points are closely interconnected, according to Khera. "Formalisation improves access to finance, technology and quality upgrades support productivity, and stronger export capabilities create opportunities for sustainable growth," he said.

The MSME sector accounts for 30% of the gross domestic product (GDP) and around 49% of exports. Khera said that in this environment, boosting the competitiveness of Indian MSMEs is essential for economic growth and achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat. He noted that consistent quality, competitive pricing and reliable delivery schedules are crucial for Indian suppliers seeking to expand their presence in global markets.

Additionally, he called for upgrading the country's testing infrastructure to ensure that products manufactured by Indian enterprises conform to international standards. Certification remains another area requiring attention; while participation in bronze-level certifications has improved, the uptake of silver and gold tiers remains low, leaving significant scope for progress.

As per a CII and Indian School of Business study, 32% of the surveyed MSMEs held recognised certification. Among non-certified respondents, 50.9% said their customers did not require certification, while 30.4% cited a lack of awareness.

Bihar Joins Maha, UP in Curbing Sale of Non-subsidised Fert

Shambhavi Anand

New Delhi: Bihar joined Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh in restricting the sale of non-subsidised fertilisers by companies supplying government-subsidised products such as urea, di-ammonium phosphate, NPK complexes and muriate of potash, a decision that industry executives say could affect farmers' access to newer crop nutrition technologies.

The restrictions could potentially limit the range of products available to farmers through existing distribution networks. For the companies that sell specialty fertilisers, micronutrients and other crop nutrition products alongside conventional fertilisers, this could cause an up to ₹120 crore loss in margins, according to industry estimates. The move comes at a time when fertiliser industry executives say they are seeking to promote the use of more efficient nutrients and encourage farmers to adopt advanced crop nutrition products to improve yields and soil health.

Unlike conventional fertilisers, whose retail prices are either controlled or supported by government subsidies, non-subsidised products are generally sold at market-determined prices. In a joint letter dated October 9, some top industry players urged the Bihar government to review its order, warning that the move could restrict farmers' access to essential nutrients and affect soil health and crop productivity. Bihar's low soil organic carbon levels make balanced nutrient application particularly important, said the letter, which **ET** has seen. "Restricting these products could discourage investment in new crop nutrition technologies and reduce farmers' access to alternatives that may help improve fertiliser-use efficiency," said a top executive at a large fertiliser manufacturer that sells subsidised and non-subsidised products.

Move comes amid industry efforts to promote advanced crop nutrition products to improve yield and soil health

This could also disrupt manufacturing operations of fertiliser companies producing organic and sulphur-based products, as well as supplies routed through dealers under the government's one-stop fertiliser outlet model, the official said. The restrictions are aimed at preventing tagging, a practice in which dealers or suppliers make the purchase of non-subsidised products a condition for obtaining subsidised fertilisers. In UP, the restrictions took effect on January 1, 2026, covering non-subsidised products sold by major fertiliser suppliers.

PM GatiShakti: Over 400 Infra Projects Worth ₹20 L Cr Sent for Okay

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The PM GatiShakti initiative has recommended more than 400 infrastructure projects worth about ₹20.23 lakh crore for approval, including projects in roads and railways, as the government's flagship programme completes five years.

The projects have been evaluated by the Network Planning Group (NPG), constituted under the initiative launched on October 13, 2021.

"The NPG evaluated over 400 infrastructure projects worth approximately ₹20.23 lakh crore based on PM GatiShakti principles," the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement on Tuesday.

The ministry said the PM GatiShakti digital platform has integrated more than 1,800 data layers, covering 58 central ministries and departments and all 36 states and Union Territories.

All logistics and connectivity infrastructure projects involving investments of more than ₹500 crore are routed through the NPG.

"The platform has also facilitated the development and integration of more than 65 software modules/tools and over 100 mobile and web applications, strengthening data-driven infrastructure planning across the country," it said.

The portal provides data on land records, ports, forests, schools, railway stations, water bodies, telecom towers and highways.

RITES Dispatches First 18 Coaches to Bangladesh

Export arm of Indian Railways supplying coaches under a project funded by European Investment Bank

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Railway PSU RITES has dispatched the first rake of 18 broad-gauge passenger coaches to Bangladesh Railway under a contract to supply 200 coaches. The coaches, comprising seven variants, are being manufactured by Rail Coach Factory (RCF) in Kapurthala, Punjab, the company said in a statement. Officials said this was the first such shipment since the change in regime in Bangladesh.

India has previously supplied Bangladesh Railway with 120 broad-gauge passenger coaches, 36 broad-gauge locomotives and 10 metre-gauge locomotives.

RITES, the export arm of Indian Railways, is supplying the coaches under a project funded by the European Investment Bank.

The ₹915-crore contract was awarded to RITES in May 2024 through a global competitive bidding process.

Dispatched on October 12, the first rake comprises 11 non-AC Shovan chair cars, three AC chair cars, two AC sleeper cars and two AC power cars equipped with a guard room and luggage space.

"RITES has been offering integrated export services to various countries in Asia and Africa," the company said.

It added that it had supplied more than 280 locomotives and 1,085 coaches and diesel multiple unit (DMU) trainsets worldwide.

More Thermal Capacity Needed to Meet Power Demand, Says CEA Chief

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India may need to add more coal-fired power capacity than previously projected to meet rising electricity demand, even as renewable energy additions continue at a rapid pace, Central Electricity Authority (CEA) chairperson Ghanshyam Prasad said on Tuesday.

The initial target for additional thermal capacity was 97 GW with 2023 as the reference year, which was later revised to 105 GW. Now, it is expected to rise to 115 GW, Prasad said at India Energy Summit organised by Indian Chamber of Commerce. The additional capacity is likely to be required by around FY32-FY34, he said on the sidelines of the event.

"The way the demand is growing, this figure needs to move slightly higher. It needs to be done, though the numbers aren't final yet," Prasad told reporters. "We have to have a judicious mix of all kinds of resources in the country." India's current thermal power capacity is 252.5 GW, about 45% of the total installed capacity.

India's power demand has grown over 10% on a year-on-year basis this year with high cooling and irrigation demand

Power demand in the country has grown over 10% on a year-on-year basis this year, with high cooling and irrigation demand. Peak power demand touched 271 GW in May and September. Last year, the weather was favourable with good monsoon rains, making the base lower, Prasad noted.

He said renewable energy will continue to grow at the required pace. "Last year is a very good example of renewables getting added into the systems," he added. India added over 50 GW of renewable energy capacity in FY26, the highest ever in green energy capacity in the country.

"And this phenomenon will keep on growing almost every year, with capacity addition of more than 50 GW each year coming from renewable energy itself," Prasad said.

With the plant load factor of coal-based units running high this year, the concern is also of fuel availability because of the sharp stock depletion in the last few months. Many of the thermal power plants have not been able to take maintenance shutdowns because of the high-power demand, which started as early as March this year. "We are not finding time to put them on the maintenance cycle... But we have been able to manage them [challenges] in a much better manner," Prasad said.

Addressing the session, NTPC chairman and managing director Gurdeep Singh said the high power demand situation is because of the El Nino condition and economic growth. Going forward, the artificial intelligence (AI) and data centre boom will also contribute to the demand, he said.

Bitter Truth Surge in Sugar Prices to Push Up Festival Budgets

'Prices to stay high, may moderate only if fresh supplies arrive, input costs soften'

Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: Sweets, candies and desserts are getting costlier during the ongoing festive season, raising the cost of celebrations and gifting for consumers. Higher sugar prices and costs of other key inputs are fuelling the increase, putting pressure on manufacturers as festive demand picks up.

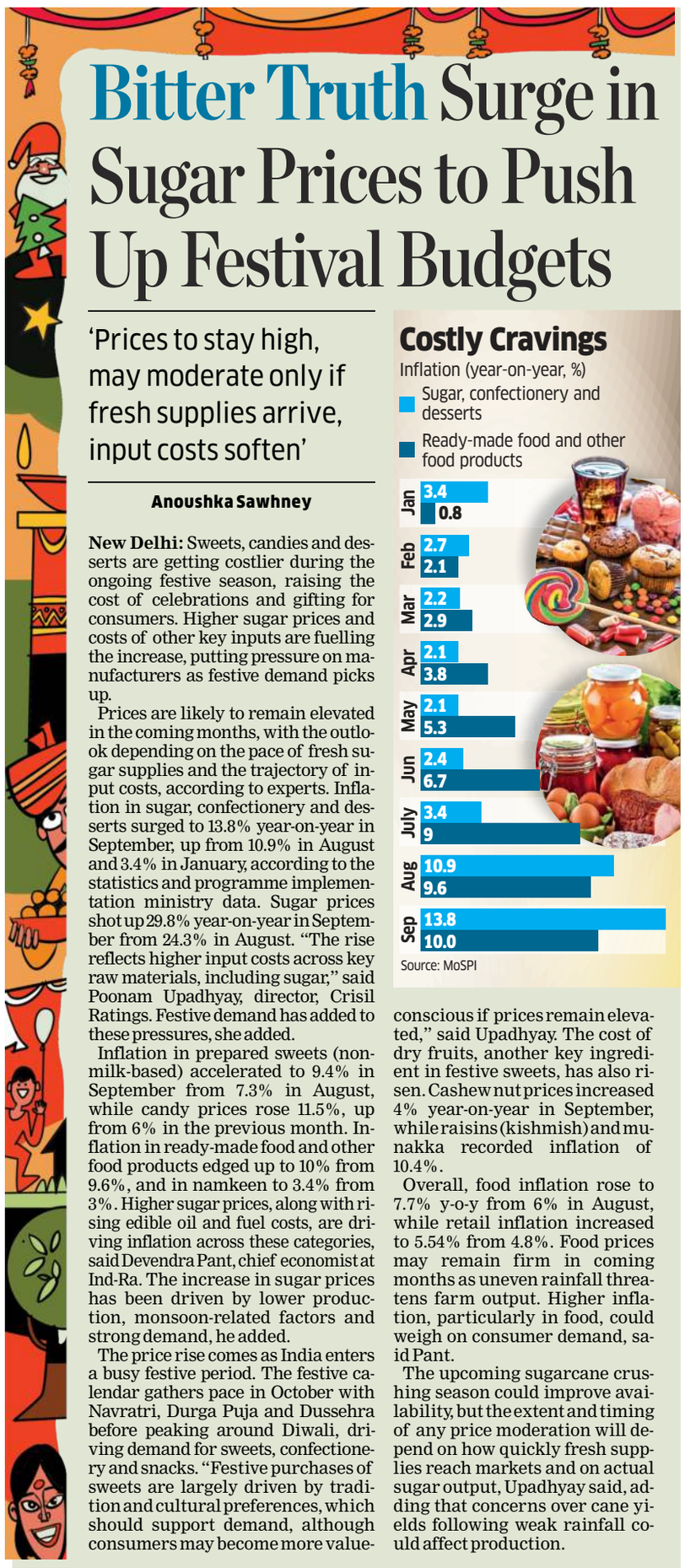
Prices are likely to remain elevated in the coming months, with the outlook depending on the pace of fresh sugar supplies and the trajectory of input costs, according to experts. Inflation in sugar, confectionery and desserts surged to 13.8% year-on-year in September, up from 10.9% in August and 3.4% in January, according to the statistics and programme implementation ministry data. Sugar prices shot up 29.8% year-on-year in September from 24.3% in August. "The rise reflects higher input costs across key raw materials, including sugar," said Poonam Upadhyay, director, Crisil Ratings. Festive demand has added to these pressures, she added.

Inflation in prepared sweets (non-milk-based) accelerated to 9.4% in September from 7.3% in August, while candy prices rose 11.5%, up from 6% in the previous month. Inflation in ready-made food and other food products edged up to 10% from 9.6%, and in namkeen to 3.4% from 3%. Higher sugar prices, along with rising edible oil and fuel costs, are driving inflation across these categories, said Devendra Pant, chief economist at Ind-Ra. The increase in sugar prices has been driven by lower production, monsoon-related factors and strong demand, he added.

The price rise comes as India enters a busy festive period. The festive calendar gathers pace in October with Navratri, Durga Puja and Dussehra before peaking around Diwali, driving demand for sweets, confectionery and snacks. "Festive purchases of sweets are largely driven by tradition and cultural preferences, which should support demand, although consumers may become more value-conscious if prices remain elevated," said Upadhyay. The cost of dry fruits, another key ingredient in festive sweets, has also risen. Cashew nut prices increased 4% year-on-year in September, while raisins (kishmish) and munakka recorded inflation of 10.4%.

Overall, food inflation rose to 7.7% y-o-y from 6% in August, while retail inflation increased to 5.54% from 4.8%. Food prices may remain firm in coming months as uneven rainfall threatens farm output. Higher inflation, particularly in food, could weigh on consumer demand, said Pant.

The upcoming sugarcane crushing season could improve availability, but the extent and timing of any price moderation will depend on how quickly fresh supplies reach markets and on actual sugar output, Upadhyay said, adding that concerns over cane yields following weak rainfall could affect production.



The Economics of Standing Alone

Selling a masterpiece at a time, not a roomful

Auction house Volte Una introduced its inaugural auction as 'One lot, one hour'. On Sunday, when bidding closed, the late Tyeb Mehta's 2002 painting 'Rickshaw Puller' fetched $7.15 mn (₹69.1 cr). The work, depicting a tired rickshaw-wala, carriage and carrier almost fused into one, of course, lies at the centre of what is now the 4th-most-expensive Indian artwork sold at auction. But perhaps more startling is the intriguing reversal in the economics of selling expensive things by this new Indian platform specialising in single-lot sales.

Traditional multi-lot auctions exploit economics of reflected glory. Lesser-known artists or obscure vintages benefit from sharing a catalogue with celebrated names. Bidders arrive for a Ganesh Pyne, and discover someone special but considerably cheaper. Auction houses benefit from economies of scale, spreading marketing and organisational costs across numerous transactions. Single-lot auctions invert this arrangement. No competing masterpiece distracts the buyer. No lesser work dilutes the occasion. Curatorial storytelling, provenance, exclusivity and carefully cultivated anticipation transform an object into an event. Volte Una's model could extend beyond art to exceptional vintage automobiles, rare manuscripts, celebrated musical instruments.... Indeed, private treaty sales and dedicated trophy-asset auctions already exploit variations of this logic. A maharaja's Rolls-Royce may command more attention as the sole attraction than as 'Lot 47' between two Bentleys.

Concentrated marketing *is* expensive. Thin bidding can undermine price discovery. And Mehta's record doesn't, by itself, prove the format caused the premium. Yet, the commercial proposition is compelling. Where supply is genuinely scarce, and buyers exceptionally wealthy, maximising attention may matter more than maximising inventory. Mass markets sell by offering choice, while luxury markets increasingly sell by eliminating it. The ultimate auction catalogue may contain just 1 page. And an extraordinarily large number.

Listen to Consumer Feedback, It Helps

Whether for a company or government, having a system in place that allows for 'consumer' feedback is vital. Acting upon the feedback — especially critical ones — is what makes such entities be trusted, or not. The trick, of course, is to listen *before* complaints become a brand-damaging chorus, as has been the case with SIR. But better late than never, as EC has — lately — demonstrated. Facing heavy criticism over its handling of SIR of electoral rolls, the poll panel reportedly eased verification procedures in Delhi in late September. The result: of the 33 lakh Delhi voters who were issued notices under logical discrepancies/unmapped cases, more than 60% (some 20 lakh) have now had their cases resolved. Booth-level officers (BLOs) are now visiting homes to collect documents, minor discrepancies are being corrected without Byzantine paperwork, and voters needn't always appear for hearings in person. This, EC has stated, was being done under its objective, 'No eligible voter to be left out of electoral roll' promise. Excellent.

EC's turnaround — after 'stakeholder' pressure — extends well beyond electoral rolls. Governments that dismiss public grievances invite dissent. Companies that ignore customer complaints risk losing customers. Airlines that leave stranded passengers without information or assistance turn an operational problem into a reputational one. Institutions must distinguish between defending a legitimate objective and becoming prisoners of the machinery built to achieve it.

Negative feedback isn't an admission of failure, but opportunity for course correction. The customer may not always be right. But treating every complaint as coming from an ill-wisher is hardly a recipe for good business, or governance. Listening is good.

JUST IN JEST

Like in physics, the most cutting-edge of culinary arts should be theoretical

The Proof is in the Pudding, Or is It?

Cooking has suffered for centuries from one tiresome requirement: food must actually be cooked. This insistence on physical execution has held back culinary imagination, shackling gastronomic genius to such vulgar considerations as ingredients, kitchen equipment, temperature and, worst of all, whether anybody would eat the resulting dish. It's time to liberate cuisine from the kadhai. Welcome to theoretical cooking, a new discipline in which recipes are conceived, debated, peer-reviewed and awarded Michelin stars without ever approaching a stove. Much as theoretical physicists need not personally collide particles, theoretical chefs should not be expected to boil potatoes.

A theoretical biryani might contain 37 spices, 6 varieties of rice, and a philosophical objection to saffron. Its excellence would be judged not by taste or presentation, but by conceptual audacity, ingredient compatibility and sophistication of its accompanying explanatory notes. And master chefs could finally concentrate on what they do best: talking about food. Critics (read: gluttons) will complain that cuisine without eating is meaningless. But literature needn't be performed, architecture needn't be built, and economics seldom requires its theories to work. Theoretical cooking's greatest triumph? A perfectly satisfying meal that leaves everyone licking their lips.

Demonstrate why global institutions should allocate capital to Indian firms and not elsewhere

Go On, Show Us the Money!

Joe Wallen

There's nothing to gain from avoiding the numbers. FPIs have withdrawn more than ₹3 lakh cr from Indian equities in the first 9 mths of 2026, already the largest annual exodus of foreign portfolio capital since records began. It's a figure that has caused concern among international institutional and retail investors alike, and understandably, closer to home, in the corridors of power in Delhi.

'There are some concerns. Foreign capital has not been very forthcoming of late,' acknowledged Alok Tiwari, joint secretary in finance ministry's Department of Economic Affairs, in late August. For a country now increasingly viewed as one of the world's great economic powers by East and West alike, there is rightfully cause for unease. Record outflows should prompt introspection after years of seemingly uninterrupted macroeconomic tailwinds around the India Story.

Indian firms must become considerably more sophisticated in international investor relations, transparency and reputation management

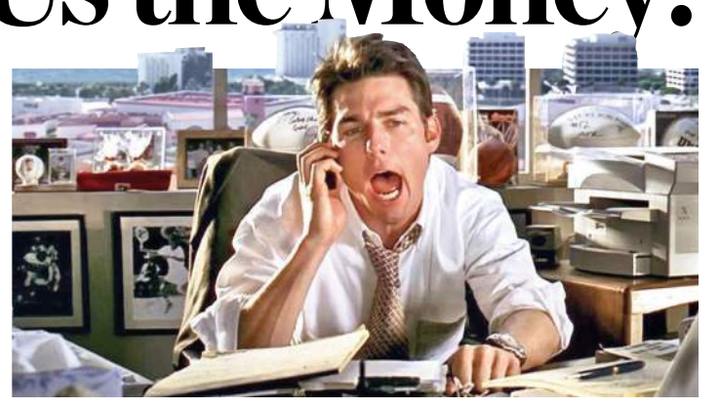
Yet, the investment landscape is nowhere near as gloomy as some headlines suggest. While foreign investors have withdrawn a significant amount of capital from India's secondary equity market this year, they have simultaneously invested more than ₹47,000 cr in Indian IPOs.

So, while we see record levels of foreign portfolio outflows, this year has also seen India become the world's busiest IPO market. The India Story hasn't collapsed. On Tuesday, IMF raised India's growth forecast for 2026-27 to 7%, from 6.4% projected in July. Neither have international investors suddenly stopped believing in India's long-term economic trajectory. PwC's latest global CEO survey found that India had risen to 2nd place among preferred destinations for international investment, level with Germany and Britain, and behind only the US. Instead, global investors are becoming more selective about what they buy, where they invest, and what returns they expect to receive.

In India, foreign investors are simultaneously selling parts of the old economy and buying pieces of the new. They are offloading expensive existing stocks in historically favoured sectors, such as IT and consumer businesses, while securing allocations in new businesses at predetermined prices.

New offerings have increasingly provided access to sunrise sectors including electronics manufacturing, consumer technology and renewables. India is also operating in a very different international investment environment from even a year or two ago.

Rise of contemporary India has seemed inevitable, and the country's proposition to global capital is self-evident, from its enormous consumer market to the opportunity presented to global companies diversifying supply chains away from China. But with the advent of AI, rupee volatility and a host of short-term cyclical factors, India now faces much greater competition for global capital. Simply put, every institutional investor deciding to allocate a dollar, dirham or euro elsewhere is doing so because they view the alternative as more compelling.



India, time to play hard ball

India now faces much greater competition for global capital. Every institutional investor deciding to allocate a dollar, dirham or euro elsewhere is doing so because they view the alternative as more compelling

India's weighting in MSCI Emerging Markets Index fell to 10.87% in June, close to half of its 2024 peak, as international capital shifted towards semiconductor and AI-linked companies in East Asia. Bank of America's August survey of Asian fund managers is perhaps even more telling. India was a net 32% underweight, compared with net overweight positions of 55% in Taiwan, and 50% in Japan. Most strikingly, 28% of respondents identified the lack of a clear AI investment play as their biggest concern about India.

This doesn't mean that Delhi should mirror Taipei or Tokyo. It does, however, expose a considerable disconnect between what is being built in India and what international portfolio investors believe is available to invest in.

Rather than simply offering additional incentives, India and its corporations must better identify, package and articulate opportunities originating from its AI ecosystem and other linked industries. Firms must become considerably more sophisticated in international investor relations, transparency and reputation management.

Fundamentally, they need to demonstrate why international institutions should allocate capital to them rather than to an increasingly compelling universe of alternatives. There is already an encouraging domestic blueprint in smartphone manufacturing. As recently as a few years ago, India had a negligible presence in iPhone manufacturing and exports. Today, iPhone is India's largest branded export, and more than 40 domestic companies form part of Apple's supplier ecosystem.

This transformation did not happen solely because India told one of the world's biggest companies about its enormous population or favourable demographics, but because it identified a strategically important global industry and constructed a clear, investable proposition around it. This gave international capital a reason to choose India. AI and other industries must now do the same.

Long-term, the India Story remains one of the most compelling investment opportunities in the world. But its narrative must mature as oil prices, US bond yields and geopolitics evolve in ways Delhi cannot control. Reputation management must increasingly be understood as part of the competition for international capital. Articulating India's opportunities to global investors and providing evidence, rather than relying on assumption, that its companies and industries offer advantages competing markets cannot.

For years, international investors would worry about missing India's rise. Now, increasingly, India must demonstrate why they should prioritise it.

The writer is partner and India head, Michael Macfarlane Associates

Slow Outflows, Sure, But Inflows?

M C Govardhana Rangan

Inflows of $144 bn in a matter of weeks should ideally have ensured a good night's sleep for Sanjay Malhotra. Instead, it appears to have become a nightmare. Just when the stage was set for a rally in rupee against dollar — now an all-too-familiar pattern during sudden gushes of the greenback — RBI is having to dust off a playbook it uses only during a crisis.

Suddenly, rupee's weakness is the talk of the town. The money market is swimming in cash. RBI's market operations are not helping interest rates to be aligned with its goals. Inflation is round the corner due to sticky oil prices, El Niño and geopolitical disturbances.

Thanks to 'Operation Midnight' late last Saturday, which imposed restrictions on forex transactions, including a risk reserve requirement, RBI seems to have signalled there are fault lines running under the surface of the economy that's growing at 7.8%. Headline growth has papered over external weakness.

These are not actions of a central bank that believes the external sector is in the pink of health. These may change the timing and cost of funding of external trade, but aren't going to eliminate basic demand driven by trade and capital flows.

While GDP numbers, driven by domestic factors, have been holding up, the external sector has been flashing amber — relentless capital outflows and a rising CAD. That RBI had to subsidise investors to bring in dollars through special deposits, captures the state of affairs. Bond yields in the US, Japan, France and Germany are soaring to levels not seen in two decades. India, a net capital importer, can't be blind to such developments around the world.

Overseas investors, who took India to top of the EM heap with the highest premium, are queueing up for exit. They have sold shares worth $61 bn since Oct 2024. The economy may be humming but the plumbing needs fixing.

Indian monetary policy framework, which targets inflation at 4% in a +/–2 percentage point band, was born out of the 2013 taper tantrum crisis when ignoring inflation came home to roost. Although MPC brought credibility, it seems to have acquired a blinkered view of inflation and growth, ignoring the role of interest rates on currency.

More plumbing required

As far as equities are concerned, experts peddling that PE ratio for Nifty below the long-term average of 21× is attractive may be good enough to lure gullible retail investors, but not global investors. India, without an AI trade, is still at a premium to China, South Korea, Indonesia, Brazil and MSCI EM Index.

Saturday's midnight measures can slow outflows. But what's needed is to draw inflows. Forex reserves adjusted for forward book is about $420 bn, enough to fund 6 mths of imports, similar to 2013. Capital flows are driven by returns, and little else. Global risk-free return — US treasuries — are yielding 5.36%. The Indian equivalent is at 7.3%. If historical difference of 450 bps is any guide, this setting won't lure funds.

Scope of MPC needs to be widened beyond inflation and growth to include financial stability. Setting rates on the basis of domestic inflation may meet the mandate, but not a correct one. When price of money has been shooting through the roof everywhere, a quarter-point increase and 'calibrated tightening' stance seem afterthoughts.

The *colour* of FDI is more important than just the FDI. Much of it over the past decade has been in the nature of financial FDI from PE and venture funds, which have a 5-7-yr lifespan. A vibrant market with SIP flows into MFs may have helped them get unseen valuations, but may end up making retail investors the proverbial lambs in a slaughterhouse. GoI needs to prioritise FDI that not only brings in capital to manufacture but also tech, and capital that stays for decades, instead of PE funds that find their way to Haldiram's and diapers-seller FirstCry.

Another thorny issue is taxation. The state may have arguments to retain securities transaction tax (STT), and both long-term and short-term capital gains taxes. But when the need to compete for funds arises, India must be on the same platform as, or better than, its peers.

Rupee may gain in the short run. Last month, US treasury secretary Scott Bessent may have challenged the bond market with his 'I am the house now' line. But the market slid after an initial blip. And that truth about financial markets is universal.

govardhana.rangan@timesofindia.com

Taking the Fear Out of GST

V Anantha Nageswaran & K Balasubramanian

A year ago, GST Council lowered rates and moved to a simpler structure with two main rates. It expected that lower rates would bring more economic activity into the tax base, and that a wider base would support revenue over time.

Figures for the year since Sept 2025 bear this out. Gross GST collection grew by 11.6% in H1 2026, and growth rose to 15% in Q2 2026-27. Average monthly taxable supply between Oct 2025 and Aug 2026 grew 25.6%. Effective tax rate on domestic taxable supply, including exempt supply, fell from 11.74% to 10.84%.

Taxable supply growing by a quarter in one year is well ahead of growth in nominal terms. Part of it is higher activity. Part of it is likely to be earlier existing activity that wasn't reported. A business decides how much of its sales to report on two counts: rate of tax, and expected cost of being visible to the tax administration. Rate rationalisation dealt with the first. The latest GST Council decisions attempt to deal with the second.

The council recommended that power of arrest be removed from GST law. Its presence weighed on genuine businesses, and kept some small traders away from GST altogether. Small traders can now register and grow within the system without that fear. This should bring many more of them into the GST base.

Removing fear doesn't mean ignoring fraud, which, because it can't be eliminated, must have effective deterrence. Fraud must be kept small enough not to compromise the system's integrity. Focus now will be on fewer cases, stronger evidence and faster trials. This gives honest businesses assurance that the law will be enforced fairly, without unnecessary hardship on compliant taxpayers.

Technologically, India is better placed for this today than in 2017. Invoices a seller reports can now be matched against credit a buyer claims. e-Invoices and e-way bills track movement of goods, and analytics can flag a cluster of registrations issuing invoices without any real purchases. Changes to returns now approved by the council will tighten this further.

Now we can hang out

Sales to consumers (B2C) are the next area of focus. Consumers don't claim input tax credit (ITC). So, when a retail sale is not reported, it doesn't show up in invoice matching. A trader may sell goods to consumers without a bill and then issue invoices for the same goods to other businesses that never received them.

In this way, a B2C sale is shown as a B2B sale, and the fake ITC passes to a business not entitled to it. Reported B2C supply rose from ₹45.91 lakh cr in 2022-23 to ₹86.55 lakh cr in 2025-26. Better B2C reporting compliance will widen the tax base and reduce the scope for fraud. e-Invoicing for B2C supplies is expected to be ready for roll-out by Apr 2027.

Nirmala Sitharaman also announced that GoI will move CGST administration for taxpayers spread across several jurisdictions to a centralised, faceless platform. This will make compliance easier for medium and large businesses with a presence in several states. For example, a mid-sized company with units in 5 states may have to deal with 5 different commissionerates. This results in multiplicity of proceedings.

Under the proposed centralised and faceless administration, each issue will be examined once, rather than separately by several offices. Similar cases will be decided in the same way. That consistency is one of the main benefits of a faceless system. I-T and customs already run faceless processes. Their experience shows what works and what needs care. The CGST design will draw on those lessons.

The council's other decisions follow a single approach — moving toward trust-based administration. These include automatic registration amendments, a threshold for notices, correction of return errors, faster refunds and limits on vehicle interception. Trust extended in this way places obligations on both sides. The administration must keep its detection capacity sharper, act on evidence and decide cases on time. Businesses must use the room now given to them responsibly.

If fraud were to rise, the case for harsher tools would return. The reform will last only if both sides keep their part of the bargain.

Significant changes to ITC rules would free up working capital for many firms, especially those facing an inverted duty structure and those exporting. The decision to allow refund of ITC on capital goods would also encourage investment.

Rate rationalisation showed that a lower rate yields more revenue as the base widens, and process reforms rest on the same principle. A business that doesn't fear the tax office is more likely to register, report its full sales and grow within the system.

Nageswaran is chief economic adviser, GoI. Balasubramanian is joint secretary, Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance, GoI

THE SPEAKING TREE

The Invincible Adya Shakti

NARAYANI GANESH

The Markandeya Purana's Devi Mahatmayam, also known as Chandi or Durga Saptashati, narrates the story of how Goddess Ambika was created, in the second canto, Madhyam Charita, verses 6-13. The devas come to Shiv and Vishnu and tell them, how Mahishasur has thrown them out of heaven. 'We seek shelter under you both,' they say. 'May both of you be pleased to think out the means of his destruction.' Hearing this, Vishnu was angry and so was Shiv, and Brahma, whose faces became fierce and full of frowns. A great light issued forth from the angry faces of Vishnu, Shiv and Brahma. The devas witnessed a blazing mountain of light whose raging flames pervaded all quarters. Then, that unique light that emerged from the bodies of angry devas and the teen murtis, its lustre pervading all three worlds, merged into one and thence emerged a fiery female form. Ambika was born. She is also known as Ma Durga who, with her multiple hands carrying weapons of different kinds from the gods, overpowered Mahishasur.

Ambika is really Adya Shakti, the primordial energy force. In a metaphorical sense, her energy is meant to protect us and strengthen our inner nature, making it a great source of internal power. Whether she is invoked as Durga, Kali, Bhagwati or Ambika, she is seen as the provider of strength and confidence, hence, she is shown seated on a tiger or lion, having sublimated negative emotions and forces.

PEAS IN A PODCAST

A Magical Listen

India's multilingualism is a cultural treasure, but it can also keep readers from accessing literary riches beyond their own languages. Literature Trails, a podcast that brings stories from Hindi and Urdu literature to listeners, helps bridge this divide. Featuring celebrated writers such as Munshi Premchand, Saadat Hasan Manto, Bhisham Sahni, Ruskin Bond and Jaishankar Prasad, it offers an opportunity to discover stories that might otherwise remain inaccessible to those who aren't comfortable reading Hindi.

The episode, **Chota Jadugar**, features a short story by Jaishankar Prasad that explores the world through a child's eyes. The story follows a young boy who tries to earn money by performing small tricks at a fair, revealing his resourcefulness and circumstances that shape his life. It offers a glimpse of Prasad's ability to weave human emotion and social realities into a simple narrative. Born in Varanasi in 1889, Prasad was a major figure in modern Hindi literature and theatre, and one of the leading figures of Chhayavaad, the romantic movement in Hindi poetry.

The podcast's appeal lies in making stories accessible to those who may not read Hindi fluently, while reminding us that good stories need no single language to find a home.

Chat Room

Add 'Domestic' To Our GDP

Apropos 'Inches, Not Just Percentages' by Ashish Gupta (Oct 13), economic growth figures often conceal the difference between national progress and household experience. A rising GDP does not necessarily mean that families can afford better housing, quality education or nutritious food. Policymakers should, therefore, look beyond headline growth rates, and examine real wages, employment security, productivity and the cost of essential services. Reliable household surveys can reveal whether prosperity is reaching lower-income groups. Better public healthcare, education and transport can improve living standards without depending entirely on income growth. GDP remains an important measure, but it should inform policy rather than dominate it. Development must ultimately be judged by improvements in people's everyday lives.

K Sakunthala
Coimbatore

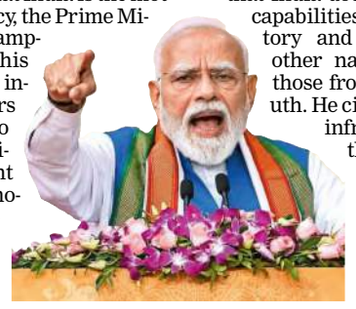
Traditional Wisdom, says PM

▸▸ From Page 1

"It is from here that a new idea emerges and that idea is the Power to Empower," he said. "Beyond power to control lies power to enable. Beyond power to compete lies the power to collaborate. Beyond power to succeed lies power to help others succeed. And therefore, the vision with which I have come here today is Power to Empower."

This has been ingrained in India's traditional wisdom and the real test is in not just preaching but incorporating it in governance, he maintained.

"Let us walk together. Let us speak together. Let us strive to understand one another. Because when we walk together, our strength grows," he said. "Through dialogue, our understanding deepens. And by understanding one another, we can jointly solve great challenges. This is the essence of Power to Empower. It means not limiting our power solely to our own progress but using it to create new opportunities for others as well."



Underlining that India is the mother of democracy, the Prime Minister cited examples to buttress his point. He urged industry leaders from abroad to look at India's digital payment ecosystem, its mobile and internet connectivity and the affordable data that empowers even a small shopkeeper in a remote area to do business and the young to enroll for online courses.

"In our country, a street vendor and a large car showroom may operate at completely different scales, but both use the same digital payments ecosystem. This is the strength of inclusive technology," he said.

The Prime Minister underscored that India does not confine its capabilities to its own territory and shares it with other nations, especially those from the Global South. He cited digital public infrastructure and the Covid vaccine in this regard.

On the power of innovation, Modi said India believes in transforming an idea into a product and turning a problem into a solution. He mentioned the startup revolution in the country, with the number jumping from just a few hundred in 2014 to 250,000 today. More than 45% of these have either a woman heading it or in the leadership.

"When such opportunities reach a larger number of people in society, the balance of power becomes more equitable and its impact multiplies many times over," he said.

The purpose of power is equally important in governance, the Prime Minister asserted, adding that his government has helped in elevating 250 million Indians out of poverty.

"It is clear that whenever the world needs a steady pillar, India extends its hand in support, recognising its responsibility. We do not grow at anyone's cost. We grow with the world, and for the world," the Prime Minister said.

He also referred to the Direct Benefit Transfer scheme and India fulfilling its commitment at COP-21 in Paris on climate change much before the deadline.

India has also contributed to the creation of global platforms such as the Big Cat Alliance, Global Biofuel Alliance, India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor, Missing LiFE and Lifestyle for Environment, he said.

Interest Payment on FCNR(B) Deposits

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"Banks have garnered $133 billion via FCNR(B) deposits, and assuming a 6.5% interest for five years, the coupon outgo could be $40 billion, which is not covered by the RBI facility," said a foreign exchange dealer. "Not all of this interest payment would have been hedged by banks so far, which means that for all the remaining exposure, banks will have to maintain the high FERR."

Over the weekend, the central bank had announced a raft of other measures that included restricting the rebooking of cancelled contracts and imposed a 20% cash reserve requirement on forex derivative contracts above $2 million.

Anshul Chandak, head of treasury, RBL Bank, said regulatory measures to remove all speculative dollar purchases should stabilise the rupee and prevent a sharp depreciation in the currency.

"For banks, it means subdued forex business as it's costly for clients to hedge. It is also to be seen how banks with unhedged exposures on balance sheets deal with the situation given yesterday's announcement on FERR applicability," he said.

Muted Volumes

On Tuesday, banks were reluctant to take fresh dollar positions due to uncertainties on how the new measures will be implemented. Dollar sales by state-owned banks likely on behalf of the RBI also helped the rupee, which climbed 1.56% since its recent low of ₹96.79 per dollar last Thursday.

Bankers said the new measures will have a direct impact on their balance sheets and profitability, particularly after the banking system raised funds through dedicated forex-inflow programmes.

Kospi Slumps 5.5%

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This was because of "hopes (of) possible changes to capital gains taxation and STT, and buying in IT and banking stocks," said Agrawal of SBI Cap. "Reports circulating during market hours about stakeholder feedback on long-term capital gains tax and STT lifted sentiment, although the finance minister's remarks did not amount to an announcement of any tax change."

IT stocks led the gains as technology shares in several Asian markets came under pressure amid renewed concerns over the global AI trade. The Nifty IT index jumped 5.22%, with HCL Technologies surging 8.4%, TCS rising 6.8%, Tech Mahindra advancing 5% and Infosys gaining 4.2%.

South Korea's Kospi slumped 5.5% led by its chipmakers, amid concerns over the durability of the AI-centric rally and rising Chinese competition. Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix were among the biggest losers in South Korea following a report that China's CXMT Corp. had made progress on a new memory architecture being developed by the South Korean chipmakers. Taiwan's Taiex fell 2% and Japan's Nikkei 225 declined 1.8%.

At home, the Nifty mid-cap 150 index rose about 1% and the small-cap 250 index gained 0.3%. Of the 4,591 shares traded on the BSE, 2,415 stocks advanced and 1,957 declined.

The Nifty Realty and Nifty Consumer Durables indices gained 2.5% and 1.6%, respectively. The Nifty FMCG index rose 1.4%, while the Nifty Auto and Nifty Metal indices advanced 1.2% each.

Despite Tuesday's rally, Agrawal identified crude oil prices as the key factor determining the market outlook.

Oil prices fell on Tuesday as investors weighed the prospect of increased Russian energy supplies entering global markets, although concerns over the Saudi-Houthi conflict limited the downside. Brent crude futures slipped 1.3% to $105.24 a barrel on Tuesday.

Stability in the rupee following recent RBI measures was another positive factor, with the currency holding around 94.5 against the dollar, Agrawal said.

Industry Bodies have Sought Postponement

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On September 11, it reported that a rate of about 40 basis points was under consideration. NPCI announced the framework on September 15.

One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

Under the new framework, a 40-basis-point MDR will apply to eligible bank account-to-merchant UPI transactions above ₹2,000, while smaller transactions and exempt merchant categories will continue to remain outside the levy.

ET reported on October 1 that the All-India Mobile Retailers Association and the All-India Consumer Products Distributors Federation had sought a postponement during the festive season, a higher small-merchant exemption threshold and exclusion of merchant-to-merchant payments.

The bodies withdrew their proposed October 2 "No UPI Day" protest after meeting finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on September 30.

More than 95% of UPI merchant-payment transactions by volume are expected to remain free, limiting the charge largely to higher-value transactions. In value terms, industry estimates suggest a significantly larger share of transactions will attract MDR because payments above ₹2,000 account for a sizable portion of merchant-payment value.

UPI INCENTIVES

Govt has budgeted ₹2,000 cr for UPI & RuPay incentives in FY27, significantly below estimated cost of operating the UPI ecosystem

The introduction of MDR marks a shift from the zero-MDR framework under which merchants have not been charged for accepting bank account-based UPI payments.

The government had instead compensated banks and payment companies through an incentive scheme for low-value UPI and RuPay debit-card transactions.

The government has budgeted about ₹2,000 crore for UPI and RuPay incentives in FY27, significantly below the estimated cost of operating the UPI ecosystem. No subsidy has been paid since April 2025.

Next Meeting on Oct 28

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The representatives from the Airline Operators Committee (AOC) and other stakeholders were also present. Jeet Adani, non-executive director of Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL), also held separate meetings with airlines to discuss carrier-specific concerns over the proposed capacity transition, the people said. AAHL runs the two Mumbai airports.

"Jeet Adani and (AAHL CEO) Arun Bansal met with the AOC of Mumbai Airport today," an MIAL spokesperson said. "They have assured the airline community of minimisation of disruption and have assured them of fully respecting historical slots allocations. They have further given a commitment not to disturb any slots for the winter schedule."

A joint working group will devise a plan to implement the redevelopment of ageing Terminal 1 over the next two weeks. Airlines will back this programme from the summer schedule. MIAL will also support any airline seeking to shift operations to Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA).

The two sides will meet again on October 28 and engage with the network and slot teams of carriers in the interim, the spokesperson said.

The postponement follows the civil aviation ministry's intervention after airlines raised concerns over the proposed transition stemming from the inconvenience to them and to passengers. The ministry had sought consultations and a revised transition plan, with the proposed changes raising questions over implementation timelines, slot allocations and operational disruption.

MIAL had proposed discontinuing 265 of the 770 weekly international departure slots at Mumbai airport from October 25 as part of a plan to redistribute traffic between the existing facility and NMIA.

The transition was intended to facilitate the redevelopment of Terminal 1 and balance capacity across the two airports.

The International Air Transport Association (IATA) had called for consultations with airlines, transparent demand-capacity assessments, adequate notice and respect for historical slot allocations. It also called for separate slot coordination processes for Mumbai's existing airport and NMIA.

The deferral avoids a major operational change during the winter schedule, when festive travel and year-end holidays typically support strong passenger demand.

The joint working group will now work towards finalising the implementation plan for the summer schedule.

External Challenges, Uncertainties

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"There's a lot of debate" over the tax commonly known as the securities transaction tax, the minister said, adding that the issue came up during her conversation with investors in India and abroad.

India levies an STT on stock market transactions and also imposes capital gains tax when profits are booked. Market experts have argued that this amounts to double taxation.

There have been comments that both are "running parallel and it's not right; we should have only one of them," Sitharaman said. "So this debate on the tax in the market, debate on securities transaction tax and also the question of treating all asset classes similarly has been a very well-discussed topic." "It's healthy to have this debate, and I will be keenly hearing them," she added.

RUPEE MEASURES

Sitharaman attributed the "very significant" rupee depreciation over the last one and a half years to external challenges and global uncertainties. RBI, over the weekend announced a slew of measures to stem rupee fall, including a special window for oil marketing companies that will take US dollar demand away from the spot market, and tightened rules governing forex derivatives trades to curb speculative bets against the rupee.

"So, these efforts from RBI...will continue – not to, as I said, fix the rupee. We would appreciate it if the rupee finds its own (level)," the minister said. India's macroeconomic fundamentals, including forex reserves, are strong, she added.

"I am sure there are efforts which RBI would further take to make sure the rupee doesn't become too volatile," Sitharaman said. "Within the country, we are making sure we keep macroeconomic fundamentals sound... As regards the rupee, and as regards the way it is reacting to the ups and downs with the dollar, yes, that's where the challenge is, and we will be attending to it."

The government and RBI, in June, announced a slew of steps to attract dollars into the country.

FOREX PUSH

FM attributed "very significant" rupee depreciation over last one and a half years to external challenges and global uncertainties

- The govt and RBI, in June, announced a slew of steps to attract dollars into the country
- Govt extended income tax exemption on interest and capital gains made by foreign portfolio investors in G-secs
- RBI announced a swap facility for foreign currency non-resident (bank) deposits

YOGEESH

ANAND RATHI SHARE AND STOCK BROKERS LIMITED

Registered and Corporate Office: Express Zone, A Wing, 10th Floor, Western Express Highway, Goregaon (E), Mumbai - 400 063, Maharashtra, India

CIN: L67120MH1991PLC064106 | **Website:** www.anandrathi.com | **Email:** secretarial@rathi.com

YoY REVENUE 20% ↑ | EBITDA Margin 37% | YoY PAT 50% ↑

EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF THE UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & SIX MONTHS ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

(In Rs. Millions, except EPS)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Six Months Ended		Year Ended
		30-Sep-2026 (Unaudited)	30-June-2026 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2025 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2026 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2025 (Unaudited)	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)
I	Total revenue from operations	2,732.14	2,461.03	2,272.02	5,193.17	4,283.08	9,321.57
II	Profit before exceptional items and tax	561.53	523.72	375.33	1,085.25	680.31	1,715.73
III	Profit before tax (after exceptional items)	561.53	313.76	375.33	875.29	680.31	1,715.73
IV	Profit for the period (after exceptional items)*	419.39	233.51	279.01	652.90	507.15	1,292.72
V	Total comprehensive income for the period	406.25	236.60	282.18	642.84	511.92	1,285.85
VI	Equity Share Capital	315.33	315.13	313.63	315.33	313.63	313.63
VII	Reserves ((excl Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the audited Balance Sheet of the previous year))	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	13,167.66
VIII	Basic EPS**	6.65	3.71	6.27	10.36	11.40	24.10
IX	Diluted EPS**	6.52	3.63	6.05	10.16	11.00	23.40

***EPS for the stub periods have not been annualised*

EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF THE UNAUDITED STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & SIX MONTHS ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

(In Rs. Millions, except EPS)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Six Months Ended		Year Ended
		30-Sep-2026 (Unaudited)	30-June-2026 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2025 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2026 (Unaudited)	30-Sep-2025 (Unaudited)	31-Mar-2026 (Audited)
I	Total revenue from operations	2,727.37	2,456.83	2,270.85	5,184.20	4,281.02	9,314.91
II	Profit before exceptional items and tax	565.14	525.27	382.19	1,090.41	692.74	1,741.18
III	Profit before tax (after exceptional items)	565.14	315.31	382.19	880.45	692.74	1,741.18
IV	Profit for the period (after exceptional items)*	423.00	235.06	285.87	658.06	519.58	1,318.17
V	Total comprehensive income for the period	408.94	237.23	287.28	646.17	522.39	1,306.47
VI	Equity Share Capital	315.33	315.13	313.63	315.33	313.63	313.63
VII	Reserves ((excl Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the audited Balance Sheet of the previous year))	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	13,216.01
VIII	Basic EPS**	6.71	3.73	6.43	10.44	11.68	24.58
IX	Diluted EPS**	6.58	3.66	6.20	10.24	11.27	23.86

***EPS for the stub periods have not been annualised*

*During the quarter ended June 30, 2026, the Company recognized an exceptional expense for the compensation of loss of ₹ 209.96 million towards the replenishment/restoration of securities to two clients of its Depository Participant (DP) business who suffered losses due to fraudulent off-market transfers from their demat accounts. The aforesaid amount includes the contingent liability disclosed in the quarter ended March 31, 2026, which has been recognised as an expense during the quarter ended June 30, 2026, along with the impact of fraud identified during the quarter ended June 30, 2026 in continuance to the previous fraud. The Company has reported the incident to the relevant authorities, including the Depositories and the Stock Exchanges, and has also lodged an FIR with the Economic Offences Wing ("EOW"). The matter is currently under investigation, and the Company is cooperating fully with the relevant authorities. The Company believes that there has been no systemic failure of internal controls, nor any non-compliance or negligence on its part in relation to the incident. Nevertheless, as a matter of prudence and pending outcome of the investigation, the Company has recognised the related outflow as an exceptional expense in the current quarter.

The EOW has traced the money trail and has attached certain assets and bank accounts of the beneficiaries of the fraudulent transactions. Further, the Company has filed insurance claims to recover the eligible losses incurred. Any recoveries from such claims or through legal proceedings will be accounted for as and when the realization becomes reasonably certain.

Notes:

The above are extracts of the detailed format of unaudited (consolidated and standalone) financial results for the quarter ended September 30, 2026, which have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and thereafter approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on October 13, 2026, subjected to review by the statutory auditors, and filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and 52 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended. The full format of the aforesaid financial results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges (i.e., www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and also on the website of the Company (www.anandrathi.com).

The same can also be accessed by scanning the following Quick Response (QR) Code from compatible devices:

For ANAND RATHI SHARE AND STOCK BROKERS LIMITED
Sd/-
Pradeep Gupta
Chairman and Managing Director
DIN: 00040117

Date: October 13, 2026
Place: Mumbai

Thank You!

Today, we take this opportunity to Thank all our Clients, Investors and our Employees for being a part of our success journey.

www.anandrathi.com

ANANDRATHI

SUITS & SAYINGS

ET's roundup of the wackiest whispers in corporate corridors

High-end Realty

Some wealthy families collect diamonds. Others prefer trophy homes. Even before sales formally opened at the recently announced 65-storey Trump Towers in Hyderabad, a local business family is said to have snapped up four penthouses spread across two floors of a single tower, with plans to combine them into a sprawling 30,000 sq ft residence. At a reported ₹62 crore, the deal is being touted as a record for the city's apartment market. Real estate circles are abuzz with whispers pointing to one of Hyderabad's most powerful business families, whose fortunes were built on big-ticket infra projects. The family is no stranger to palatial living, already owning one of the city's most talked-about private residences. Clearly, when it comes to homes, the sky is no limit.

Talent Venture

From advising businesses to building one. A handful of partners at two marquee consulting and professional services firms are reportedly preparing to swap their cushy consulting roles for the uncertainties of entrepreneurship. The destination? An ambitious new venture in the talent space being put together by a veteran media entrepreneur. Watch this space.

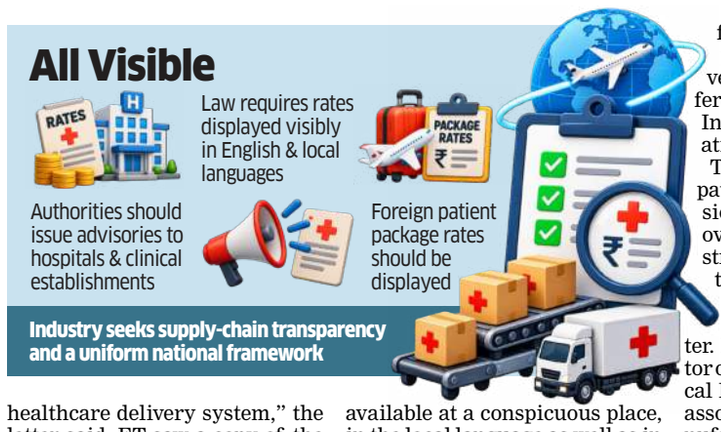
Privy to the whispers in power corridors or juicy tips on India Inc? Do share with us at **etsuits.sayings@timesofindia.com**

CENTRE PUSHES FOR GREATER BILLING TRANSPARENCY

Hospitals, Clinics May Now Have to Display Service Rates Prominently

States and UTs told to ensure compliance; move to help patients make informed decisions

Teena Thacker



New Delhi: In a push to make healthcare billing more transparent, the Centre has asked states and Union Territories to ensure that hospitals and other clinical establishments prominently display the rates they charge for services and facilities.

Clear display of rates helps patients and their attendants understand the likely financial implications of treatment, make informed decisions and plan their healthcare spending, health secretary Punya Salila Srivastava said in a communication to state and UT health authorities.

"It can also help minimise avoidable confusion and billing-related disputes and contribute to greater trust and confidence in the healthcare delivery system," the letter said. ET saw a copy of the letter. The health secretary urged state and UT authorities to review compliance with existing provisions on displaying rates and take appropriate measures to ensure their effective implementation.

Under the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010, and the Clinical Establishments (Central Government) Rules, 2012, establishments covered by the law are required to display the rates charged for each type of service and the facilities available at a conspicuous place, in the local language as well as in English. "Since health is a state subject, implementation and enforcement of the applicable provisions rest with the respective state and UT authorities," the health secretary noted.

States and UTs have their own regulatory frameworks, several of which also contain provisions for displaying service rates, she said. She also told them to issue an advisory to concerned authorities and clinical establishments. The Centre has also called for clinical establishments to prominently display, wherever applicable package rates offered to foreign patients visiting India for medical or Ayush treatment.

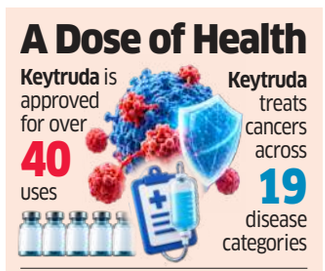
This would help international patients make informed decisions, minimise grievances over pricing and billing, and strengthen India's position as a trusted destination for medical and Ayush care, the health secretary said in the letter. Rajiv Nath, forum coordinator of Association of Indian Medical Device Industry (AiMeD), an association of medical device manufacturers, said it's a patient-friendly step towards transparency.

"To make them fully effective, transparency should cover the whole supply chain, not only the hospital's last point," Nath said. "Margins should be traced from the import landed cost, or the manufacturer's ex-factory price, at the first point of sale, treating GST charged initially on sale to importers as the first point of sale. We urge a uniform national framework, and AiMeD stands ready to help design it," he added.

Zydus' Cancer Biosimilar of 'Keytruda' Gets USFDA Green Light for Review

Co, developing the drug with Formycon, to be among the first to gain access to US market for biosimilar

Rica Bhattacharyya



Mumbai: The US Food and Drug Administration has accepted Zydus Lifesciences' application for review of the world's first publicly announced biosimilar of cancer drug Keytruda (pembrolizumab), a high grossing medicine that makes innovator Merck (MSD in India) over $30 billion a year.

The proposed biosimilar FYB206, if approved, could potentially make the Ahmedabad-based company one of the first to gain access to the US market for pembrolizumab, which is recommended in over 40 FDA-approved indications in about 19 cancer types, including skin, lung, breast and colon cancer.

Zydus holds exclusive commercialisation rights for the US and Canada and brings extensive commercial experience in the North American market for this product.

"Acceptance of the application marks a significant step toward expanding access to affordable pembrolizumab therapy in the US and Canada," said Sharvil P Patel, managing director of Zydus Lifesciences. Zydus is developing FYB206 jointly with Formycon AG, a Munich-based independent developer of biosimilars.

The drug will now undergo a full regulatory evaluation, and the FDA review decision is expected by the third quarter of 2027, Zydus said on Tuesday. "The Biologics License Application (BLA) was submitted in the third quarter of 2026... The regulatory dossier for FYB206 has also been submitted to Health Canada," it said in a statement.

Historically, FDA approval rate of biosimilars accepted for review exceeds 90%, according to biopharmaceutical intelligence platform DrugPatentWatch.

Keytruda (pembrolizumab) is an immune checkpoint inhibitor that binds to and blocks the PD-1 receptor.

In 2025, its worldwide sales, including the subcutaneous formulation Keytruda Qlex, reached $31.7 billion. In the first half of 2026, combined sales of Keytruda and Keytruda Qlex totalled $16.40 billion, which maintains Keytruda's position as the world's best-selling biologic medicine.

Doctors said a Keytruda biosimilar will bring significant benefit to patients.

"Keytruda has broad spectrum indication and has significant benefit in progression free survival," said Sunil Chopade, medical and haemato-oncologist at Mumbai's Jaslok Hospital. "Biosimilars will increase access to the drug by significantly bringing down cost."

Patil recently told ET: "The opportunity (in cancer drugs) is not just about bringing products to market. It is about making these therapies accessible to patients and building capabilities that allow us to participate in the next generation of cancer treatment."

Analysts said it is too early to assess the impact of the development on Zydus as it depends on the actual patent expiry of the product.

While Merck's original patents for Keytruda are set to expire in 2028, the company is said to have filed multiple additional patents that may protect the product a year or two more, analysts said.

For full report, go to www.economictimes.com

Advertising Spends May Keep Growing in High Single Digits

Advertisers exercising cautious optimism during festive period: Publicis Media top exec

Javed Farooqui

Advertisers were initially enthusiastic... but as plans have taken shape, I have seen some caution and delays in approvals
LALATENDU DAS
CEO, South Asia, Publicis Media

Mumbai: India's advertising expenditure growth is expected to remain in high single digits in 2026 amid cautious optimism among advertisers, who are spending cautiously this festive season as businesses continue to recover from the aftereffects of the Gulf war, a top ad industry executive said.

"There is cautious optimism. Advertisers were initially enthusiastic about spending more, but as plans have taken shape, I have seen some caution and delays in approvals," Lalatendu Das, chief executive, South Asia, at Publicis Media, told ET.

He expects this festive season to be broadly on a par with, if not better than, that last year, which benefited from a cut in goods and services tax on many products and services. "However, external uncertainties could affect actual spending," he cautioned.

The festive season is a major business driver for automobiles, electronics and gadgets, beauty and personal care, and home decor. India's annual advertising expenditure (adex) is estimated at ₹1.5 lakh crore to ₹2 lakh crore, with an ad-to-GDP ratio of 0.5%.

Publicis Media led India's new business rankings in the first half of 2026, securing $218 million in total new business, including retentions, and $157 million in net new business, excluding retentions, according to COMvergence, a research and data consultancy.

"The more interesting development is the shift in expenditure. Money is moving from large celebrity-led productions towards creators, and quick commerce is attracting investment from categories such as food, beauty and clothing," he said.

CTV is another growth area, combining television's co-viewing advantage with the convenience of taking action on a phone. "The integration of content and commerce is important, although frequency capping remains a challenge on some platforms," he said. Clients increasingly expect media agencies to move beyond media efficiency to solving business problems, Das said. "It is not enough to offer a better CPM (cost per 1,000 views) or a cheaper media deal," he said.

Clients also want agencies to future-proof their businesses and explain how they will remain relevant three years down the line.

Das said advertising expenditure as a percentage of GDP was the wrong measure, despite India's ad-to-GDP ratio being lower than that of advanced markets such as the US and Europe. "What we need to look at is advertising expenditure in relation to GDP per capita. That is the more relevant measure," he said.

India's advertising expenditure (adex) is estimated at ₹1.5 lakh crore to ₹2 lakh crore, as per industry estimates

India has 50-60 million people with purchasing power comparable to developed-market consumers, another 100-140 million comparable to middle-income countries, and a larger low-income population.

"The challenge is that we may be reaching people through advertising who cannot afford the products being advertised. That does not mean lower-income consumers do not buy anything. They buy smaller packs and affordable products, such as ₹2 shampoo sachets or ₹5 chocolate products," he said. As more people gain the ability to afford products and services, advertising expenditure will increase naturally.

"The growth of advertising is closely linked to the growth of consumer purchasing power," Das said.

NMC Healthcare Founder Files $15-b Lawsuit against BoB

Maulik Vyas & Joel Rebello

Mumbai: BR Shetty, the founder of NMC Healthcare and UAE Exchange, filed a $15 billion suit against Bank of Baroda (BoB), accusing the state-owned lender of colluding with former executives of his business group to siphon off funds that left him facing liabilities on guarantees he said he never signed.

The suit, filed in the Bombay High Court, seeks $5 billion in direct damages for alleged fraud and negligence, $5 billion in consequential damages and $5 billion in compensation for reputational harm arising from various actions taken by the bank, including a lookout circular issued against him.

Shetty also sought 18% interest on the first $10 billion. The suit names Bank of Baroda, several of its current and former officers, former NMC executives, other individuals and companies.

The latest petition by Shetty is linked to a case in the UAE that BoB settled in July by paying $600 million (around ₹5,700 crore) to the administrators of the insolvent NMC and its affiliates. Administrators of the UAE-based healthcare group had accused the bank of facilitating improper transactions in cohort with Shetty, without doing due diligence and following proper anti-money-laundering and customer verification processes.

Suit seeks $5 b for alleged fraud, $5 billion in consequential damages and $5 billion for reputational harm

The bank agreed to settle the case without admission of liability or wrongdoing. The settlement agreement and its terms otherwise remain confidential. The liability of the bank in these proceedings is limited to this sum, BoB had said in a statement.

Waseem Pangarkar and Abhishek Gupta of MZM Legal, which represents Shetty, confirmed filing of the suit but refused to provide details, saying that the matter was sub judice. BoB did not reply to an email seeking comment.

NMC Health was declared insolvent in 2020 after it was found to have allegedly hidden more than $4 billion of debt. Creditors to the company included BoB, Abu Dhabi Commercial Bank, Abu Dhabi Islamic Bank, Dubai Islamic Bank and Emirates NBD.

Shetty's suit alleges that the bank's officers helped structure and document these transfers to withstand scrutiny and that its systems generated more than 100 money-laundering alerts that were subsequently closed.

'D2C Brands Need Distribution Shift to Scale Up to ₹500 crore'

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: India's challenger brands, newer or emerging D2C brands, can reach ₹100 crore in revenue within a few years, but growing to ₹500 crore requires a shift in distribution and marketing, according to a report by WPP Media, Google and Elevation Capital, in partnership with Kantar.

Ashwin Padmanabhan, chief operating officer of WPP Media South Asia, said digital and commerce platforms help brands reach consumers already looking to buy. However, further growth requires brands to expand distribution and reach audiences beyond existing buyers.

"These brands grow quickly by tapping into existing demand through digital and commerce platforms. But to scale further, they need to expand their distribution and create new demand. That is when they start competing with the big boys," Padmanabhan said.

The report, The Disruptor's Toolkit, identifies five areas shaping challenger brands' growth: brand positioning, credibility, creative strategy, channel mix and media activation. It divides the growth journey into three stages: anchoring (₹0-150 crore), acceleration (₹150-300 crore) and institutionalisation (₹300-500 crore).

Chirag Chadha, partner at Elevation Capital, said the time taken by challenger brands to reach ₹100 crore had shortened considerably.

"Journeys to ₹100 crore that once took two decades now take two to four years, and the brands pulling ahead are those that own a sharp consumer need before earning the right to go wider," Chadha said.

The report also examines the role of brand advertising alongside performance marketing.

WPP Media learnings cited in the report show that consumers exposed to both have 1.8 times higher conversion rates than those exposed only to direct-response performance ads.

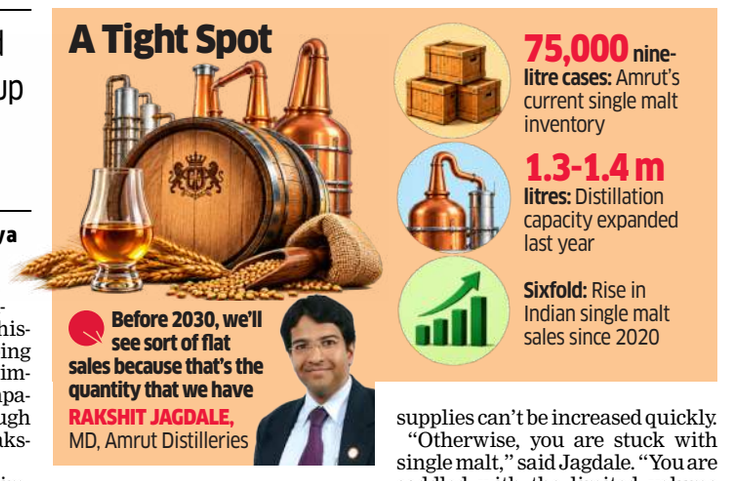
Satya Raghavan, director, marketing partners, Google India, said consumers were researching brands more deeply before purchasing, using AI-powered search experiences and creator reviews.

"Indian shoppers are eager to try new brands, but curiosity always comes with a verification step," Raghavan said. He added that YouTube shopping watch time had risen 55% year on year.

'Whisky Shortage, Cheaper Imports to Weigh on Amrut's Sales Through 2030'

Distiller looking beyond single-malt, eyeing tie-up with Mexican cos for tequila brand, says MD

Aanya Thakur & Sagar Malviya



Mumbai: Amrut Distilleries, India's single malt pioneer, is facing an inventory shortage as whisky demand is sharply outstripping production. This is expected to impact the Bengaluru-based company's growth performance through 2030, said managing director Rakshit Jagdale.

At the same time, increased imports of cheaper Scotch due to India's free trade pact with the UK will likely weigh on sales of domestic whisky brands especially of newer blended whiskies, he said.

"Before 2030, we'll see sort of flat sales because that's the quantity that we have," Jagdale told **ET**. "We cannot increase the quantity."

Amrut, which has a single malt inventory of 75,000 nine-litre cases, expanded distillation capacity to 1.3-1.4 million litres last year. It however can't significantly boost output in the near term as Indian single malt requires at least three years of maturation.

With production constraints limiting its ability to expand sales, Amrut is broadening its portfolio beyond single malt. It has introduced blended malt whisky to tap the luxury spirits market without relying entirely on a category in which supplies can't be increased quickly.

"Otherwise, you are stuck with single malt," said Jagdale. "You are saddled with the limited volume that you can supply the market."

Prices of some imported Scotch brands have dropped over 15%, affecting Amrut's sales in North India. For now, the company is holding off on major price cuts while assessing the impact of India-UK FTA. Amrut sells rum and brandy and is exploring a tie-up with Mexican distilleries to develop its own tequila brand, potentially starting with bottling in Mexico before considering a shift to India, said Jagdale. It is also planning a more affordable single malt priced about 15% below its Fusion brand in North India before December.

Amrut and Paul John were the first Indian single-malt brands, launched in the 2000s, followed by the likes of Rampur, launched by Radico Khaitan about a decade ago. However, in the past few years, the market has seen a flurry of new single-malt distillers like Piccadily Agro's Indri and Kamet as well as global liquor companies including Pernod Ricard and Diageo adding their own Indian brands such as Longitude 77 and Godawan.

Jagdale expects six or seven more Indian distilleries to enter the single malt market, increasing competition in a category that has attracted consumers seeking alternatives to imported whisky.

He criticised India's fragmented alcohol taxation system, saying differences in state levies and registration fees can disadvantage domestic producers. Jagdale cited differences in taxation between imported bottled-in-origin spirits and Indian single malts, arguing that local distillers should get equal treatment in their home market.

India Keeps Crown as World's Most Mature Flexible Office Mkt

Share of bookings rises to over 10% as country's office stock touches nearly 89 million sq ft in first half of the year amid sustained occupier demand, finds report

Faizan Haidar

New Delhi: India's share of global bookings of coworking space increased to 10.2% in the first half of calendar 2026 from 2.2% a year earlier, making it the second-most active market globally after the US. India also retained its position as the world's most mature flexible office market with a 100% score on commercial real estate consultancy Cushman & Wakefield's flexible office market maturity index.

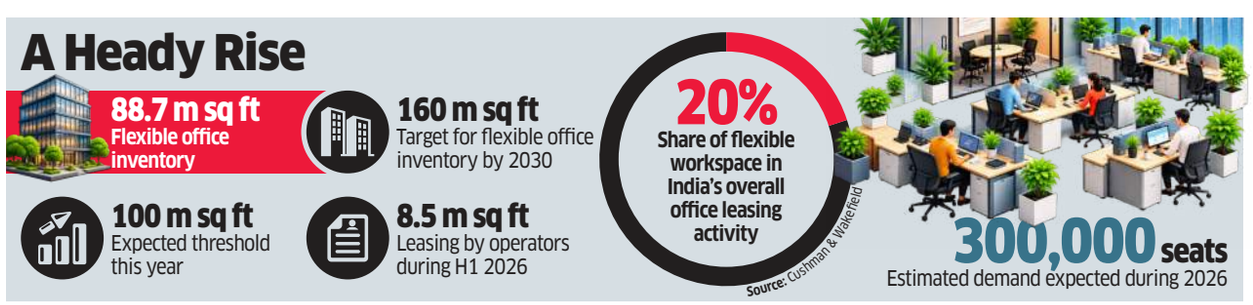
"Flexible offices today can support businesses across the lifecycle of their real estate requirements, from establishing a presence to scaling teams and managing longer-term portfolio needs. More importantly, we are seeing demand, capital and product quality advance together, which is creating a stronger foundation for sustained growth," said Ramita Arora, executive managing director, Bengaluru and head of Flex, India, at Cushman & Wakefield.

The index is a scoring system that assesses flexible office markets across a range of indicators (market size, leasing activity, operator presence, workplace formats, landlord participation, operating models, managed space adoption, market transparency and tenant demand). Markets are scored and normalised to enable comparison across global regions and identify the world's most mature flexible office ecosystems.

India's flexible office inventory reached 88.7 million sq ft in H1 2026, accounting for 10.5% of the country's total office stock, according to an analysis of nearly 23,000 on-demand bookings by hybrid work management platform Upflex. The market is expected to cross the 100 million sq ft mark in 2026 and expand to approximately 160 million sq ft by 2030, nearly doubling from current levels as operators continue expanding to meet growing enterprise demand. Cushman & Wakefield's report cites Upflex data.

"Greater institutional participation is bringing long-term capital and discipline into the sector, while evolving occupier expectations are pushing operators towards higher-quality, more sophisticated offerings. With newer demand pools also emerging, including AI-led businesses, the opportunity for flex is becoming both broader and more enduring," Arora said. The expansion is being underpinned by sustained occupier demand. Flexible office operators leased 8.5 million sq ft in India's top eight cities in H1 2026, their strongest ever first-half performance. Flexible workspace now accounts for around 20% of overall office leasing in India. Between 2023 and 2025, operators leased 44.1 million sq ft, or more than 720,000 flex seats, Cushman said in its report.

Managed office requirements averaged between 350 and 500 seats. At the same time, seat demand has expanded consistently despite periods of macroeconomic volatility—growing nearly sevenfold from around 38,000 seats in 2020 to an estimated 300,000 in 2026, it said.



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BENGALURU, WEDNESDAY, 14 OCTOBER 2026

SMART INVESTING

SIFs Gain Ground: Should Investors Explore Them?

NIFTY IT INDEX LOGS HIGHEST ONE-DAY GAIN IN 17 MONTHS

Mood Swing: AI Hits a Bump, Indian IT Stocks Get a Jump

MOMENTUM BUILDS HCL Tech's Q2 earnings, stronger dollar also provide a lift

Himadri Buch

Mumbai: Indian IT stocks surged on Tuesday, with the Nifty IT index jumping 5.2%, its biggest single-day gain in about 17 months, as HCL Technologies' September quarter earnings reassured investors about demand for software services. A selloff in Asian semiconductor stocks amid concerns over the durability of the heavy investments in AI also lifted sentiment in the sector. The software services industry is considered among the biggest casualties of AI adoption.

All 10 constituents of the Nifty IT index ended higher. HCL Technologies led the gains, surging 8.42%, followed by Tata Consultancy Services at 6.8%, Coforge at 4.46% and Infosys at 4.13%. The rally helped the Nifty 50 advance 1.6% to 22,721.95, while the Sensex rose 1.54% to close at 73,033.78.

"For the Indian IT sector, the pace of global AI adoption over the next 2-3 years remains a key concern for earnings growth and valuations," said Krishna Sanghavi, CIO Equity, Mahindra Manulife Mutual Fund. "However, if questions arise globally around the commercial viability of AI, potentially slowing its rollout, market concerns over Indian IT companies could ease," he said.

HCL's second quarter net profit rose 21.2% year-on-year, beating analyst expectations. The earnings performance eased investor sentiment, which has been weighed down by concerns about AI-led disruption and slowing growth in traditional software services.

A stronger dollar provided additional support to Indian IT exporters, which earn a substantial share of their revenues in foreign currencies.

The Nifty IT Index is still down over 21% so far this year as against the 13% decline in the Nifty.

The Nifty IT index also broke above the 27,614–28,755 range in which it had traded between September 24 and October 12, according to Sudeep Shah, head - Technical and Derivatives Research at SBI Securities. "The RSI is trending higher and approaching the 60 mark, signalling renewed bullish momentum. The zone of 28,600–28,500 is likely to act as immediate support, and the index may extend its pullback as long as it sustains above this zone," Shah said.

On Tuesday, South Korea's Kospi slumped 5.46%, weighed down by losses in Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix, while Taiwan's Taiex declined about 2% as TSMC shares weakened.

"The sector may remain positive in the near term, supported by improving sentiment and buying interest following HCLTech's results, but after a sharp single-day rally, some profit-booking and volatility cannot be ruled out," said Gaurav Garg, head - Research, Lemonn.

Garg advised investors against chasing the rally, recommending a focus on companies with strong earnings visibility, healthy deal conversion and stable margins.

Earnings Spark Rally

Company	Tuesday Close	% Change 1 Day	1 Mth	3 Mths	In 2026
HCL Technologies	1,326.0	8.4	5.8	8.6	-18.3
Tata Consultancy Services	2,269.3	6.8	0.8	4.0	-29.2
Tech Mahindra	1,543.5	4.9	-2.1	2.6	-3.0
LTM	4,215.0	4.9	-3.0	2.2	-30.5
Mphasis	2,466.3	4.8	3.7	3.2	-11.6
Coforge	1,929.0	4.5	8.6	25.2	16.0
Wipro	169.0	4.4	-0.6	-5.3	-35.8
Infosys	1,062.1	4.1	-1.4	-3.7	-34.3
Persistent Systems	5,988.0	3.5	9.3	15.3	-4.5
Oracle Financial Services	10,640.0	2.7	-9.9	-9.4	38.4
Nifty IT	**29,830.1**	**5.2**	**0.9**	**2.8**	**-21.3**

Compiled by: **ETIntelligence.com**

Q2 Call GQG Pulls More Money from Adani Cos, Other FPIs Mix It Up

Stakes Shrink

GQG Holdings in Adani Group Companies

	No of Shares (in cr) Sep Qtr	Jun Qtr	Chg	Stake Sale Value (₹Cr)
Adani Energy Solutions	2.1	5.0	-2.9	-3,792
Adani Enterprises	2.5	2.7	-0.2	-607
Adani Ports	4.0	4.4	-0.5	-854
Adani Power	76.0	83.3	-7.4	-1,500
Adani Green	5.3	6.3	-1.0	-1,267
Total				**-8,020**

Source: **BSE shareholding pattern data**

Ravindra Sonavane

Mumbai: GQG Partners, a US-based investment firm, continued to pare its holdings in Adani Group companies in the September quarter, cutting stakes worth an estimated ₹8,000 crore across five group stocks. The selling came amid mixed trends in foreign portfolio investor (FPI) ownership, with overseas investors raising their stakes in some Adani companies even as they reduced exposure to others.

The firm, founded by Rajiv Jain and managing assets of more than $156 billion, attracted widespread attention in 2023 when it bought stakes in Adani Group companies amid a selloff following allegations by US short-seller Hindenburg Research.

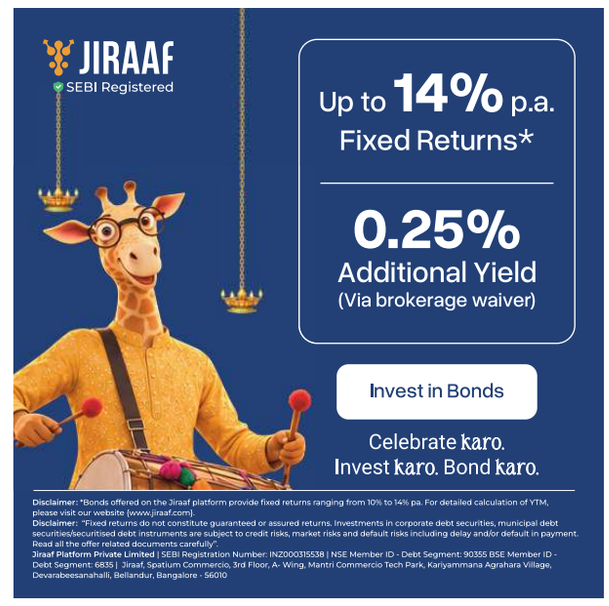
GQG's latest reductions follow estimated stake sales worth around ₹13,200 crore in the first six months of 2026. In contrast to GQG's selling, overall FPI holdings rose in Adani Enterprises and Adani Ports during the September quarter, while declining in Adani Power, Adani Green Energy and Adani Energy Solutions.

GQG's biggest reduction during the quarter was in Adani Energy Solutions, where its stake fell to 1.71% from 4.14% in June. The market value of GQG's holdings across Adani Group companies stood at around ₹39,270 crore at the end of September, compared with ₹47,290 crore a quarter earlier.

During January-June 2026, Adani Enterprises accounted for GQG's largest estimated stake reduction at around ₹6,375 crore, followed by Adani Green Energy and Adani Power.

Market value of GQG's holdings across Adani Group cos stood at ₹39,270 cr at Sept end

Overall FPI holdings showed a mixed trend during the September quarter. Foreign investors reduced their stakes in Adani Power, Adani Green Energy and Adani Energy Solutions, while increasing their holdings in Adani Ports, Adani Enterprises and Adani Total Gas. Mutual funds also showed a mixed pattern. Their holdings declined in Adani Enterprises, Adani Ports and Ambuja Cements, while increasing in Adani Energy Solutions, Adani Power and Adani Green Energy.



Tech Picks | NAGARAJ SHETTI, Senior Technical Research Analyst | HDFC Securities

ATHERENERG — BUY TARGET ₹1,570
Near a larger consolidation breakout, with higher weekly highs & lows and positive daily/weekly RSI.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹1,490 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹1,445

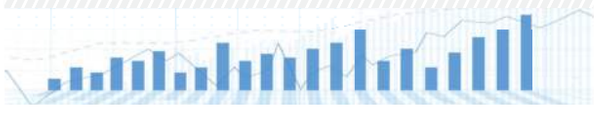
BSOFT — BUY TARGET ₹312
Recent double-bottom formation, at downtrend-line breakout, with rising volumes on the upside.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹297 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹289

ZENSARTECH — BUY TARGET ₹505
Recently broke downtrend resistance and is nearing a crucial breakout above the 20-week EMA.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹480 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹467

F&O Strategy | NANDISH SHAH, Senior Technical & Derivative Analyst

PNB FUTURE (27 OCT EXPIRY) — BUY TARGET ₹122
Long build-up signals a positive short-term trend, with price up 0.5% and open interest up 2%.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹117.75 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹115

PERSISTENT FUTURE (27 OCT EXPIRY) — BUY TARGET ₹6,350
Long build-up, with price up 3.5% and OI up 8%, alongside a daily chart breakout.
LAST CLOSE ▸ ₹5,990 STOP LOSS ▸ ₹5,750



'Let Rupee Find its Own Level'

Mumbai: Veteran banker Uday Kotak on Tuesday said the rupee should be allowed to find its own level, asserting that the underlying strength of the Indian economy will reflect in the currency over time.

"My personal view is we should let the rupee find its own level, and over time, the true strength of the economy will play out," he said at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum 2026.

Kotak said the situation should serve as an important signal for India to strengthen its competitiveness, improve efficiency and self-reliance, and invest more in research and innovation.

He mphasised the importance of allowing market forces to determine currency levels without creating expectations about a particular level that policymakers might seek to defend. **PTI**

COS GET MORE TIME TO NAVIGATE MARKET VOLATILITY

Sebi Extends IPO Size Flexibility by 6 Months

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India on Tuesday extended by six months the latitude, initially given to companies seeking a listing, to either increase or decrease the size of their issue without fresh regulatory approvals.

This allows such companies to negotiate market volatility without having to incur inflated compliance costs related to a listing. The relaxation will apply to initial public offerings (IPO) opening on or before March 31, 2027. Earlier, the exemption was available for prospectuses filed until September 30, 2026.

Under the revised framework, lead managers can file an updated offer document reflecting changes in the issue size, provided the main object of the issue remains unchanged. The relevant sections of the DRH prospectus must be updated and an addendum made public.

They would also be required to ensure compliance with Sebi regulations, conduct due diligence and provide justification for the revision.

SEBI PROPOSES FINE FOR NON-COOPERATION ▸▸ ON PAGE 11

AIBI in a statement said the relaxation followed its representations to Sebi on challenges faced by issuers and merchant bankers when changes to fresh issue sizes become necessary. The measure will improve efficiency in capital raising while allowing companies to respond to evolving business needs and market conditions.

The Rupee Matrix Reloaded

ET EXPLAINER

Atmadip Ray

Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has taken a slew of steps since Saturday to help lift the rupee to what Governor Sanjay Malhotra described as its "correct" value. These measures have helped the rupee recover to 95.28 a dollar, about 150 paise over two days. An immediate fallout is the reduction in speculative bets on the currency and discouraging over-hedging by companies in anticipation of further rupee depreciation. An inevitable inflation in hedging costs, a natural outcome of the reserves to be set aside by banks against client exposures, has caused some noses to wrinkle in the importer community.

Separately, total removal of the dollar needs of three state-run fuel retailers from the spot rupee market reduces the pressure on the currency.

Here's an **ET** explainer on the measures taken by the central bank and their impact.

INTRODUCTION OF FOREIGN EXCHANGE RISK RESERVE (FERR)

A first-time measure imposing a 20% cash reserve requirement on large forex derivatives contracts over $2 million. This means banks will have to set aside funds as a percentage of their total exposure, and that money will no longer be available for onlending until the exposure is fully cancelled.

For instance, for a $10 million hedging contract for a client, a bank will have to keep around ₹19 crore everyday with the central bank until the expiry of the contract. This money is not available for lending.

Hence, banks will have to pass on this cost to their clients. This would inflate the hedging cost for importers by at least 150 basis points (one basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point) and, therefore, they would be discouraged to hedge their exposure, experts said.

FERR IMPACT ON THE FORWARDS MARKETS

Another fallout of the FERR curbs is an immediate cut in the rates on forward premium, as the aggregate demand for hedging itself would reduce. Since importers would keep open positions, it would ultimately soften forward premium rates, currency experts believe. Softening forward premiums will also help reduce pressure on the spot rupee in the local market.

However, a section of the importers is worried their cost would climb significantly as the funds needed to hedge will eat into their working capital buffers, potentially requiring them to borrow to plug the gap.

EXTENSION OF FERR RESTRICTIONS FOR CONTRACTS WITH OVERSEAS ENTITIES

The regulator Monday widened the ambit of FERR, extending the rule for non-deliverable contracts involving rupee to non-resident customers, only for the purpose of hedging. The move also eliminates the probability of dollar hoarding by companies and importers because of the steep FERR costs, limiting their dollar exposure to genuine and foreseeable business needs.

THRESHOLD FOR FOREIGN EXCHANGE DERIVATIVE TRANSACTIONS REDUCED

The limit has been reduced to $5 million equivalent from $100 million across all authorised dealers. This will curb speculative trading in the rupee. A corresponding reduction has been introduced in exchange-traded currency derivatives involving the rupee, across stock exchanges taken together.

RESTRICTIONS ON REBOOKING OF CANCELLED FOREIGN EXCHANGE DERIVATIVE CONTRACTS

Banks cannot allow users to rebook any previously cancelled foreign exchange derivative contract involving the rupee — whether deliverable or non-deliverable. Rollover of foreign exchange derivative contracts on maturity shall continue to be permitted.

SPECIAL DOLLAR WINDOW FOR STATE-RUN OIL RETAILERS

The RBI would use its own dollar stockpile to meet the daily dollar needs of Indian Oil Corp, Bharat Petroleum Corp and Hindustan Petroleum Corp. This reduces dollar demand in the spot market, easing the pressure on rupee.

This would also mask the underlying pressure on balance of payments while dollars will be drained from the central bank's foreign exchange reserves. The Reserve Bank of India opened this window Monday, albeit for a temporary period.

STRICTER VERIFICATION

RBI tells banks to obtain additional documentation for verification of underlying exposures. This will prevent users from entering into foreign exchange derivative contracts involving the rupee to hedge contracted exposures, using the same underlying exposure that has been hedged with any other bank. Banks have to keep the documents for a minimum two-year period.

OVERALL VIEWS OF FOREX MARKET AND TREASURY PROFESSIONALS

Economists see these measures as tactical steps to support the rupee, not structural solutions ensuring its durable stability. They believe that defending the rupee amid the continued geopolitical headwinds would be a costly policy trade-off, requiring broader capital market reforms to encourage stable and long term foreign capital inflows.

India still levies a security transactions tax, even when the long-term capital gains tax was reintroduced in 2018, and increased it to 12.5% last year. Experts suggest a broader response spanning lowering of taxes, exchange-rate flexibility and further monetary policy tightening to bolster the rupee.

ET Q&A **JONATHAN GRAY**
COO, BLACKSTONE

IT services cos are much more adaptable than people realise. They have moved from just providing services to AI deployment cos

After US, India is the Easiest Place to List a Company

India is the best performing market for Blackstone, chief operating officer Jonathan Gray told **Sruthijith KK** in an interview. The world's largest alternative asset manager aims to double its investment in India to $100 billion, he said, adding that the sentiment on the country is still positive. Edited excerpts:

ROHIT MAHESHWARI

From your perch, what are two causes for concern about the global economy and two for optimism?
Obviously the wars in Russia, Ukraine, as well as West Asia, which are causing commodity prices to go up. Agricultural prices are impacted, and that has pushed central banks... part of the reason they've had to move to raise rates as opposed to lowering. That ties to my second concern–the rising cost of capital. Interest rates around the world are going up. We've seen 10-year treasuries in the US go up by 80 bps in the third quarter. In Europe, we've seen a pretty significant rise, particularly in France. This is really a combination of the war, or the wars, and the inflation caused by that, as well as concerns around government deficits.

Add to the mix this huge AI capex build and what that is doing in terms of demand for capital. All of that will likely lead to multiples coming down a bit for assets. That's the major impact.

On the positive side, I would say two things. One is we still see a lot of economic momentum. In the US, very strong revenue growth at our companies. In India, strong revenue growth. The second thing is AI diffusing into the economy, and the productivity we're beginning to see at our companies, which is pretty remarkable.

On the AI infrastructure build-out, is this investment sustainable? McKinsey's State of the AI report earlier this year said adoption is deepening, but enterprise returns are flatlining. We're also seeing some concern with AI debt...
Whenever you have a large innovation and then capital flowing towards it, there's a risk that things go out of kilter. First off, the demand is just continuing to grow, and I would say at our companies, the returns on investment seem remarkable. They're finding new ways to use this technology. We have a garage door opening company that's using AI visualisation tools to recognise when the package is coming from Amazon, then automatically opening the door. They've created a $50 million business that they think will be a $500 million business.

We're finding use cases in legal and accounting and all these different areas, and our teams at times can find it difficult to get this deployed, to get the technology right. If you think about a classic bubble–telecom infrastructure in the 90s–the supply was built with leverage well in advance of the demand. It turned out to be excessive, and ultimately there were a lot of losses.

In this case, most of this is being built out by the biggest companies in the world who have very healthy balance sheets. What we're seeing is demand is running ahead of supply, and the supply of compute is constrained by getting entitlements, getting a power plant, getting turbines, getting chips, amassing capital. We have a fundamental shortage of compute, and that is supporting the value. Most of this is now being contracted by very large companies such as Microsoft, Amazon, Google.

How does the firm view the Indian economy in the medium and long term?
Start with the short term. Obviously, there's been some negativity because the wars have driven up energy costs. There's been some pressure on IT services valuations with concerns about AI disruption and the market was trading at a very high multiple here. We've seen the sentiment in India, people have gotten overly negative, (but) when you look at the medium and longer term, you've got an economy that's growing at 7%-plus, a very young population.

CURRENCY DEPRECIATION HAS BEEN THE OTHER HEADWIND FOR GLOBAL INVESTORS. THAT'S PROBABLY THE BIGGEST QUESTION WE GET ABOUT INDIA

There's a lot of things that give India an edge over time, and I see it as the fastest-growing major economy for many decades to come. As an investor with a long-term perspective, we say this is actually a pretty good moment. As the market's pulled back, that creates a better entry point for us. We take a long-term view. I remember back after the financial crisis, most investors were saying, "Oh, India, gosh, I don't wanna do that." We stuck through it. That turned out to be the right decision. This is nothing like that. But again, if you look at the long-term fundamentals of this economy–the rising middle class, the opportunities that will create, India's opportunity to be more of a manufacturing powerhouse globally–there are a lot of interesting places to deploy capital.

You mentioned IT services and pressure on the sector. How do you see that playing out?
I think these IT services companies are much more adaptable than people realise. They've moved from just providing services to be AI deployment companies. If you think about most enterprises, it's not like I could hand you Claude code or Codex and say, "Change your business. Make your company different."

You need a partner to come in and say, "This is how you're going to change your workflow. This is how you're going to do your financial reporting." India, given its strength in IT services, is a natural to help bridge this world. I also think there's a big opportunity in India in the infrastructure we were talking about earlier. We've got AirTrunk here to do hopefully sizeable things in the data centre space. We invested in Neysa, which is a neo cloud.

Blackstone has had a tremendous run in India–you have $50 billion deployed here. What has helped you succeed?
Well, it starts with the people. Amit Dixit, who runs our private equity business, Tuhin Parekh, who runs our real estate business, have been with us now for several decades. They've really been builders of businesses. They've started with things that are very small or started from scratch.

They've decided to start with something small, add capacity to it, maybe do additional acquisitions, put in place world-class management teams, ultimately take these businesses public. We've taken 14 companies public in India, five of the six REITs. We helped create the REIT rules here, working with this government that's done such a good job.

What can you tell us about Blackstone's road map in terms of investments?
It will definitely be playing this rising middle class. People are going to travel more. They're going to consume more financial services. Healthcare certainly is going to be high on their list. We're developing housing. We've invested in financial institutions who finance housing. All the things that happen as you move from a country with a very low GDP per capita, and many of those people move up, they're going to want to consume. Providing those services is really important. I think this AI build-out is critically important. I think energy, which is an area India's made a lot of progress in.

The Prime Minister talked about progress in the solar space. I think renewables are very exciting. The digital infrastructure, the data centres and compute are really important.

You have $50 billion invested in India. How much would you like that figure to be?
In five years, we'd love that number to be $100 billion. Now we've got to find great businesses. It could be in private equity, could be in real estate. We're going to be expanding here in infrastructure. We're looking to expand in credit. I think growth equity is an opportunity. I think there's more we can do in more sectors. As the Indian market grows, it really works well for our business. People in India don't fully appreciate just how strong your capital markets have become. The stock market's up five and a half times in the last 20 years. It is probably, after the US, the easiest place to list a company, and that is very good for foreign capital because when you think about investing money, and in particular our drawdown funds, we've got to send the capital back to our investors. So the fact that India has a robust public market is very helpful. It's another reason we have a lot of confidence here.

In August, we sold more than a billion dollars of stock in a company, Knowledge Realty. To do a billion-dollar secondary speaks of the scale of this market, that there is real liquidity, and that is definitely helping our investors. It's helping investments here. And

If you think about a classic bubble –telecom infra in the 90s– the supply was built with leverage well in advance of demand. It turned out to be excessive, and ultimately there were a lot of losses. In case of AI infra, most of this is being built out by the biggest cos in the world. Demand is running ahead of supply

CAUSE FOR CONCERN: A COMBINATION OF THE WAR, OR WARS, AND INFLATION CAUSED BY THAT, AND GOVT DEFICITS. ADD TO THE MIX THIS HUGE AI CAPEX BUILD & IMPACT ON DEMAND FOR CAPITAL

so even as the stock market has pulled back here, the liquidity has really been maintained. And again, I think the government is continuing to make the market easier to access, yes, for foreign investors.

There is some concern that we're seeing in terms of public markets in India. In 2026 alone, foreign portfolio investors have pulled out $37 billion...
Public market investors can be fickle. There was a simple narrative last year, which is that India is an importer of a lot of energy, and energy costs are going up, and that made investors cautious. India has exposure to IT services—AI's coming. Simple narratives get established and then as money comes out, the market obviously has underperformed. But the public market can fall back into love again too. If the earnings growth, which I think is expected this quarter to be mid-teens, continues, the revenue and earnings growth, then you'll see global investors come back.

When you market your own funds and products to your LPs, are you facing any pushback? What is the sentiment about India like among global investors?
The sentiment is still fairly positive. Global investors recognise there aren't that many global firms who have boots on the ground who are capable of executing at scale. They want exposure to private market assets in India, but there's a relatively small number of firms who can access it. The currency depreciation has been the other headwind for global investors. That's probably the biggest question we get about India. But I think there's increasingly more and more belief that this story has real legs.

You're significantly invested in software services, data centres, AI infrastructure, healthcare. Any other sectors or themes that have caught your fancy?
Well, definitely travel, the hotel business. We invested in a visa processing business, VFS. We think foreign travelers are going to come to India more and more, particularly as the infrastructure improves. The airports here–most people who come to India for the first time are shocked when they see the first-class nature of the airports now. As the roadways get better, travel is an area. Definitely energy in every form that you can come by. And, manufacturing will continue to be important.

Financial services certainly, because you have an economy where you're just starting to get people into markets. More and more people, as they get wealth, are going to look to invest, save, buy a house.

You've taken a minority position in Federal Bank. We've been hearing murmurs about other Blackstone deals in the financial services space. Is that an area you're beginning to get excited about?
For sure. We've had success with Aadhar in the home lending business, ASK in the wealth management business. I just think that's a natural part when you get this sort of increasing GDP, increasing wealth. Financial services are something that people begin to access. The banking system, the stock market, there'll be all sorts of things. The insurance industry offers opportunities as well.

Between Blackstone, KKR, Bain, Brookfield and EQT, some $50 billion have been raised for Asia funds. Typically, a third of that tends to come to India. Are there enough quality companies and scale opportunities to absorb so much capital?
The Indian economy is now over $4 trillion. The stock market is over $5 trillion. When you think about those as the denominator, as the potential pool of investable assets, this is a place that can absorb a fair amount of capital, certainly relative to the amount of money raised in other parts of the world. I would say we are constantly pushing our teams to find new things here, but we haven't found that we've had to compromise the bar.

Globally, private credit has had a few challenges over the last few years. Are you seeing challenges ease up?
What's interesting is there was all this noise around private credit, and yet we haven't seen what these sort of town criers of private credit doom were predicting, which was mass defaults and all these issues. Had they come out and said, "You know, you were operating in an environment two or three years ago where rates were really elevated, spreads were high, and there were no losses, and returns we think are going to come down a bit," that would've been a very credible criticism. Instead, you've got a lot of noise and it led investors to say, "Whoa, I'm concerned" and it led to redemptions. I think the reality will be

WE'VE SEEN THE SENTIMENT IN INDIA, PEOPLE HAVE GOTTEN OVERLY NEGATIVE, (BUT) WHEN YOU LOOK AT MEDIUM & LONGER TERM, YOU'VE GOT AN ECONOMY THAT'S GROWING AT 7%+, A VERY YOUNG POPULATION

different, and we'll see that wave ebb.

I think there was some moderation in returns. But these products are remarkably resilient because they're generally lowly leveraged, and they made low loan-to-value loans themselves. You'll continue to see private credit, both on the investment and non-investment grade side, continue to take a lot of share.

You love running in New York's Central Park. Do you plan to run in India?
Yes, I do plan on running in India. When you're traveling the world, there's no better way to see a place than to do it on foot. Right? And so, to wake up in Delhi or Mumbai or Tokyo or Brussels or wherever you are in the world, that to me is always a nice thing to do, run along the water somewhere.

RUN ALONG WATER I do plan on running in India. When you're traveling, there's no better way to see a place than to do it on foot...to wake up in Delhi or Mumbai or Tokyo or Brussels...that to me is always a nice thing to do, run along the water somewhere

ET IN THE CLASSROOM
SIFs Gain Ground: Should Investors Explore Them?

A year after their launch, Specialised Investment Funds (SIFs) are beginning to find a place in investor portfolios. Sitting between traditional mutual funds and high-ticket offerings such as PMSs and AIFs, they offer fund managers more freedom in managing money without requiring the large investment amounts associated with those products.

WHY HAVE SIFs BECOME POPULAR?
The appeal of SIFs lies in the space they occupy between mutual funds and PMSs. Investors looking for something beyond traditional equity and debt schemes can access strategies that are not available in regular mutual funds, without committing the much larger sums typically required by PMSs and AIFs.

Another factor is flexibility. SIFs give fund managers more room to manage money and adjust portfolios as market conditions change, which has attracted investors looking for alternatives to conventional mutual fund strategies.

HOW ARE SIFS DIFFERENT FROM MUTUAL FUNDS, PMSs AND AIFs?
The biggest difference is the freedom available to the fund manager. A mutual fund largely benefits when the stocks it owns rise in value. A SIF can also take limited positions that benefit when stocks fall. However, such positions cannot exceed 25% of the scheme's assets.

SIFs also allow managers to change allocations more actively than traditional mutual funds.

In terms of investment size, they sit between mutual funds and PMSs/AIFs. Investors can start investing in mutual funds with a few hundred rupees, while SIFs require a minimum investment of ₹10 lakh. By comparison, PMSs and AIFs typically require investments of ₹50 lakh and ₹1 crore, respectively.

HOW FAR HAVE SIFs COME IN THEIR FIRST YEAR?
The category has grown quickly. Assets under management stood at ₹38,224 crore as of September 30, 2026, according to SIF360.com.

Seventeen AMCs now offer SIFs. As of August 2026, the category had 33 live schemes and nearly 1.26 lakh folios. The growth, however, has been concentrated among a small number of players. The top five platforms account for 83% of industry assets, while the top three manage nearly two-thirds of the total money invested.

Invesco Mutual Fund
An investor education and awareness initiative

For Know Your Customer (KYC) guidelines along with the documentary requirements and procedure for change of address, phone number, bank details, etc., please visit the Education and Guidance section on www.invescomutualfund.com. Investor should deal with only SEBI registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified under "Intermediaries/Market Infrastructure Institutions" on https://www.sebi.gov.in/index.html. For any grievance / complaint, please call us on 1800-209-0007 or write to us at mfservices@invescoindia.com. Alternatively, complaints can be registered on the SEBI SCORES Portal at https://scores.sebi.gov.in

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

WHICH SIFs STRATEGIES HAVE BECOME POPULAR?
Investors have gravitated towards hybrid strategies, which accounted for 60% of net inflows in August 2026.

Among equity-oriented offerings, strategies focused on companies outside the top 100 by market capitalisation have drawn interest. Investors have also shown appetite for multi-asset strategies where fund managers can move money across equity, debt and other asset classes depending on market conditions.

WHO SHOULD INVEST AND WHO SHOULD NOT IN SIFs?
SIFs are primarily aimed at investors who already have some experience with market-linked products and want to go beyond traditional mutual funds. Wealth managers typically view them as an addition to an existing portfolio rather than a substitute for mutual fund investments.

They may not be suitable for first-time investors, people looking for assured returns or those uncomfortable with the possibility of losses. Retirees who depend on their investments for regular income should also evaluate such products carefully before investing.

SACHIN KUMAR

HOPE & HURDLES BPO firm to go debt-free after offer, but currency risks remain

Fusion CX's Growth Momentum Faces a Test Outside India

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Fusion CX, a business process outsourcing company, plans to raise ₹500 crore through fresh equity to repay debt and fund acquisitions and ₹202 crore through an offer for sale. The promoter stake will fall to around 80% after the IPO from 96% on a fully diluted basis. The company derives over 90% revenue from overseas markets, exposing itself to geopolitical uncertainties and currency fluctuations. On the positive side, it has shown a strong growth in revenue and profits over the past three years and it plans to become debt free after the IPO. It has so far not faced any client-side pressure on either billing or deliverables. It has also forayed in artificial intelligence (AI) related data infrastructure services to take advantage of the opportunities in this segment. Given these factors, investors with higher risk appetite may consider the IPO over the long term.

Scaling Up
- **IPO Dates:** Oct 14-16, 2026
- **IPO Price:** ₹275-289
- **IPO Size:** Upto ₹702 crore
- **Implied Market Cap:** Upto ₹4,258 cr (diluted basis)
- **Face Value:** ₹1 per share
- **Lot Size:** 51 shares
- **Retail Portion:** 10%

IPO WATCH

BUSINESS
Incorporated in 2004, Fusion CX provides multichannel customer support through voice, email, chat, social media and messaging to companies. Its workforce expanded to 13,735 as of June 2026 from 8,539 at the end of March 2024. It had 40 delivery centres and two sales offices across13 countries as of June 2026. The US is its major market contributing over 77% to revenue, followed by India at around 10%, and Australia and Europe each at around 7-8%. The top 10 clients contributed around 50% of the revenue in FY26. In the current year, the company acquired VA Platinum offshoring to expand presence in Australia.

FINANCIALS
Revenue rose nearly two times to ₹1,818 crore while net profit grew nearly five times to ₹169.8 crore between FY24 and FY26. The operating margin before depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda margin) expanded to 18.1% from 10.6%. It was at the lower end of the margin band of 16-34% for the peer group. The return on equity rose to 30.3% from 13.4% during the period. This compares with 15-32% range for peers.

VALUATIONS
The company demands a FY26 trailing price-earnings (P/E) multiple of 25 considering post-IPO equity. Based on annualised June 2026 quarter earnings of ₹55.7 crore, the P/E works out to be 19. Peers including Firstsource Soutions, Sagility, and Eclerx Services trade at forward P/Es of 31, 24, and 21.

China, Russia Not Helping Iran, they have Much to Lose: Trump

US President Donald Trump said on Monday that he does not believe that China and Russia are helping Iran, adding that they have "too much to lose".

Trump has faced pressure over reports that Chinese and Russian entities have supplied Iran with intelligence for attacks on US troops.

Responding to comments that China and Russia are helping Iran, Trump said in a post on Truth Social: "If they are, it's at a very low level, but I don't believe they are at all."

"They have too much to lose, and we would know about it, and know about it very fast!" he added.

Trump said in July that he did not believe China and Russia were selling weapons to Iran, warning that "it would be very bad for them" if they did. China and Russia both maintain strong ties with Iran but have refrained from getting directly involved in the West Asia war, which began with US-Israeli strikes on February 28.

Since the outbreak of the war, Russia has sent humanitarian aid to Iran, but has otherwise not officially announced any concrete assistance. The Kremlin has denied US media reports claiming that Moscow passed sensitive intelligence to Iran, including the locations of US warships and aircraft in the region.

'IRAN, RUSSIA TARGETING UK'

Iran is stepping up attempts to hit harder targets such as military sites in Britain and Russia is increasing its hybrid warfare against Ukraine's allies, the UK's domestic spy chief said on Tuesday.

In his annual speech on wide-ranging threats to Britain, MI5 Director General Ken McCallum said state threats had quadrupled over the last decade.

ENERGY TALKS CONTINUE

The Kremlin said on Tuesday that contacts about an energy ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine which US President Trump announced on Sunday were continuing, but that it had nothing more to say on the matter for now.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov did not specify who Russia was talking to about the ceasefire. **Agencies**

'No Energy Sites Hit in Ukraine Post Truce'

Kyiv: Russia hit no Ukrainian energy targets on Tuesday for the first time since US President Donald Trump's weekend announcement of an "energy ceasefire", while hammering cities' transport and logistics overnight with ballistic missiles and drones. Russia's defence ministry, in its daily summary ofernight strikes, made no mention of Ukrainian energy facilities. A Kremlin spokesman, asked about the energy ceasefire, would only say that contacts were ongoing, but declined to provide any further details. However, one missile came down just over a kilometre from a plant providing heating to much of the city of Lviv, in the west. **Reuters**

Adani, Jabil in Pact to Manufacture Gear for AI, Data Centres in India

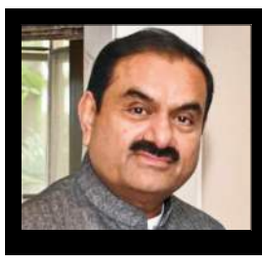
Proposed 50:50 JV likely to manufacture AI racks, servers, storage, networking gear

Our Bureau

Chennai: Adani Enterprises and global engineering, supply chain and manufacturing company Jabil on Tuesday said they have signed a non-binding Memorandum of Understanding setting out the framework for a proposed 50:50 joint venture to manufacture and assemble artificial intelligence and data centre equipment in India.

The JV will look at manufacturing and assembling AI racks, servers, storage and networking equipment used in data centres. The racks would house high-performance computing systems for AI applications and other digital services. The portfolio would include equipment to power and cool these systems, including power distribution units, liquid-cooling systems and transformers.

The MoU follows the June 2026 announcement of Adani Group and Jabil's intent to establish a strategic alliance to develop an AI and data centre infrastructure manufacturing ecosystem in India. "The AI revolution will demand far more than just breakthroughs in algorithms," Gautam Adani, chairman of Adani Group, said in a statement. "It will require an entire new industrial architecture where energy, hyperscale infrastructure, advanced computing and precision manufacturing converge to power the intelligence economy."



The AI revolution will demand far more than just breakthroughs in algorithms. It will require an entire new industrial architecture where energy, hyperscale infrastructure, advanced computing and precision manufacturing converge to power the intelligence economy

GAUTAM ADANI, Chairman of Adani Group

He said the Adani Group's vision is to expand up the AI value chain evolving from powering and hosting AI infrastructure to engineering and manufacturing the critical systems that will define the next generation of computing. The venture is also expected to have multi-gigawatt AI rack manufacturing capacity, supporting computing systems with a combined power capacity of several gigawatts.

"Our proposed joint venture with Jabil marks a strategic step towards this future, combining Jabil's world-class engineering and manufacturing capabilities with Adani's integrated strengths in energy, infrastructure and data centers to help build the physical backbone of the global AI economy," he added.

The venture is also expected to have multi-gigawatt AI rack manufacturing capacity, supporting computing systems with a combined power capacity of several gigawatts. It would also provide installation and commissioning services.

"The signing of this MoU is the next step forward in our shared efforts to establish a scaled AI infrastructure manufacturing platform in India, a market we believe will become increasingly important for both domestic and global AI infrastructure demand," said Mike Dastoor, chief executive officer of Jabil Inc.

Karnataka Plans IKF Offices Abroad to Attract Investments

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka has proposed setting up overseas offices of its nodal investment agency, Invest Karnataka Forum (IKF), in the US, Japan, Taiwan, South Korea and France to attract investments, industries minister MB Patil said.

The proposal was discussed at a meeting of the IKF board of directors in Bengaluru. The minister directed officials to assess its advantages and disadvantages, hold consultations and submit a report, the industries department said in a statement.

"There is intense competition among states to attract industrial investments. Some state governments have already taken steps to open offices in the countries mentioned above to attract investments. Karnataka cannot afford to lag in this regard," Patil said.

He said the state must assess each country's industrial strengths and sectoral specialisations before taking a decision. The meeting also discussed appointing professionals with relevant expertise to head the proposed overseas offices. Another meeting will be held shortly to take the discussions forward, Patil said.

Hyundai Motor to Invest $15.5B in India Over 7 Yrs

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Korea's Hyundai Motor Group Tuesday said it will invest $ 15.5 billion in India over a seven-year period till 2032.

The initiative positions India as a strategic core market for the group's future growth, emerging market expansion, and next-generation automotive innovation.

The initiative was discussed during a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Hyundai Motor Group Executive Chair Euisun Chung at the Prime Minister's Office in New Delhi on October 13.

The investment will be made towards expanding manufacturing operations, research and development (R&D) infrastructure development, local supplier cultivation for parts localisation and future technology innovation -fostering a comprehensive automotive industry ecosystem in India, HMG said. To effectively execute this large-scale investment initiative, the group will establish a dedicated investment entity in India. The entity will systematically coordinate and execute investments across R&D infrastructure, future technologies and the broader automotive industry ecosystem. Additionally, it will serve as a platform to identify outstanding local partners, support strategic partnerships and foster collaboration with local suppliers.

भारतीय विमानपत्तन आर्थिक विनियामक प्राधिकरण
Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA)
भारत सरकार/Government of India
3rd Floor, Udaan Bhawan, Safdarjung Airport, New Delhi – 110003
Ph.: 011-24695044

PUBLIC NOTICE

STAKEHOLDERS' CONSULTATION MEETING ON DETERMINATION OF TARIFF FOR THE AERONAUTICAL SERVICES FOR ALLURI SITARAMA RAJU INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT, BHOGAPURAM (VTZ) FOR THE FIRST CONTROL PERIOD (01.04.2026 – 31.03.2031)

Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA) has issued Consultation Paper No. 06/2026-27 on 01.10.2026 (which is available on AERA website at URL www.aera.gov.in) w.r.t the Tariff Determination for the Aeronautical Services for Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport, Bhogapuram (VTZ) for the First Control Period (01.04.2026 – 31.03.2031).

In accordance with the provision of Section 13(4) of the AERA Act, 2008, the various tariff proposals of the Authority contained in the Consultation Paper, are put forth for Stakeholders' Consultation. A Stakeholders Consultation Meeting in hybrid mode (Physical/Online) in this regard is scheduled on **16th October, 2026 (Friday) at 3:30 PM** at:

Stakeholders Room, 3rd Floor, Udaan Bhawan, Safdarjung Airport, New Delhi – 110003.

All stakeholders like Passengers/Passengers' Associations, General Public, Airport Operators, Airlines, Industry Associations/Bodies, Independent Service providers for Cargo, Ground Handing Fuel Farm etc., are requested to join the said meeting and give their valuable suggestions/comments/views on the aforesaid Consultation Paper on tariff proposal of Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport, Bhogapuram (VTZ).

Participants joining in person may send their confirmation to AERA before the above-mentioned date of meeting with Name, email address, mobile number, vehicle number by email (to directorps@aera.gov.in and rajan.gupta1@aera.gov.in). Online link will be shared on AERA website (https://aera.gov.in) before the Stakeholders meeting under Tab "News and Announcements".

CBC 03112/11/0016/2627

Sd/-
Secretary, AERA

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
CORRIGENDUM NO. 1

Open Tender No. DyELA20Paint WAG9A. Name of work : Outsourcing of complete painting operations of WAG-9 locomotives on supply and application basis through wet-on-wet system as per scope of work at CLW/CRJ. **Previous Online Tender Closing Date & Time :** 10.10.2026 at 11:00 hrs. **Revised Online Tender Closing Date & Time: 17.10.2026 at 11:00 hours**. Detailed information about tender and tender format is available at website **www.ireps.gov.in**.

PR6/518 AWM/ELA-II/CLW/Chittaranjan
Visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

Sports World Play

Manchester City striker Erling Haaland is in prime form having scored six goals in six Premier League games

VITALS

THIRD T20I

Hunt for Wickets, don't Try to Contain West Indies: Tilak to Bowlers

Hyderabad: India need to hunt for wickets rather than focus on containing a power-packed West Indies batting line-up, vice-captain Tilak Varma said on Tuesday, stressing the need to execute their bowling plans as the hosts look to seal the T20I series in the fourth match. India lead the series 2-1 and a win on Wednesday would give them an unassailable lead, while West Indies will be looking to draw level. Tilak said India could not afford to relax against a side whose power-hitting extended to the lower order. "They play so much franchise cricket, so they know how to play this format. The power they have is unbelievable," Tilak said. "Everyone can hit the ball. It is not just the openers, number three or four. All their players can strike the ball, and even the 11th batter can come in and hit. Until all 10 wickets fall, the game is not over. We cannot relax." **PTI**

7pm | Star Sports

Hazlewood Takes 6 Wkts As Australia Beat South Africa in First Test

Durgan: Australia paceman Josh Hazlewood bowled his side to a 214-run victory on the last day of the first Test at Kingsmead on Tuesday with South Africa's resistance ending before tea as the home side were dismissed for 206. Hazlewood took 6/49 as Australia bagged the six wickets they needed on the last day to go 1-0 up in the three-match series. South Africa held out for the first 110 minutes of Tuesday's play before a legside delivery from Hazlewood was edged by Wiaan Mulder and snagged by a diving catch from wicketkeeper Alex Carey. Mulder and Aiden Markram resumed at 102-4 overnight and the pair extended the fifth-wicket partnership to a patient 69 runs off 205 balls before Hazlewood's breakthrough with Mulder making 29. South Africa were 166-6 at lunch and added 25 runs before the new ball was taken but crumbled quickly thereafter. **Reuters**

BRIEF SCORES **Australia** 390 (Renshaw 190; Mulder 4/68, Jansen 3/68) and 314 for 6 dec (Renshaw 82, Maddinson 48; Maharaj 2/56, Nortje 2/56) beat **South Africa** 284 (Bedingham 49; Cummins 3/54, Hazlewood 2/54) and 206 (Markram 75, Bedingham 46; Hazlewood 6/49, Renshaw 2/30) by 214 runs

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

A Gulf Apart

Man City, PSG clash at contrasting time for state-backed projects

Manchester City and Paris Saint-Germain have reshaped football with the financial backing of Gulf state owners, but there is a stark contrast in the health of those projects ahead of their latest Champions League meeting on Wednesday.

City return to Champions League action for the first time since they were found guilty of breaking Premier League financial rules in a bombshell verdict which could threaten their place in the English top-flight.

PSG strived to follow City's era of sustained success and are now firmly established as Europe's top dogs after successive Champions League titles to go along with their domination of French football.

Abu Dhabi-backed City won the race against Qatar-owned PSG to become European champions first in 2023.

The triumph over Inter Milan in Istanbul that completed a treble of Champions League, Premier League and FA Cup was the pinnacle of City's rise since a 2008 takeover fronted by Sheikh Mansour, the vice-president and deputy prime minister of the UAE.

But a cloud now hangs over City's haul of silverware from the past 15 years unless they can overturn the findings of an independent commission on appeal.

City were found to have used "sham" commercial deals with Emirati companies to inflate revenue and reduce costs to the tune of over £900 million ($1.2 billion) between 2009 and 2018.

No sanction has yet been meted out, but a severe points deduction or even expulsion from the Premier League are among the potential punishments.

94% FOOTBALL CLUBS IN ENGLISH TOP 5 DIVISIONS ARE OPERTING AT A LOSS

English football clubs are "dangerously exposed" to financial risk, the country's Independent Football Regulator said in a report released on Tuesday, after finding that 94% of clubs in the top five divisions were operating at a loss. IFR's draft State of the Game report, which will undergo an eight-week public consultation before a final version is published, found nearly two-thirds of English Football League and National League clubs were "technically insolvent". Many were increasingly dependent on cash injections from their owners to remain in business, the regulator said. "A significant number of clubs have told us they would not survive if their owners walked away. This lack of resilience can no longer be ignored," the IFR said in its report. **Reuters**

AL-KHELAIFI SHOWS SUPPORT

The Premier League season has been thrust into turmoil while clubs await the appeal verdict, with City sitting top of the table after six successive wins.

Winning the Champions League could be City's only way back into the competition next season. To do so they will need to stop PSG's quest to join a very select club of sides to win the Champions League or European Cup in three consecutive seasons.

Further UEFA action against City is unlikely as the club successfully fended off European football's governing body when they attempted to act on the same leak of documents in 2018 that led to the Premier League's case.

In 2020, City were found guilty of breaking UEFA's Financial Fair Play rules, fined 30 million euros ($34 million) and banned from playing in European competitions for two years.

But City successfully overturned the ban at the Court of Arbitration for Sport, which ruled that most of the alleged breaches "were either not established or time barred".

In the early days of FFP rules, both City and PSG entered into settlement agreements with UEFA in 2014. But the French champions have managed to steer clear of such issues since, with president Nasser Al-Khelaifi becoming an influential figure, both as a member of the UEFA Executive Committee and chairman of the European Football Clubs (EFC) organisation.

At a meeting of the EFC in Copenhagen last month, Al-Khelaifi showed support for embattled City CEO Ferran Soriano. "I think they have the right to appeal, so it is not the final decision," said Al-Khelaifi.

But a crisis which could eliminate City as a Champions League rival for years to come would be another win for PSG on the field, giving Qatar the upper hand in the soft power battle with regional rivals the UAE. **AFP**

WATCHOUT! Tonight

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE **LASK Linz v Liverpool** 10:15pm; **AS Roma v Real Madrid** 12:30am; **Bodo/Glimt v Borussia Dortmund** 12:30am; **Man City v PSG** 12:30am (Sony Ten)

taril

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EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER, 2026

(₹ in Cr.)

Particulars	Standalone					
	Quarter ended			Half Year ended		Year ended
	30th September, 2026	30th June, 2026	30th September, 2025	30th September, 2026	30th September, 2025	31st March, 2026
	Unaudited					Audited
Total income from operations	711.84	573.56	440.81	1285.40	967.72	2,452.34
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	98.68	68.03	25.61	166.71	106.87	301.84
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	98.68	68.03	25.61	166.71	106.87	301.84
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	75.01	49.87	16.80	124.88	76.95	225.43
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after Tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	75.06	49.92	16.90	124.98	77.10	225.47
Equity Share Capital	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	-	-	-	-	-	1410.17
Earnings Per Share (of Re. 1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) Basic & Diluted	2.5	1.66	0.56	4.16	2.56	7.51

Particulars	Consolidated					
	Quarter ended			Half Year ended		Year ended
	30th September, 2026	30th June, 2026	30th September, 2025	30th September, 2026	30th September, 2025	31st March, 2026
	Unaudited					Audited
Total income from operations	742.16	588.65	473.95	1330.81	1023.61	2569.65
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	109.93	88.03	45.30	197.96	135.78	363.04
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	109.93	88.03	45.30	197.96	135.78	363.04
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	81.38	64.29	37.35	145.67	104.81	272.17
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after Tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	81.28	64.34	37.45	145.62	105.00	272.09
Equity Share Capital	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02	30.02
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	-	-	-	-	-	1484.81
Earnings Per Share (of Re. 1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) Basic & Diluted	2.66	2.05	1.13	4.71	3.37	9.07

Note:

1. The above results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meeting held on Tuesday, 13th October 2026.
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended on 30th September, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter and half year ended Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results is available on the Stock Exchange websites (**www.bseindia.com** and **www.nseindia.com**) and also available on the Company's website **www.transformerindia.com**

Date: **13th October, 2026**
Place: **Ahmedabad**

For Transformers and Rectifiers (India) Limited

Satyen J. Mamtora
Managing Director & CEO
(DIN: 00139984)

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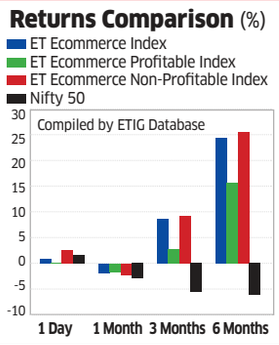
ET Ecommerce Tracker

Returns Comparison (%)



Tweet OF THE DAY

RADHA KRISHNA KAVULURU
@IAMKRISHRADHA

GPU is the new jet Engine. If you don't have your own silicon, you will become a slave of the ones who do

Tech Buzz

'AI May Soon Self-replicate on IoT Devices'

Anthropic said its tests suggested small AI models may be months away from being capable enough to self-replicate on commercial internet-of-things (IoT) devices, like smart ovens and off-brand Android TV boxes. In its tests, Anthropic looked at whether AI models could find vulnerable devices, copy themselves into those, and continue spreading without human help. The firm found that small models under 30 billion parameters could complete the many steps needed for replication. In its simplified tests, stronger models were capable of end-to-end replication. – Reuters

$2.2billion
Funding raised by India's fintech sector in the first nine months of 2026, up 14% yoy: Tracxn

Nvidia's China AI Chip Share Plunges 34%

BEIJING: Nvidia's share of China's market for data-centre AI chips fell to 34% in the first half of 2026, as US export controls restricted supplies of its products and domestic rivals led by Huawei gained ground. Nvidia shipped 678,000 AI accelerators in China from January through June, down 44% from a year earlier, IDC data showed. AI accelerators are specialised chips used to train and run AI models.Washington has restricted China's access to Nvidia's most powerful AI chips, limiting the range of products the US chipmaker can sell in the world's second-largest economy. – Reuters

Blume, Kalaari, Chiratae Among 19 Managers Picked for RDI Scheme

Fund managers comprise 14 alternative investment funds & five focused research organisations

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Chiratae Ventures, Blume Ventures, Kalaari Capital, Speciale Invest, YourNest Capital, IvyCap Ventures, Ideaspring Capital and TVS Capital Funds are among the 19 fund managers selected for the government's ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme. The fund has made a total commitment of ₹7,131 crore to the cohort.

The fund managers comprise 14 alternative investment funds (AIFs) and five focused research organisations (FROs), which will channel long-term capital into deeptech startups and private sector research and development.

The five FROs are AI & Robotics Technology Park at IISc Bengaluru, Centre for Cellular and Molecular Platforms in Bengaluru, IIT Madras Research Park, Pilani Innovation & Entrepreneurship Development Society at BITS Pilani and Society for Innovation & Entrepreneurship at IIT Bombay.

The AIFs include Celesta India AIF Managers, AdvantEdge Investment Managers, AMA Capital Advisors, Translation Endeavors, Sixth Sense Ventures and Campus, according to the list released by the government on Tuesday.

Anusandhan National Research Foundation, the government's apex research body, serves as the custodian of the ₹1 lakh crore RDI fund.

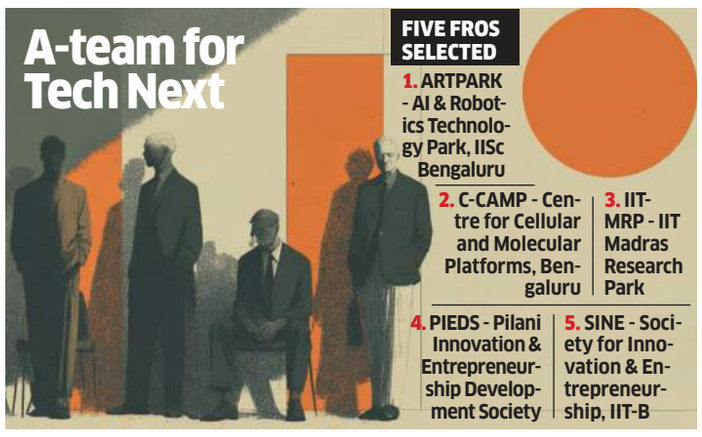
The amount received by the funds is yet to be made public. People with knowledge of the matter told **ET** that the government plans to announce the second cohort shortly and is open to expanding commitments depending on the quality and number of proposals received.

LONG-DRAWN PROCESS

More than 160 venture capital firms had applied to access the government-backed capital pool, according to people in the know.

The selection process focused on applicants' capabilities and depth of expertise in deeptech, they said. The process took time as the government sought to establish a system to assess the quality and readiness of fund managers before committing public capital, according to one of the persons, who did not wish to be identified.

Those not selected in the first round can address feedback received during the evaluation and apply in subsequent cohorts.



LOOKING AHEAD

Govt to announce second cohort shortly and is open to expanding commitments depending on the quality and number of proposals it receives

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO
www.economictimes.com

IBM to Deploy India's 1st Quantum Computer in Amaravati Early '27

India MD says AI infra just one part of task, developing applications equally important

Himanshi Lohchab

Mumbai: IBM plans to deploy what it describes as India's largest quantum computer early next year at the newly developed tech park in Amaravati, a top executive said. The facility will focus on developing practical applications for quantum computing and helping Indian enterprises prepare their IT infrastructure for post-quantum cryptography.

"I think the facility is almost ready… Machines should be here early next year," Sandip Patel, managing director of IBM India, told **ET**. The project, backed by chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu, is part of IBM's Andhra Pradesh Quantum Valley initiative, which it is executing in partnership with Tata Consultancy Services.

Patel said creating the infrastructure was only one part of the task; developing applications and the capabilities to use the machine would be equally important.

According to government policy think tank NITI Aayog, India will need to train some 100,000 quantum developers to secure its place as a quantum computing leader in the 2030s.

"Real-world quantum applications are still 3-5 years away, but the work on specific uses is progressing globally," he said. For instance, HSBC and IBM reported a trial that improved predictions of whether European corporate bond trades would be executed at a quoted price by up to 34%, compared with commonly used classical techniques.

"So these are the kinds of use cases which I think we need to start developing with quantum and some of that work will start happening from India," Patel said.

He cautioned that post-quantum cryptography is the more immediate priority for enterprises as they prepare their security systems for advances in computing. "That work I think is probably going to progress a lot faster than mainstream quantum," he said.

On IBM's top three priorities for India, Patel named security, hybrid cloud and artificial intelligence, with quantum computing remaining part of its longer-term focus.

On AI, Patel said that even after three years of running AI pilots, enterprises are still struggling to scale them. A joint IBM–IndiaAI study released in May found that 85% of Indian organisations surveyed remained at the pilot stage of AI adoption, while only 15% were scaling AI through significant investments across business functions.

Poorly organised data, uncertainty over returns, shortages of relevant skills and a lack of trust in AI outcomes are key obstacles, he said. "You just don't apply AI to everything. You have to redesign your process and then apply AI. Then you get the right value out of it," Patel said. "If done right, the productivity gains can be immense."

NITI AAYOG STUDY

India will need to train some 100,000 quantum developers to secure its place as a quantum computing leader in the 2030s

Deal Corner

Deal counters keep buzzing as investors eye bright spots

Urban Company Eyes ₹2.5kcr War Chest through QIP to Battle Instant Help Rivals

Board to review plan on Oct 16; InstaHelp business likely to corner about 40% of fresh funds

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The board of home services platform Urban Company will meet October 16 to consider raising fresh capital, showed a regulatory filing Tuesday. It didn't elaborate on the fundraising plan.

People familiar with the matter said the company is planning to raise ₹2,000-2,500 crore via a qualified institutional placement (QIP).

The Gurugram-based company, which went public in September 2025, is locked in an escalating battle with Lightspeed-backed Snabbit and General Catalyst-backed Pronto in the high cash-burn instant household segment.

Snabbit has raised a total of $112 million, including a $56 million round in April 2026. Pronto, meanwhile, has raised more than $50 million.

India's home services market, valued at $60 billion in FY25, is expected to grow to $100 billion by FY30, according to brokerage firm Jefferies.

Urban Company raised ₹472 crore through its initial public offering (IPO) last year.

As of June 30, the company had ₹2,019 crore in cash on its books, even as the hyper competitive InstaHelp business continued to weigh on profitability.

"About 40% of the fresh funds is expected to be allocated towards building a warchest for the InstaHelp business, while remaining is likely to be deployed towards inorganic expansion and other businesses such as India core home services, international and Native (its line of home devices)," said one of the persons cited above.

Urban Company didn't respond to ET's queries.

Urban Company entered the 10-minute household segment in early 2025, just months before its IPO, as Snabbit and Pronto were raising venture capital to compete in the space. While Urban Company initially established a lead in monthly order volumes, Bengaluru-based Snabbit caught up with its rival, with Pronto ranking third.

Urban Company's InstaHelp business reported ₹11 crore in revenue and adjusted operating loss of ₹132 crore in the June quarter.

House Help Wars

Urban Company currently locked in battle with Snabbit and Pronto in the instant household segment

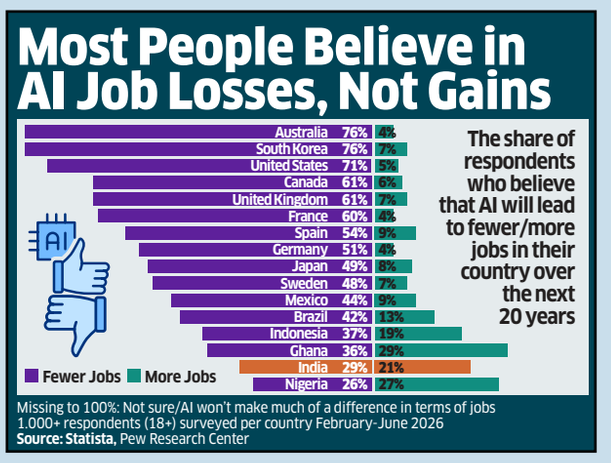
Snabbit has raised **$112 m,** including **$56 million** round in April 2026

Pronto, so far, has secured over **$50 m** in funding

Currently, all three firms competing for a slice of India's home services pie, set to grow to $100 billion by 2029-30

Tech Trotter

Meanwhile in tech..



China's CXMT is Claiming Memory Advances Ahead of Samsung, Hynix

CXMT declared it achieved a breakthrough in chip technology that rivals like Samsung Electronics had pursued for years, an unsubstantiated claim that jolted stocks and reflects China's aggressive push into a critical sphere.

The domestic memory leader plans to roll out a new type of chips with increased memory density thanks to the company's self-developed new architecture, CXMT President Cao Kanyu told an industry conference in Shanghai over the weekend. —**Bloomberg**

Spill Games Gets $10.5 m from Elevation, Others

Bengaluru: Bengaluru-based mobile gaming startup Spill Games has raised $10.5 million in a funding round led by Elevation Capital, with existing investors Centre Court Capital and Peer-Capital also participating.

Founded in 2024 by former PlaySimple Games operators Om Misra, Tapan Ranjan and Harsh Garg, Spill develops free-to-play casual, puzzle and hybrid-casual mobile games for global markets.

The fresh funds will be primarily used for marketing and user acquisition of its successful titles such as 'Cozy Finds: Hidden Objects', a hidden-object puzzle, and 'Cozy Finds: Differences', a spot-the-difference game, among others, co-founder and chief executive Om Misra told ET. The funding comes as the startup looks to expand its portfolio of games. The company currently has six successful titles. —**Our Bureau**

Fundamentum's F2A Raises ₹3kcr for AI-Deeptech Fund

Fund gets nod for ₹500-cr green shoe; targets 12-15 investments in 3 yrs

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: Fundamentum Frontier Advisors (F2A), the artificial intelligence (AI) and deeptech investment platform anchored by Infosys cofounder Nandan Nilekani, has raised ₹3,000 crore for its growth-stage fund. The fund has secured approval from limited partners (LPs) to exercise the green shoe option of ₹500 crore.

Fundamentum launched F2A in May as a dedicated frontier-tech investment platform.

The new venture is led by Ashish Kumar, who moved from Fundamentum to head it alongside general partners Debraj Banerjee and Vivek Singla. F2A plans to make 12 to 15 investments over the next two to three years, with initial cheques of ₹100–150 crore that can go up to ₹200 crore. F2A is looking to complete its final close by the end of October.

The fund is in advanced stages of evaluating three investments that it expects to close over the next quarter, Singla told **ET**. It is also assessing around 75 companies, six or seven of which are at an intermediate stage of evaluation.

"LP interest has been beyond our expectations, from small HNI (high-net-worth individual) cheques to institutions, with healthy participation from large family offices and corporates. The cap table is very well diversified. LPs have also learned the trade after about a decade of investing in alternatives," Kumar told ET.

The fund expects to invest in four to five companies annually and deploy the entire corpus over two to three years. Singh said Nilekani will continue to mentor the fund and meet portfolio companies before and after investment. The fund has raised capital from Indian and overseas investors across two regulated investment vehicles.

Fund expects to invest in 4-5 cos annually and deploy the entire corpus over 2-3 yrs

F2A's initial cheques to be of ₹100–150 cr and may go up to ₹200 cr

Capital raised from Indian and overseas investors across two regulated investment vehicles

INTEREST AREAS

F2A's pipeline spans automation, robotics, advanced materials and defence technology, which Singla identifies as promising areas. The investments will cover companies domiciled in India and building for the domestic market, as well as those developing products in India for overseas markets.

IN-SPACe Pushes Space Cos to Adopt SCL's Indigenous Chips

SCL's TRL-9 space-grade chip portfolio, quarterly wafer runs open to cos

Suraksha P

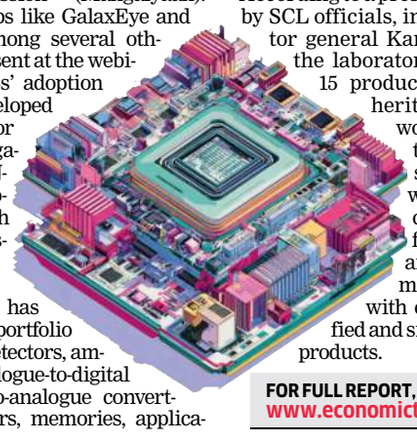
Bengaluru: The Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe) on Tuesday urged startups, industry, academia and research organisations to adopt semiconductor products developed by the government-run Semiconductor Laboratory (SCL), Mohali, for space and launch vehicle applications.

IN-SPACe, which supervises space activities by non-governmental entities (NGEs) and private startups, made the call during a webinar where SCL officials showcased its capabilities across semiconductor design, fabrication, testing, packaging, quality assurance, and failure analysis.

State-owned SCL, India's sole integrated device manufacturing (IDM) facility, is responsible for crucial indigenous microelectronics fabrication, famously producing the specialised CMOS chips used in India's Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan). Space startups like GalaxEye and InspeCity, among several others, were present at the webinar on 'NGEs' adoption of SCL-developed semiconductor products', organised by IN-SPACe in association with SCL on Tuesday.

Established in 1976, SCL has developed a portfolio of sensors, detectors, amplifiers, analogue-to-digital and digital-to-analogue converters, processors, memories, application-specific integrated circuits and communication interfaces for strategic and space applications.

According to a presentation made by SCL officials, including director general Kamaljeet Singh, the laboratory has around 15 products with flight heritage (real-world evidence that a piece of space hardware has successfully performed during an actual space mission), along with critically qualified and silicon-validated products.



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SaaS Firm Freshworks to Acquire US AI Spends Mgmt Platform Torii

Firm looks to expand its software management and AI spending governance play

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Software-as-a-service company Freshworks said it will acquire New York-based SaaS management platform Torii to expand its Freshservice offering to software management and artificial intelligence (AI) spending governance.

Freshservice is the IT service management platform of Nasdaq-listed Freshworks. As companies grapple with rising costs and security risks from the proliferation of SaaS and AI tools, the acquisition will enable Freshworks to provide businesses with enhanced visibility into their software applications, licences, user identities and AI-related expenditures.

"Torii tracks AI consumption to the token, attributes it to the people and teams driving it, and forecasts where it's heading, so IT can charge it back, set limits, and catch a spike while it's still small," the company said in a statement.

Freshworks further said that the integration would bring technology inventory, usage and spending information onto a single platform, enabling IT and finance teams to identify unused software licences, track expenditure and manage access more efficiently.

AI services, which increasingly follow consumption-based pricing models, have added complexity to technology budgeting and cost management, Freshworks said. "Freshservice already gives IT one place to see everything they run. With Torii, that same view now extends to software and AI spend — what's running, who's using it and what it costs, so finance and IT stop reconciling spreadsheets and start making decisions together," said Freshworks CEO Dennis Woodside.

Integration would bring technology inventory, usage and spending info onto a single platform

Microsoft to Install its Own AI Chips in Large Data Centres

Microsoft is gearing up to install the latest version of its own chips in data centres, with the aim of powering its AI software using mostly homegrown hardware.

The company expects to stock multiple gigawatts of its Maia chips in its server farms, with the newest iteration, the Maia 300, starting to roll out next year, Microsoft said on Monday. The semiconductors are designed to handle inference — using an AI model for tasks such as summarising a conference call or producing answers to a research question. Microsoft, Amazon.com and Alphabet's Google are all creating in-house artificial intelligence accelerators. —**Bloomberg**

Co expects to stock multiple gigawatts of its Maia chips in its server farms

AXIS CAPITAL GETS THE MANDATE FOR SALE OF OPERATIONAL PROJECTS

PSU Ircon to Monetise 4 Highway Assets

The listed engineering and construction co plans to unlock ₹3,000 cr value as part of govt's infra monetisation plan

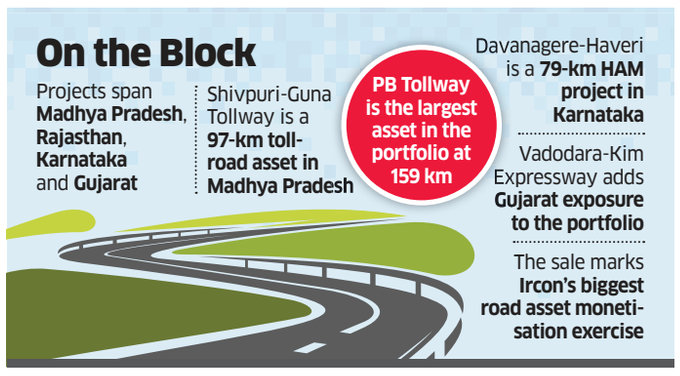
Reghu Balakrishnan

Mumbai: Ircon International has put four highway assets on the block as part of the government's broader infrastructure monetisation programme, people familiar with the development told **ET**. The enterprise value of the assets, for which Axis Capital has the sale mandate, is likely to be around ₹3,000 crore, the people said.

The portfolio on sale of the railway ministry's listed engineering and construction company comprises two build-operate-transfer (BOT) toll-road assets, the 97-km Ircon Shivpuri Guna Tollway in Madhya Pradesh and the 159-km Ircon PB Tollway in Rajasthan, and two hybrid annuity model (HAM) projects, the 79-km Ircon Davanagere Haveri Highway in Karnataka and the 32-km IrconVadodara Kim Expressway in Gujarat. The government currently holds a 65% stake in the listed entity Ircon, incorporated in 1976 as the Indian Railway Construction. It was initially set up mainly for the construction of railway projects in India and abroad.

Ircon has been a Mini Ratna Category-I PSU since 1998 and was subsequently upgraded to Navratna status in October 2023. Although the company has diversified into roads, buildings, electrical substations and distribution, airport construction, commercial complexes and metro segments, it mainly earns its revenue from the railway segment. For FY26, Ircon posted a turnover of ₹9,502 crore and a net profit of ₹592 crore on a consolidated basis. Ircon posted operating revenue of ₹1,205 crore from highways (14% of overall operating revenue) in FY26, down from ₹1,871 crore (18%) in FY25. Railways contributed about 82% of its annual operating income of ₹6,995 crore in FY26. Ircon Shivpuri Guna Tollway, incorporated on May 12, 2015, entered into a 20-year concession agreement with the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to undertake four-laning of the Shivpuri-Guna section.

Emails sent to Ircon officials did not elicit a response till press time.



The government has proposed disinvestment and equity sales in public sector undertakings (PSUs), including stake sales in their subsidiaries, as part of its ₹16.72 lakh crore Asset Monetisation Pipeline 2.0, covering the four financial years from FY27 to FY30. As part of the plan, the government also intends to pare its holdings in seven listed railway PSUs over the next four financial years. Aligning with the Government of India's objective under the Assets Monetisation Plan 2025-30, NHAI has also been pursuing its asset monetisation strategy.

Through toll-operate-transfer (ToT), Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs) and securitisation models, NHAI raised over ₹1.4 lakh crore across more than 6,100 km of national highways under the National Monetisation Pipeline.

ICICI Life Q2 Net Up 25% on Better Product Mix

Our Bureau

Mumbai: ICICI Life Insurance's second-quarter profit rose 25% year-on-year as growth in new business and a shift towards protection and annuity products supported profitability.

Net profit for the quarter ended September 2026 increased to ₹374 crore from ₹299 crore a year earlier. For the first half of FY27, profit rose 26.5% to ₹760 crore.

Shares fell 2.65% on the BSE to ₹446 apiece even as the benchmark index rose 1.54%.

Annualised premium equivalent (APE), a measure of new business sales, grew 15.1% to ₹4,935 crore in the first half. Protection APE rose 39.5% to ₹1,155 crore, while annuity APE increased 50% to ₹324 crore. Savings APE grew at a slower 6.6% to ₹3,455 crore as the business mix moved towards protection and retirement products.

"The mix is geared more towards protection, and that is what is helping us deliver the margins at this point," management said during the earnings call.

The stronger mix helped improve the value of new business (VNB), a measure of profitability from new policies, by 22.3% to ₹1,283 crore in the first half. The VNB margin expanded 150 basis points to 26%, indicating higher expected profitability from new business.

ICICI Life has also been working to improve profitability within individual product categories by increasing policy tenures, raising sum-assured multiples and expanding rider attachment.

The insurer expects growth in retail protection to moderate in the second half after four quarters of elevated growth following the GST changes. It said its priority remains expanding absolute VNB while balancing growth, product profitability and risk.

The solvency ratio stood at 229.9% at the end of September, up from 213.2% a year earlier and above the regulatory minimum of 150%.

Net Interest Income to Grow well for Banks in Q2, Profits may Lag

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Nifty 50 banks are expected to report 11.5% year-on-year growth in aggregate net interest income (NII) for the September quarter, according to the average of estimates by ETIG and four broking firms. However, growth in pre-provision operating profit and net profit will be slower, at around 10%, given the pressure on treasury income due to hardened bond yields. Credit costs are expected to stay benign during the quarter amid stable asset quality.

What The Street Expects

September'26 Quarter Estimates for Nifty 50 Banks

	Net Interest Income		PPOP		Net Profit	
	₹ crore	YoY %	₹ crore	YoY %	₹ crore	YoY %
State Bank of India	48,169.3	12.1	34,940.4	9.5	22,424.4	11.2
HDFC Bank	34,335.1	8.8	28,602.6	2.4	19,350.5	3.8
ICICI Bank	24,869.3	15.5	20,693.0	19.6	14,494.5	17.3
Axis Bank	14,993.9	9.1	11,642.2	11.8	7,168.1	40.8
Kotak Mahindra Bank	8,192.6	12.1	6,258.2	18.8	4,199.5	29.1
Total for Five Banks	1,30,560.1	11.5	1,02,136.4	10.1	67,637.0	10.1

PPOP: Pre-provision operating profit
Source: Avearge of the estimates by ETIG and four broking firms

Earnings Preview

The quarter was marked by strong capital inflows for the banking system through the RBI's 2026 Foreign Currency Non-Resident-Bank (FCNR-B) deposit swap scheme, which collected over $127 billion, exceeding expectations. This is expected to support deposit growth, which has not kept pace with the pick-up in credit demand for the past several quarters. On the flip side, it is likely to affect the CASA (current account savings account) ratio and net interest margins (NIMs).

"For large private banks, these inflows may dilute reported CASA ratios and create a short-term drag as funding raised at attractive offshore spreads takes time to be deployed," said Kotak Securities in a report. The broker estimates a 10-15 basis point quarterly impact from FCNR deposits on NIMs.

"Provisional business updates for 30 banks show loan growth accelerating sharply to 19.1% year-on-year and 6.6% sequentially, and deposit growth to 15.8% year-on-year and 5.8% sequentially, aided meaningfully by the FCNR-B mobilisation drive," noted JM Financial Institutional Securities in a preview report. The broking firm expects net profit of the banks under its coverage to grow by 12% year-on-year.

"NIMs may remain compressed in the September quarter but should gradually recover in the second half as banks retire high-cost liabilities and deploy liquidity into loans," said Global Financial Services in a preview report, adding that banks with high floating-rate loans may benefit from the recent rate hike. For investors, management commentary by banks on FCNR-related deployment, trends in fee income and the impact of the recent rate increase will be crucial.

"Key metrics to monitor are deployment trajectory and yields on FCNR deposits, impact of rate hike, upcoming ECL transition and any stress in SME and unsecured loans," stated JM Financial in the report. Among the top private sector banks, Axis Bank is expected to report the highest year-on-year net profit growth of 41% for the September quarter, followed by Kotak Mahindra Bank with a 29% increase. For SBI, profit is likely to grow by 11.2%. All three banks likely to report double-digit NII growth.

Bigger Car Loans, Longer Tenures Face a Rate Test

As avg PV loan size rises 49% to ₹8.2 lakh; repayment period extends to 62 months

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian car buyers are taking larger and longer-tenure loans to fund higher-priced vehicles, a trend that could face a test as borrowing costs begin to rise following the Reserve Bank of India's latest rate hike.

The average passenger vehicle loan grew 49% to ₹8.2 lakh between the first half of 2019 and the first half of 2026, while the average repayment tenure increased by five months to 62 months, according to TransUnion CIBIL's Shifting Gears 2026 report.

The shift comes at a time when vehicle demand remains strong. Total vehicle registrations increased 32% year-on-year in September to nearly 2.58 million units, with passenger vehicle retail sales up 33% and two-wheeler sales up 32%, according to data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations. However, the RBI's 25-basis-point repo rate hike to 5.5% last week is already feeding through to lending rates. Several lenders have raised repo-linked benchmark rates by up to 25 basis points, potentially increasing borrowing costs for fresh retail loans. A basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

"Car ownership is increasingly being shaped by a combination of aspirations and affordability. Consumers are choosing higher-value and feature-rich vehicles, while larger loan amounts and longer tenures are helping make these purchases more manageable," said Bhavesh Jain, MD and CEO, TransUnion CIBIL.

51% of high-value car loan borrowers now come from semi-urban & rural markets

Higher vehicle prices and a growing preference for sport utility vehicles and feature-rich models have driven premiumisation, making financing increasingly important for car purchases. The trend is no longer confined to large cities. About 51% of borrowers taking higher-value car loans in the first half of this year were from semi-urban and rural markets, six percentage points higher than in the corresponding period of 2019.

Non-banking financial companies remain the largest financiers of passenger vehicles, accounting for 37% of active loans, followed by private banks at 26%.

The active borrower base reached 25 million in June 2026, 1.7 times higher than in June 2019.

IndiGo Inks $328m Citi Deal for 8 Airbus Jets

PTI

Mumbai: The country's largest carrier, IndiGo, has signed a $328 million financing deal with Citi to buy eight narrow-body planes to be manufactured by Airbus.

This is the world's first aviation financing transaction insured by the Belgian export credit agency (ECA) Credendo and the maiden ECA-backed aircraft financing structured through GIFT City IFSC, according to a statement. The financing will help IndiGo procure six A321s and two A320s, it said.

Global banking major Citi acted as sole mandated arranger, ECA coordinator and sole lender, with the financing backed by Credendo's credit insurance, it added.

The transaction was executed through IndiGo's subsidiary, InterGlobe Aviation Financial Services IFSC, which provides a "competitive and diversified source of long-term funding" for the carrier's fleet and network growth, it said.

"By combining Citi's cross-border aviation and ECA financing expertise with Credendo's credit insurance and IndiGo's GIFT IFSC platform, we have delivered a first-of-its-kind solution that opens a vital new pathway connecting Indian aviation with the deep pool of ECA-backed international liquidity and supports the next phase of India's aviation growth," said Citi India's chief executive, K Balasubramanian. Frank Vanwingh, the group's deputy CEO at Credendo, said the ECA aspires to become a long-term partner for Belgian aviation stakeholders seeking access to international market opportunities and innovative financing structures.

IndiGo's chief aircraft acquisition and financing officer, Riyaz Peermohamed, said the partnership with Citi, Credendo and Airbus provides a competitive source of liquidity for its expanding Airbus fleet.

"The transaction demonstrates the potential of GIFT IFSC to bring together international banks and export credit agencies and create innovative financing solutions for Indian aviation," Peermohamed added.

Vantrock Real Assets Plans ₹3,100-cr Investment in Warehousing Projects

Co aims to build out 11.5 m sq ft, with a development value of ₹4,200 crore

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: Vantrock Real Assets, an operator-led property platform focused on warehousing, industrial and logistics, plans to invest ₹3,100 crore in a 11.5 million sq ft development pipeline, with a gross development value (GDV) of ₹4,200 crore, targeting supply-constrained logistics corridors across key Indian markets.

The Mumbai-based company, founded by real estate veteran Anshul Singhal, plans to begin construction on its initial development pipeline of around 3 million sq ft, valued at ₹1,100 crore, across Pune, Bengaluru and the National Capital Region (NCR), in 2027.

"Every good industrial and warehousing park in this country is full, and the new ones are being built an hour or more away from where the customer's business is," said Singhal, founder and CEO, Vantrock.

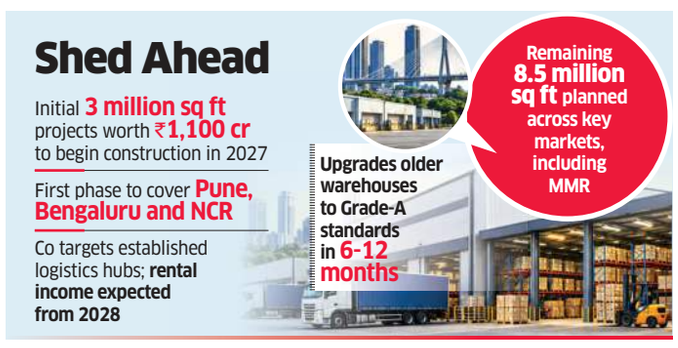
"We are going the other way by acquiring the infill land that is left inside proven corridors, and the Grade-B sheds already standing there, refurbished to Grade-A standards. These infill locations are slower and harder to assemble but bring in better value to customers."

The projects are expected to generate rental income from 2028. Land for these developments is at an advanced stage of negotiation, documentation and regulatory approvals.

The remaining 8.5 million sq ft is planned across the previously mentioned markets and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), with projects beginning in phases over the next 12-18 months.

The company will focus on 15-60-acre land parcels within established warehousing and industrial corridors, with a development potential of 0.4-1.5 million sq ft. Its strategy covers large-format and build-to-suit warehouses, multi-storey facilities, last-mile logistics, dark stores, self-storage, cold chain, industrial plots, workforce accommodation and mixed-use developments.

"Much of India's warehousing was built before anyone asked whether it was safe to work in. As a result, fire, structure, lighting, ventilation...these aspects were not prioritised. Bringing that stock to standard is as much a governance task as a real estate one, and it is the part of this plan I care about most," said Shailesh V. Haribhakti, chairman of the board, Vantrock.



Riyadh Airport Closure: Saudi Flights Suspended Till Oct 17

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Airlines have suspended flights to Saudi Arabia until October 17 after the kingdom's aviation regulator suspended operations at Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport, disrupting travel across the region and leaving passengers seeking alternative routes.

Air India, Air India Express and IndiGo have suspended services to Riyadh, Dammam and Jeddah, with IndiGo also suspending flights to Medina, according to an advisory issued by the Indian Embassy in Riyadh on Tuesday. Akasa Air has suspended flights to Riyadh and Jeddah until the same date. The disruption has spread to international carriers. Emirates cancelled multiple services to Riyadh, Dammam, Jeddah and Medina on October 12 and 13, while Etihad Airways cancelled Abu Dhabi–Riyadh flights through October 19 and services to Jeddah and Dammam through October 14. Flydubai has reported cancellations affecting Riyadh, Dammam and Abha through October 19. Qatar Airways has suspended flights to Riyadh and Dammam without announcing a resumption date.

Attack killed Indian national Mohammed Yousef Ali and injured 11 others

Gulf Air has cancelled Riyadh services through October 17. European carriers have also extended disruptions. Lufthansa Group has cancelled Riyadh flights through October 16, while Air France-KLM has suspended services to the Saudi capital through the end of October. Philippine Airlines has extended its Riyadh suspension until November 29.

The suspensions come after an attack at Riyadh airport on October 10 killed Indian national Mohammed Yousef Ali and injured 11 others. Four of the injured Indians remain in intensive care, four are receiving treatment in hospital wards and three have been discharged, the embassy said. While operations at Riyadh airport have been suspended, flights at other major Saudi airports, including Dammam, Jeddah and Medina, continue, though they face disruptions.

Saudi carriers Saudia and Flynas are operating some scheduled services, according to the embassy.

Saudi Economy Set to Shrink as War Bites

Saudi Arabia, the world's top oil exporter, faces a major economic contraction this year, the IMF said on Tuesday, as deadly attacks by Yemen's Houthis squeeze a country already suffering from the West Asia war. Saudi Arabia's GDP is expected to shrink by 3.3%, the International Monetary Fund said in its World Economic Outlook report, predicting a regional drop over Iran's blockading of the Strait of Hormuz. The report was compiled before 13 people were killed on Saturday—the deadliest attack in Saudi in more than a decade. **AFP**

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 81 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:

	2	9		12			64	
		1	10	13		61	68	
						59		69
23			17		56		54	
			18			55		53
	81	20	79		43	44		51
				76		41		
		29	77	36	40			49
31	32					38		48

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Yesterday's puzzle solution.

Hidato Sol. 1/30

5	6	7	8	10	11	74	72	71	70
4	3	2	1	9	12	75	73	68	69
17	16	15	14	13	76	77	78	67	66
18	19	20					79	63	65
24	23	21					80	64	62
25	26	22					82	81	61
27	29	30					83	60	59
28	31	34	33	46	45	43	84	58	57
36	35	32	47	48	42	44	51	54	56
37	38	39	40	41	49	50	52	53	55

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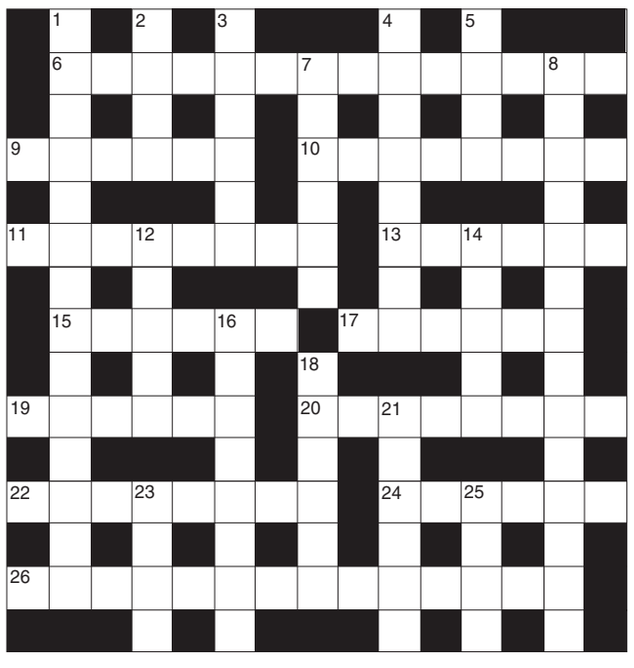
Crossword 9729



ACROSS
6 Agricultural machines by hot animal sanctuaries for marine creatures (8,6)
9 Fool seen in school is informer (6)
10 Religious members? Start to bring three nervously into service (8)
11 Last cod swimming around northern part of the UK (8)
13 Work out in detail area covered by politician in public (3,3)
15 Greek character, innocent type, facing U.S. lawyer (6)
17 Riding with sun gone and in a confused state? (6)
19 Literary composition, for instance, put among verses regularly (6)
20 Difficulty when in France on a railway (8)
22 Amateur thus by lake in Scottish island free of restrictions? (8)
24 Contrived plan with staff absent for body of work (6)
26 Typical bridge needing repair around island – it leads to loss of trust? (11,3)

DOWN
1 Actress Emma given bold score for review is far from tipsy (5-4,5)
2 Worry of retirees? Not altogether (4)
3 A quiet graduate acquiring temperature has condition (6)
4 Much admired English writer captivated by horse (8)
5 Liquid preparation kept in view as highlighted (4)
7 Represent Frenchman in European organisation (6)
8 Conceal supper we ranked in a poor state (4,5,5)
12 By the sound of it, meddle in resort in Florida (5)
14 Secretary was first made less significant (5)
16 Interrupts birds settling around street for all to see (8)
18 High-pitched cry in picturesque allotment (6)
21 A guy's first trip to get rid of no good rodent (6)
23 Likelihood party is lifted by Democratic senators, ultimately (4)
25 Impulse shown in our rugger periodically (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9728:
ACROSS: 1 Cooling tower. **8** Nonstop. **9** Prevail. **11** Housebound. **12** Miso.**14** Ice sheet. **16** Peseta. **17** Dub. **19** Entrap. **21** Targeted. **24** Ewan.**25** Folk heroes. **27** Tension. **28** Overdue. **29** Spokesperson.
DOWN: 1 Consume. **2** On the cheap. **3** Improved. **4** Gaping. **5** Oxen. **6** Examine.**7** Enshrinement. **10** Leopardesses. **13** Meagreness. **15** Tut. **18** Banknote. **20** Train up. **22** Trodden. **23** Points. **26** Pick.

©The Daily Mail

7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 Hasbro sleuthing game (4)	
2 baffled state (10)	
3 running beside each other (8)	
4 they collect stamps (9)	
5 Stadium of football Patriots (8)	
6 very basic water vessel (4)	
7 pocket-sized Apple device (6)	

UE	CL	ZL	ALL	NT
EME	EL	LLE	RA	POR
IPH	FT	PUZ	PA	TS
ONE	GI	TTE	SS	PAR

Yesterday's Answers: 1. MONEYLENDER 2. CLINGING 3. RULE 4. KENNELED 5. MORGAN 6. INSECT 7. SWAY 11/25

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Fire Hits Operations at ONGC Platform

PTI

New Delhi: A major fire broke out at state-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation's (ONGC) oil platform off the Mumbai coast, prompting the facility's shutdown, sources said.

The fire broke out at the NQG platform's Process Gas Compressor C (PGC-C) after a gas cooler finger ruptured on Monday morning and was brought under control after an hour-long firefighting effort, with no injuries reported. The fire led to the platform's shutdown. The facility processes crude oil pumped from wells below the seabed and handles over 40,000 barrels of crude oil per day. According to a senior ONGC official, the platform was shut down as a standard operating procedure (SOP) following the fire. The platform was brought back online late in the evening, and wells were being connected one after the other, the official said, adding that restoring normal operations would take a few hours.

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BRAND EQUITY
THE ECONOMIC TIMES OCTOBER 14-20, 2026

IMAGE: AI GENERATED

CoverStory
By **Anjana Naskar**

Game of Streams

From chasing viewers to focusing on profitability, India's streaming industry is entering a new phase

In the decade or so since streaming truly arrived in India, the way people watch entertainment has changed. Many binge on shows over a weekend, follow IPL on the go, and increasingly expect films to arrive on streaming soon after their theatrical run.

Hotstar, in its various guises, has been around for more than a decade. Netflix completed 10 years in India in January, while Amazon Prime Video will hit that milestone by the end of this year. India now has one of the world's largest streaming audiences.

According to Ormax Media's 2026 OTT Audience Report, India's OTT audience reached 664.9 million in 2026, up 11% from 2025 and 88% from 2021.

Yet, as the industry discovered over the past decade, getting India to watch has been far easier than getting it to pay. There are also a slew of challenges around content costs rising, attention dividing across platforms, and a shift towards advertising. The challenge now is to make India's OTT scale sustainable.

The Problem

Ormax Media estimates 172.6 million active paid OTT subscriptions in 2026, including subscriptions bought directly as well as through bundles. As consumers can hold multiple subscriptions, the number of unique paying consumers is much lower, at around 100-110 million.

Continued on Page 2 >>

INSIDE BE

PG2
How to Ride India's Anime Wave
The fandom can be a goldmine for brands. But first, they need to 'get it'

PG3
Trolling for Money
Are brands more willing than ever to use provocation, memes, irony and cultural friction to get people talking?

Data Drama

In the era of the DPDP Act, brands are looking to safeguard consumer data as vast amounts of it are shared with agency partners

By **Vidya Sathyapriyan**

Agencies are increasingly being judged not just on strategy, creativity, and effectiveness, but also on whether the agency can safely process the advertiser's data, and partially absorb the financial risk that comes with handling consumer data under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act.

The Act, which hits another milestone in November 2026 as the consent manager framework kicks off, levies a ₹250-crore penalty on data fiduciaries for each breach of personal data protection. And brands are looking to safeguard themselves as enormous amounts of data are shared with their agencies, especially those working on digital.

For brands, particularly those with large consumer databases, it is increasingly about how much consumer data the agency needs access to, how it will be handled and who bears the risk if something goes wrong.

IMAGE: AI GENERATED

Tighter Contracts

"When pitches come up for agency reviews, brands are factoring this as part of due diligence," says Attreyi Mukherjee, head legal (EV Business), Mahindra Group. The focus of any large corporate, she adds, is on whether the agency brings the right set of compliances, robust cyber security protocols, etc.

The shift is showing up as brands are drawing up tighter contracts, seeking greater oversight, and potentially much greater financial exposure for their agency partners. Security obligations, breach-reporting requirements and tougher liability provisions are also in the mix.

"We are seeing parties replace broad and conventional confidentiality clauses with a comprehensive data processing addendum (DPA), setting out each side's obligations in black and white," says Ranjana Adhikari, partner, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas.

DPDP breach-related obligations are also being carved out of conventional liability caps. That is, the financial risk is being pushed down the chain, with brands seeking uncapped liability or super-caps in multiples of the service fee for such breaches, say legal experts.

"While negotiation leans towards uncapped liability for breach of data privacy laws, it may also be a super cap, depending upon the nature of the transaction," says Mukherjee. She says the agreements are also giving brands greater oversight to check whether agencies have complied with requirements, including data deletion and anonymisation. "Brands also tend to retain audit rights. Ultimately, it's the reputation risk that concerns them."

Digital Shift

The shift is particularly relevant for digital and performance marketing agencies, which tend to handle much more personal data than traditional creative agencies. D2C brands, in particular, are increasingly reluctant to move their first-party data between agencies every few years when the account goes for a review, says the founder of an ad tech firm, requesting anonymity.

Instead, some are choosing to manage campaigns in-house or work directly with platforms' self-serve ad stacks when the use of their own customer data is required.

Agencies that *Brand Equity* reached out to declined to comment, citing the sensitive nature of the topic. But data-security capabilities are becoming a competitive differentiator for agencies in the DPDP era.

s.vidya@timesofindia.com

BEInterview **T Krishnakumar,** director, Reliance Consumer Products

Reliance Ups the Ante

From Campa to Independence, Reliance is building a sprawling FMCG portfolio. The test is turning trials into repeat purchases

By **Sonali Krishna**

There is a familiar way to tell the Reliance Consumer Products (RCPL) story. A powerful conglomerate enters a new category, prices aggressively, expands rapidly and unsettles incumbents. It is the Jio playbook, translated into FMCG.

T Krishnakumar, director, Reliance Consumer Products, is impatient with that reading.

"You cannot do a Jio here," he says. "A consumer, if he wants food and beverages, will have to taste and find it good, otherwise, every day they cannot drink or eat your product."

That is the larger argument RCPL is now making about its business. Krishnakumar states that its proposition is about global-quality products at affordable prices, targeting a market segment he believes established Indian FMCG companies have gradually vacated.

Campa is the brand that has brought RCPL's strategy into public view.

The White Space

Krishnakumar describes the Indian FMCG market as a quality-price matrix. After liberalisation, many Indian brands, he says, moved away from the affordable end of the market as multinational companies expanded and pricing rose over time.

Local and regional players have filled some of the gap, but often without matching the quality of established brands. RCPL believes the opportunity lies in offering both.

The company is still building the machinery required to deliver that proposition. Krishnakumar says RCPL is only 20-30% of the way into its journey towards a fully integrated value chain, from raw materials to distribution and the outlet.

Its early model relied on third-party manufacturing, with RCPL controlling formulations, raw materials and vendor production. It is now investing in its own supply chain, procurement and manufacturing capabilities.

The company also set up an R&D facility in Bengaluru before the business had reached significant scale.

The Portfolio Strategy

RCPL's first visible marker of scale is its portfolio of large brands. Krishnakumar says four brands have already crossed ₹1,000 crore in revenue. These include Campa, the Campa energy platform, Independence and Good Life.

A personal-care brand, Glimmer, is expected to be the next to cross the threshold.

By the middle of next year, RCPL expects to have seven to eight brands, including the newly launched ice-cream business and Udhaiyam, a lentils brand, joining the list.

Ice cream, in particular, is being treated as an open opportunity. "There is no national brand at this point of time in ice cream," says Krishnakumar.

Continued on Page 2 >>

THE BRAND EQUITY SHOW
by The Economic Times

The Brand Equity Show sits down with the movers and shakers driving Indian advertising and marketing to decode what truly powers them and their brands. In the third episode of the podcast, host Sonali Krishna talks to Gaurav Gandhi, Vice President, APAC and ANZ, Prime Video, and Nikhil Madhok, Director and Head of SVOD Originals. It is a conversation that goes beyond subscriptions and advertising. With Prime Video now backing theatrical releases, what does cinema give the streaming business that a direct-to-platform release cannot?
How much can data tell you about whether a story deserves to be made?

When Pepsi Veteran Takes Parle's Reins

Parle has appointed its first-ever CEO. Can **George Kovoor** reshape the company to take on new challenges?

By **Anjana Naskar**

For decades, the G in Parle-G has stood for 'genius'. Now there is another G in the Parle story. George Kovoor, a former PepsiCo executive, took charge early in September as the company's first-ever CEO.

For a company that has been promoter-led for nearly a century, the appointment marks a significant shift in how Parle could be run, and where it could go next.

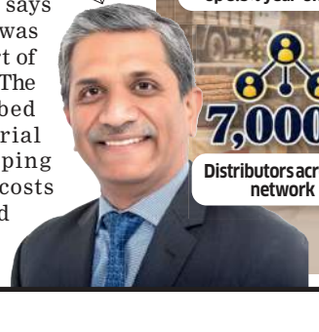
From Parle-G and Monaco to KrackJack, Hide & Seek and Melody, its brands have become part of everyday India. Now, with the market changing, profitability under pressure, and reports of a possible IPO, the question is whether Parle's old strengths will be enough to drive its next phase of growth.

The Old Parle Playbook

Parle has always been known for its familiar brands, mass distribution and sharp value. But the market has changed, with local brands competing at the value end, while premium biscuits and cookies gaining ground at the other end.

"There is a proliferation of brands at both ends of the market. At the lower end, local brands can offer better margins to dealers, while at the upper end, Parle has not had much of a play," says Bobby Pawar, advertising veteran. "The question is whether the old game plan still works."

Ambi Parameswaran, brand strategist, says Parle's frugality was an important part of its business model. The company absorbed rising raw-material costs while keeping manufacturing costs low. "They operated with very low margins. Their office was not even air-conditioned for many years," he says. These days, however, the company has moved away from this extreme frugality, with a greater focus on higher-margin cookies and cream biscuits.



Time To Reinvent

There is a popular lore around KrackJack: When sweet and salty doughs came together by accident, the combination worked, and Parle ran with it.

That willingness to experiment is what Pawar believes Parle needs to rediscover. "What made Parle, Parle, was innovation," he says. From KrackJack's sweet-and-salty proposition to Hide & Seek's chocolate-chip positioning, innovation once gave consumers new reasons to buy.

He believes Parle needs to give consumers more reasons to choose its brands beyond familiarity and price.

Krishnarao Buddha, former Parle senior category head, believes Parle can leverage its distribution strength to drive growth across markets. "Rural India offers significant headroom for deeper penetration and consumption growth, while urban markets call for a sharper focus on premiumisation, convenience and new consumption occasions," he says.

Harish Bijoor, brand strategist, sees reinvention as extending beyond communication to the products themselves. "The biggest challenge is to keep the brand relevant, original and innovative for the new generation, while continuing to build its deep-rooted distribution network," he says.

With consumers becoming more conscious of sugar, maida and traditional formulations, he believes Parle will need to rethink parts of its product portfolio.

Pawar believes Parle could have capitalised on moments like when Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifted the Melody candy to Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni in May. He reckons they could have launched an Italian-inspired limited-edition flavour.

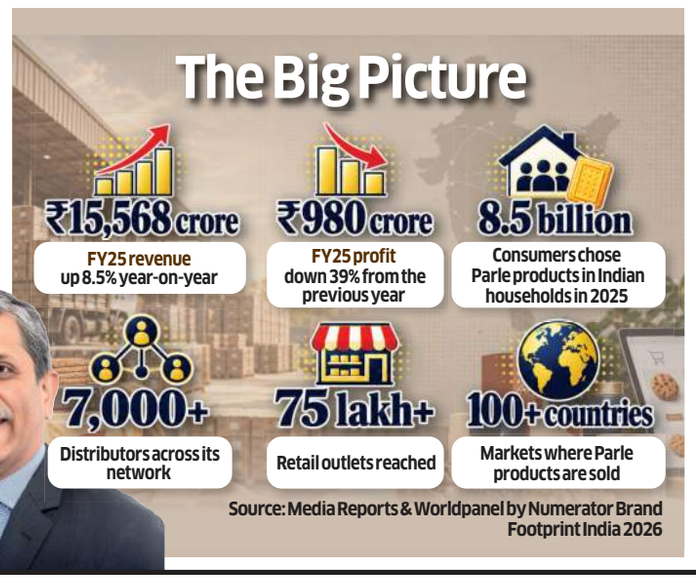
Kovoor's Challenges

According to Pawar, Kovoor could bring other senior professionals into Parle, strengthening the leadership bench around him.

Kovoor spent more than three decades at PepsiCo, working across India, China, Asia-Pacific and the US, and was most recently senior vice-president and general manager, India beverages. His experience could help Parle sharpen its approach to innovation, distribution and new growth opportunities.

Bijoor sees distribution as another key area. Parle's physical network remains a major strength, but D2C, e-commerce and newer retail formats require the company to build more muscle.

anjana.naskar@timesofindia.com



THE BRAND EQUITY SHOW
by THE ECONOMIC TIMES

PRIME VIDEO: MORE THAN STREAMING. BUT WHAT'S THE BUSINESS MODEL?

A decade after Prime Video launched in India, it is building an entertainment business that extends from streaming into advertising and theatrical films, while bringing free and paid viewing under one roof.

While the ambition is clear, the business model is more complicated. Can Prime Video expand its reach without diluting the value of a paid subscription? Why should members pay extra to go ad-free? And what does a streaming platform gain by taking its own productions to cinemas?

In the third episode of **The Brand Equity Show, Sonali Krishna** puts these questions to **Gaurav Gandhi**, vice-president, APAC and ANZ, Prime Video, and **Nikhil Madhok**, director and head of SVOD Originals.

Gandhi makes the case for giving customers more choice. Bringing Prime Video and MX Player together, he says, creates a unified experience for both audiences and advertisers. On the question of advertising, he argues that customers can choose whether to watch with ads or pay for an ad-free experience. His assessment of the membership proposition is unequivocal. "Prime at ₹1,499 is the best value in the country."

"Picking stories has to be something that comes from your gut."

But the conversation goes beyond subscriptions and advertising. With Prime Video now backing theatrical releases, what does cinema give the streaming business that a direct-to-platform release cannot?

For Gandhi, it is also about reaching new audiences. A theatrical release, he argues, can bring people to a franchise who may not already be watching it on Prime Video. The strategy, he insists, is an "and for us and not or"; cinemas and streaming can serve different needs.

For Madhok, the challenge is to keep the content pipeline fresh while building on successful franchises. He says 60% of its original shows and movies have been made into sequels. But how do you balance returning favourites with new ideas? And how much can data tell you about whether a story deserves to be made?

His answer offers a glimpse into the commissioning process. "Picking stories has to be something that comes from your gut."

The conversation also gets into what Prime Video will not disclose – its unduplicated monthly audience for the unified service, the number of subscribers paying extra to go ad-free, and the profitability of the India business. One answer from Madhok points to the next ambition. "We haven't told superhero stories of Indian superheroes." Prime Video is now attempting to do so with *Vansh: The Immortals*.

Ten years in, Prime Video is no longer simply competing to be another streaming service. It is trying to connect content, audiences and revenue across a much wider entertainment ecosystem. Whether that breadth becomes its biggest advantage remains to be seen.

BE/DOPE **Rohit Jagasia,** *CEO, Revenant Xspark*

How to Ride India's Anime Wave

India's anime fandom can be a goldmine for brands. But first, they need to 'get it'

For years in India, anime was confined to niche message boards and passionate subcultures. Today, it has exploded into a mainstream cultural powerhouse driving Gen Z and younger millennials.

From packed theatrical releases to booming regional-language streaming viewership, anime is no longer just background entertainment, it has become a core facet of youth identity and self-expression.

Brands looking to reach those audiences through anime need to understand the nuances of the culture behind the characters.

The Indian Anime Consumer

This demographic is digital-first, fiercely loyal, and culturally engaged. Their fandom overlaps seamlessly with streetwear, sneaker culture, comics, and creator communities. Crucially, they are eager to invest in limited-edition apparel, premium experiences, and authentic collectibles.

However, this audience has an acute radar for superficial marketing. Merely slapping an anime character onto packaging often falls flat; fandoms demand respect for lore, narrative arcs, and character depth.

Brands must approach anime culture-first and marketing-second, treating characters as symbols of personal identity rather than disposable graphics.

The Gaming-Anime Overlap

One of the most organic gateways to India's anime audience is gaming. Both ecosystems share identical creative DNA: Epic storytelling, high-stakes competition, vibrant fantasy worlds, and deeply engaged communities.

Globally, the boundaries between anime, gaming, and manga have blurred. In India, this crossover is personal and visible every single day. Competitive gamers and grassroots players routinely borrow their in-game aliases, gamer tags, and personal branding from iconic anime figures like Levi, Pain, or Sukuna.

When an entire generation of players chooses to identify themselves through anime characters, the synergy is no longer theoretical; it is an active subculture that bridges both worlds.

Gaming serves as the natural cultural canvas for anime fandom, giving consumer brands an authentic, high-impact touchpoint to engage young audiences rather than just advertising around them.

The Brand Playbook

For consumer brands looking to navigate India's anime boom, the roadmap is clear:

1. Respect the lore: Align campaigns with character values that reflect your brand ethos.

2. Prioritise limited drops: Lean into exclusive drops and collectibles that offer genuine cultural currency.

3. Partner with native communities: Collaborate with gaming organisations and creators who already hold authentic trust within the community.

Anime in India is not a temporary trend. It is a permanent cultural shift. Brands that enter this space with authenticity and respect will unlock one of the most dedicated consumer bases in modern marketing.

(Views Personal)

In BE Dope, experts unpack big questions shaping the creator economy.

Continued from Page 1 >>

Reliance Ups the Ante

The portfolio is now structured around umbrella brands instead of individual masterbrands for each category. Independence will drive a variety of everyday essentials. Udhaiyam, originally starting with lentils, is expanding to include other staples. Campa covers sparkling beverages, energy drinks, juices, and water.

The logic is to stretch brand investment across categories while RCPL is still building scale. "If I advertise Campa in whichever form, it straddles all the Campa products in some way," says Krishnakumar.

This architecture may not remain permanent. Once a brand crosses a certain scale, it may require sharper category identities. "When I get to critical mass, like a brand crosses ₹10,000–₹12,000 crore, then I have to think of whether I should really start splitting it."

The Next Gen

Campa is the brand that has brought RCPL's strategy into public view. The brand's growth has been attributed to nostalgia, availability and pricing. Krishnakumar believes nostalgia is only a bridge to trial.

"Our positioning is about determination, and that is the archetype we are going for, which is Gen Z," says Krishnakumar.

RCPL says its beverages portfolio has reached double-digit market share in three or four states and high single-digit share in another three or four. Nationally, Krishnakumar places it at a high single-digit share despite its limited presence.

The next phase will take it deeper into central India, Maharashtra and the south.

Distribution and Demand

RCPL is now close to three million outlets, according to Krishnakumar, and plans to reach five to six million through direct distribution within two years.

The company measures three levels of distribution: availability, visible availability and what it calls "executed availability". Executed availability means the product is displayed with signage, clear messaging, and promotional support like coolers, branded signs, product info, and calls to action.

"In the states we first launched, we now have reached at least one-third of the outlets with this executed availability," he says. Of the three million outlets, 800,000 to one million have reached that stage, by his estimate.

Once a brand crosses a certain scale, it may require sharper category identities.

The next task is to take executed availability to three million outlets. Reliance Retail's own ecosystem currently contributes about 10% of RCPL's business through stores, while its B2B distribution system contributes around 15-16%. The majority comes through external outlets and general trade.

That is critical to the company's credibility as an FMCG player. According to Krishnakumar, RCPL is not merely placing private labels in Reliance stores. It is trying to win in the fragmented trade.

The Kirana Play

RCPL's strategy is built on three pillars: acquisitions, organic brands, and what Krishnakumar describes as a plug-and-play infrastructure.

The acquisition approach targets older, more affordable brands that already have recognition. "I bought SIL for some ₹5-6 crore, and somebody else bought a brand or a company for some ₹900 crore," he says. "That is the difference."

But RCPL is not automatically taking every acquired brand national. Brands must first prove themselves regionally through penetration, market share and repeat purchase.

Journey to a Brand

The hardest part of the strategy is also the least visible. RCPL has to convert trial into habit.

The company has deliberately focused on smaller packs, allowing consumers to test products before moving to larger formats. The goal is to earn repeat purchase, then ritual. "It will take me three to four years to make my brand their ritual," he says.

For now, he describes many of RCPL's products as "products with a name". The next stage is for those products to become brands.

sonali.krishna@timesofindia.com

Continued from Page 1 >>

Game of Streams

Most of the industry responded by opening up more revenue streams, while the likes of Netflix adapted its pricing strategy.

"Most major platforms are now hybrid, combining subscriptions with advertising," says **Keerat Grewal,** head, business development, streaming, TV and brands, Ormax Media. "India's paying audience is still only around 100-110 million. Premium content comes with high costs, so platforms need multiple revenue streams."

That shift has made advertising central to the Indian OTT business, while pure subscription has become harder to scale. Other models like TVOD (Transactional Video on Demand) have not really taken off in India. "Platforms have tried putting popular films behind a paywall, but it is not a volume business," Grewal says.

The Sports Conundrum

The economics get tougher when platforms compete for premium content, with sports providing the clearest example. JioStar vice-chairman Uday Shankar has warned that cricket rights prices have "run out of control", raising questions about whether revenues can keep pace with acquisition.

Raj Nayak, managing director, House of Cheer Networks, says, "The pull of live sport is strong because people want to watch it as it happens. But sustainability depends on the price you pay. You cannot keep bidding on the assumption that revenues will somehow catch up."

The real question, he says, is what happens after the tournament. "Do viewers stay and renew?"

ZEE5's FIFA World Cup experience shows why that matters. The platform acquired India digital rights shortly before the tournament and reported around six million viewers over the opening weekend.

During the tournament, watch time rose 79%, while daily installs and new subscriptions increased 55%. ZEE5 said many FIFA subscribers also explored movies and original series, suggesting that sports can be used to pull viewers into the wider library. The big question, however, is whether they stay after the tournament.

Tejkarran Singh Bajaj, business head, ZEE5 India and AI and innovation, says, "The first decade of streaming in India was about giving audiences greater access and control over what they watched. The next phase is about earning a lasting place in their lives."

Consolidation Time

The first decade of OTT was defined by platform proliferation. The next may be defined by consolidation.

JioHotstar brought JioCinema and Disney+ Hotstar together, while Amazon integrated Amazon MX Player into Prime Video. Warner Bros Discovery is moving away from a standalone discovery+ app in India, with its content continuing through distribution partners.

For platforms, bundling can lower customer-acquisition costs and open access to large user bases through telcos, DTH operators, smart TVs and aggregators. **Aditya Pittie,** managing director, The EPIC Company, says, "Bundling and B2B distribution are now non-negotiable for discovery and scale."

The correction is also playing out in content spending. "Parts of the industry overspent chasing vanity metrics and immediate scale. The solution isn't spending less on content but spending smarter – right-sizing production budgets, building evergreen libraries and exploring multi-window licensing," Pittie says.

Then there is advertising. According to the *ET Brand Equity*–Ipsos State of Digital Advertising in India 2025-26 report, OTT accounted for 5% of India's total advertising spends, while digital advertising grew 20% in FY2025.

But advertising alone cannot solve the economics.

Platforms have to balance subscription, advertising and retention revenues. **Pep Figueiredo,** former SonyLIV executive, says, "OTT cannot be treated simply as a distribution vehicle. Stronger platforms are combining content with technology, data, advertising and other consumer ecosystems."

The next decade may be defined by consolidation.

"Content costs can also outpace subscription growth, while expensive sports rights need advertising, sponsorship and subscriber retention to justify the investment," Figueiredo adds.

The New Battle for Attention

The next challenge is keeping viewers engaged. **Mautik Tolia,** managing director, Bodhi Tree Multimedia, says, "We are seeing more selectivity around what gets commissioned, how budgets are structured and where investment creates the most value. The industry is moving away from maximising content volume towards fewer, more considered investments, with more structured deals and greater alignment between platforms and producers."

Regional content and connected TV could open up the next leg of growth, particularly beyond the metros. Much regional viewing still happens on YouTube, even as JioHotstar, ZEE5 and SonyLIV have built sizeable regional libraries.

The connected-TV opportunity is also expanding. Ormax puts India's CTV audience at 206.9 million in 2026, up 60% from 129.2 million a year earlier, with smaller towns contributing significantly to the growth.

But more screens also mean more competition for attention. Tolia says, "What has become harder is capturing attention."

Micro-drama audiences have reached around 110 million, up from 73 million last year, according to Ormax Media.

The format is another sign of how the battle for attention is shifting. Yet Grewal believes the format competes more with social media than long-form OTT, since much of the viewing happens on platforms such as Facebook and Instagram.

The challenge, Figueiredo argues, is now shifting from access to value. "The industry has solved access and abundance remarkably well, but its next evolution will be about turning attention into sustainable value," he says.

anjana.naskar@timesofindia.com

Trolling for Money

Are brands more willing than ever to use provocation, memes, irony and cultural friction to get people talking?

By **Pratishtha Bagai**

A few weeks back, Sydney Sweeney's latest brand campaign put Novig, a relatively young sports prediction platform, at the centre of a controversy that travelled far beyond advertising circles.

The 58-second 'Novig is Just Sports' ad shows Sweeney with little clothing, using footballs, basketballs and other sports equipment to cover her body while pitching the platform.

The campaign has drawn criticism from women athletes and feminists across the world for its sexualisation of women in sport and for reducing them to their bodies at a time when female athletes are fighting to be recognised for their performance.

Yet the backlash has also delivered something every marketer wants: Attention. The ad posted on September 9 has garnered more than 67.2 million views on Instagram in the past three weeks.

That tension is increasingly visible in marketing. Brands are not necessarily embracing controversy for its own sake, but they are becoming more willing to use provocation, memes, irony and cultural friction to get people talking.

The question is no longer only whether an ad will be liked. It is whether it will be noticed, remembered and carried into the wider internet conversation.

Attention-first

Is this advertising's version of a pushback on liberalism, which has already been seen around the world in politics? "I wouldn't call it 'anti-woke'," said Sree Chandran, vice-president, Creativefuel, a marketing agency under WLDD that owns multiple meme pages with a follower base of over 200 million. "I think the larger trend is really anti-corporate communication."

Younger audiences, Chandran says, warm to brands that feel unexpected, self-aware and funny. The shift is "from purpose-first to attention-first":

The old question was what a brand wants to say, and the new one is how to make people stop scrolling long enough to hear it.

"Brands are not suddenly comfortable with every kind of controversy. What has changed is their ability to spot cultural attention early and convert it into communication," said Rohit Goyal, chief executive officer of Taggify, another marketing agency.

The appetite for risk varies sharply by category, Goyal says. Fashion, beauty, entertainment, food delivery and consumer tech can take more cultural risk, while banking, healthcare and education have much less room for error.

The question isn't whether an ad will be liked, but whether it will be noticed and carried into the wider internet conversation.

Ambassadors of Attention

Sweeney has become an icon of sorts for such controversial campaigns. The debate over brands deliberately creating controversy to capture attention also featured her last year, when American Eagle built its Fourth of July campaign in the US around the line 'Sydney Sweeney has great jeans'.

The campaign drew criticism over the brand's perceived fixation on conventional beauty standards aka race, and the lack of diversity in its portrayal of women, but also generated significant chatter around the campaign.

Meanwhile in India, there is another way in which attention is being monetised by none other than actor and Member of Parliament Ravi Kishan, especially after one-liners clipped from his podcast with Raj Shamani went viral. But instead of worrying about the trolling, he monetised it through ad campaigns and a music video.

The most recognisable line he said on the podcast, "Money follows my brother," quickly moved from a viral moment to a piece of internet shorthand, giving brands a ready-made cultural reference to tap into. Several brands, including boAt, Blinkit, Swiggy Dineout, Amazon and Renee, hopped on to it.

Swiggy Dineout spun its flagship Great Indian Restaurant Festival into the 'Great Indian Ravi Festival', building the campaign around Kishan's viral persona. "We could have done a quick topical post and moved on, as brands often do, but we didn't want to just ride the wave," said Dhruvish Thakkar, AVP marketing and revenue, Dineout.

Balancing Act

But often, for the person at the centre of a joke, the maths is different. Darshan Magdum, a music creator from Kolhapur, says he began by covering musicians and their songs because he loved the music, and never meant to become a meme. People first saw his posts as a joke, he says, but over time they began to enjoy him for who he was and wait for his next video.

Brands came next. Magdum says he turned down collaborations that did not feel authentic to him, because he wanted his audience to keep seeing the same person.

"Virality gets you attention, and what you do with it is up to you. Filling my page with paid posts would have cost me followers and brought hate comments. Brands get visibility out of controversy, while the creator absorbs the hate," Magdum said.

Chandran's advice to creators fits in a line: "Monetise the joke, but don't let the joke become the business."

pratishtha.bagai
@timesofindia.com

IMAGE: AI-GENERATED

*News*Tracker

Stellantis Bets on Small Affordable EVs for European Comeback

Stellantis headed into the Paris Motor Show with a message it hopes customers, investors and dealers are ready to hear: after years of sliding market share and weak sales in Europe, the automaker is back in the fight.

At a recent gala event ahead of the show's opening, CEO Antonio Filosa unveiled six of the nine concept cars Stellantis is bringing to Paris alongside a range of production models, including affordable EVs set to compete with low-cost Chinese rivals.

The centrepiece is Citroen's revival of the iconic 2CV, a retro-styled concept previewing a European-made low-cost EV expected in 2028 and the first example of the group's plans for Europe's new 'e-car' category.

International premieres will include the DS7, Fiat Grizzly, Lancia Gamma, Opel Corsa GSE and the B03 and D19 models of Stellantis' Chinese partner Leapmotor.

"This event brings our... 2030 strategy to life," Filosa said. "It reflects the extraordinary effort of our teams and our commitment to shaping the future of mobility through iconic brands, compelling design and innovative technology."

The presentations showcase the carmaker's bid to give brands more distinct identities as the industry's increasing reliance on shared platforms and technologies leads to broad design uniformity.

"Each concept explores new ways to ... reinforce the unique identity of its brand," Stellantis design chief Gilles Vidal said.

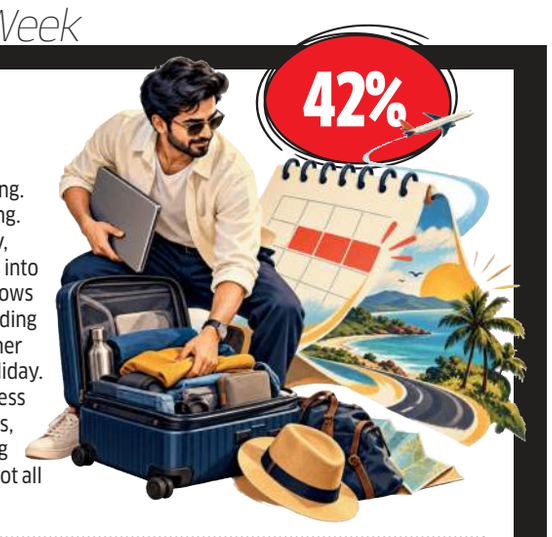
The 2CV is probably Stellantis's "most interesting launch", said Pedro Pacheco, vice-president of research at Gartner, offering an early test of whether European automakers can build affordable EVs without sacrificing quality, performance or safety.

"It will be the first example of what an e-car is going to be," Pacheco said.

With a price tag of around 15,000 euros ($16,800), e-cars are a new category of low-cost EVs aimed at reviving Europe's shrinking entry-level car market.

– Reuters

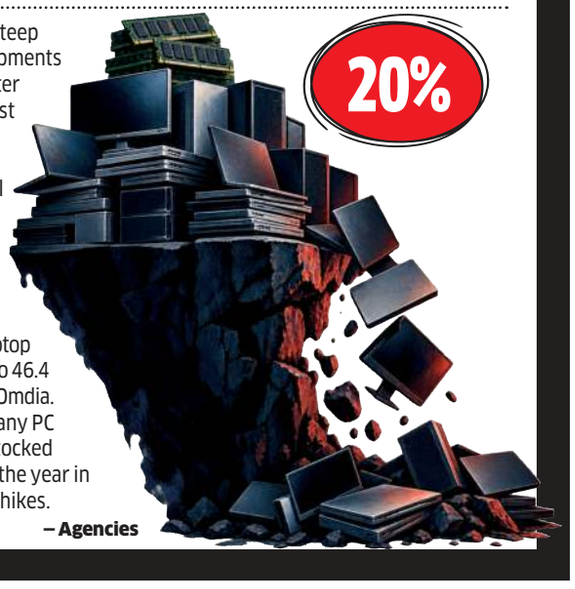
Numbers of the Week



The percentage of Indian travellers who say that just seeing a long weekend on the horizon is enough to start packing. According to a survey by Booking.com in partnership with YouGov, 64% are turning calendar quirks into a spontaneous getaway. This shows that Indians are increasingly finding reasons to travel everyday, rather than waiting for the next big holiday. In fact, while 36% admit that stress at work lead them to plan breaks, 16% revealed that they turn long weekends into workcation. So not all play; some work as well!

The average number of times that Indian consumers consult chatbots to help with festival spends. In fact, nine out of 10 of those consumers extensively research before they buy something, according to data from a Google-commissioned Ipsos study.

That's not all – impulse buying during the season is intense; 70% buy spontaneously, sparked by visual discovery and 54% of these unplanned purchases were influenced by Google and YouTube. Predictable point? AI is becoming an essential festive shopping companion for curious consumers.

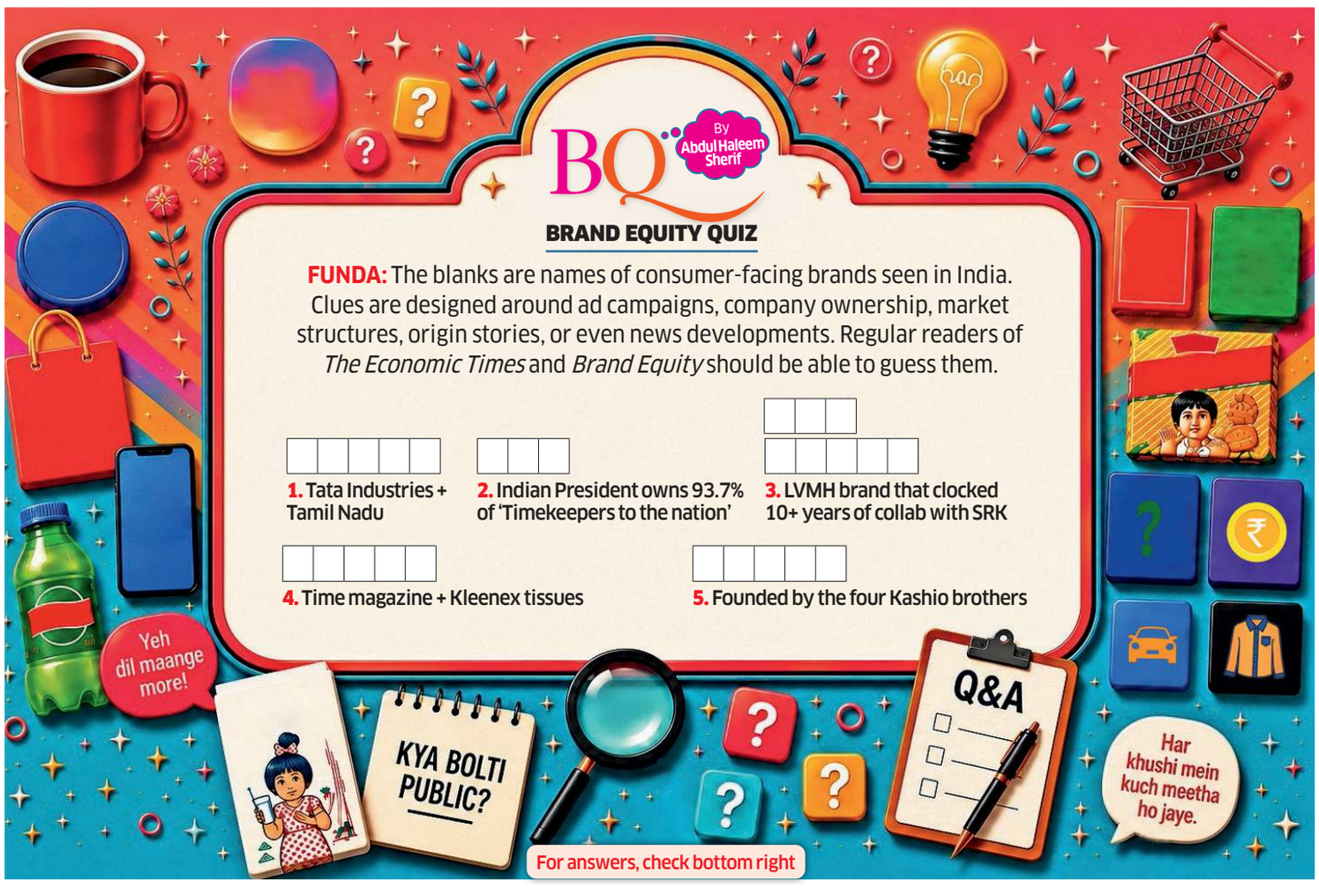


Analysts have reported a steep drop in Q3 2026 in PC shipments worldwide – or, as the computer industry called it, the "sharpest decline since Q1 2023".

Global shipments of laptops, desktops, and workstations fell 21.2% year-over-year to 58.1 million devices. Desktop PC shipments (including desktop workstations) decreased 23.5% to 11.7 million units, and laptop shipments (including laptop workstations) declined 20.6% to 46.4 million, as per research leader Omdia.

Analyst firm IDC said that many PC vendors and sales channels stocked up on PC shipments earlier in the year in anticipation of memory price hikes.

– Agencies



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